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Culture mechanics

culture mechanics *noun*
Status: proposed theoretical term
Field: moral psychology (psychology of morality), social psychology, cultural psychology, organizational psychology, organization studies, sociology of morality, sociology of culture, cultural theory, distributed cognition

Short definition

Culture mechanics is a proposed framework for explaining how culture is installed in people, activated in particular situations, synchronized across groups, reproduced through institutions, and deliberately or accidentally changed. It describes the human being as **homo duplex**, a creature with two functionally distinct processing units. The first is a powerful, general-purpose processor: the brain’s main CPU. The second is a simpler social and affective processor called the **bigOther**. The bigOther does not reason in detail. It classifies thoughts, persons, actions, and situations by attaching culturally learned sentiments to them: honour or shame, loyalty or betrayal, sacredness or pollution, legitimacy or illegitimacy, belonging or exclusion.

Although the bigOther is comparatively primitive, it is connected at a decisive point. By changing how a person *feels* about what the main processor is thinking, it can redirect attention, motivation, judgment, and action before conscious reasoning notices what has happened. It is programmed slowly with a **mythological lens** and activated quickly by social signals. In terminology adapted from Systems Leadership, a **mythology** is one socially evaluated narrative or story. Many mythologies, reinforced by symbols, rituals, institutional practices, rewards, punishments, and exemplary behaviour, shape the lens through which the bigOther maps real-world observations and events onto culturally learned values and feelings.

The **single-slot principle** proposes one local bigOther executing one operative mythological lens. That lens may braid several compatible cultural packages into a complex program; it is not a hierarchy of parallel bigOthers. An incompatible governing worldview must be rejected, or the incumbent weave must be unbraided sufficiently for one successor to be rebraided and installed.

Stable installation means **complete slot occupancy** or, in a neutral architectural sense, **full capture**. A first-order program and a lifted second-order meta-program can each fully occupy the one slot. A lifted program does not govern less. The order-level distinction concerns what is shared: first-order mechanical solidarity shares concrete rules and answers; lifted mechanical solidarity shares the rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers. Plural lives and bounded subordinate jurisdictions can follow from that architecture, but do not define it. Whether either form of full capture is open and corrigible or closed and pathological is a separate question.

The bigOther also has a special capacity: it can couple with the bigOthers of other people. It encodes its classifications in words, stories, gestures, roles, titles, symbols, and sanctions that are intelligible within a shared symbolic order. Reciprocal signalling can synchronize many locally programmed individuals into an emergent social field and, under sufficiently integrated conditions, a distributed **multi-mind-self**. Culture is the relatively stable evaluative programming and social coordination produced and reproduced through this loop.

Some ideological symbols are **conformity signals**: their performance, absence, or refusal makes a person’s relation to the installed program publicly legible. Such signals can turn private classification into monitoring, apparent consensus, recruitment, moralized exclusion, institutional coercion, or collective action. A conformity signal can also become a **targeting signal** when nonperformance exposes a sanctionable outsider; imposed marks and attributed labels can make the same target classification legible without requiring refusal.

In one sentence:

Culture mechanics is the study of how mythologies shape the mythological lens, how the bigOther uses that lens to give social feeling to observations and thoughts, and how networked bigOthers turn those feelings into collective order and action.

Long definition

1. General meaning

Culture mechanics is an explanatory model of culture as a **distributed system of sentiment classification, social coordination, and symbolic reality-construction**.

The term *mechanics* expresses a specific ambition. Culture mechanics does not stop at naming or classifying phenomena such as conformity, indoctrination, collective effervescence, moral commitment, ideology, group identity, or crowd behaviour. It asks how these phenomena are produced:

- What are the functional components?
- What information or programming does each component contain?
- How is that programming learned?
- Which signals activate it?
- How does it influence thought and action?
- How are separate people coordinated or synchronized?
- How is the resulting culture stabilized by rituals and institutions?
- Under what conditions can it be inspected, resisted, or reprogrammed?

Culture mechanics therefore treats culture not merely as a collection of customs or beliefs, but as an operative system with inputs, internal state, evaluative rules, affective outputs, communication channels, feedback loops, and institutional memory. This entry begins with the individual source and coupling interface. The emergent field and its back-action upon epistemic judgment are developed in [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#).

2. Homo duplex: the dual-processing human

The model calls the human being **homo duplex** because human conduct results from the interaction of two functionally different processing units.

This is a deliberate extension of Émile Durkheim's term rather than a claim that Durkheim described precisely this architecture. In culture mechanics, the duality is between:

1. a powerful general-purpose processor; and
2. a simpler, culturally programmable sentiment-classification processor.

The two units are connected but not reducible to one another within this theory. This is a constitutive functional commitment, not a claim that two anatomical organs have been discovered. The bigOther must therefore not be silently redescribed as merely System 1, a generic heuristic, the superego, internalized norms, or an output of ordinary cognition. Those concepts may illuminate aspects of its operation, but none replaces the proposed second component without revising the theory itself.

A person's intelligence, knowledge, or technical competence does not by itself reveal how the person's bigOther is programmed. The main CPU may remain intelligent, computationally powerful, and capable of elementary verification while the bigOther changes which conclusions feel admissible, honourable, shameful, safe, or unthinkable. Conversely, a person's cultural programming does not determine the full extent of the person's intellectual capacities.

This relative independence explains why a highly intelligent person may be strongly governed by ideological or religious classifications, while a person of ordinary intelligence may preserve considerable moral and epistemic independence. The main processor determines much of what a person *can* think; the bigOther strongly influences which thoughts feel admirable, shameful, safe, dangerous, permissible, or unthinkable.

3. First processing unit: the main CPU

The **main CPU** is the brain's powerful, flexible, general-purpose processing capacity. Its functions include:

- perception and memory;
- language and explicit thought;
- comparison and inference;

- imagination and counterfactual reasoning;
- planning and problem-solving;
- conscious deliberation;
- personal judgment;
- construction of explanations.

Most ordinary conceptions of intelligence focus on this processor. It can learn complex theories, solve technical problems, interpret evidence, and devise sophisticated strategies.

The main CPU does not, however, choose its direction in a cultural vacuum. Attention, motivation, felt relevance, moral urgency, and the acceptability of possible conclusions are influenced by the second processor.

4. Second processing unit: the bigOther

The **bigOther** is the comparatively primitive but strategically placed sentiment-classification processor. Culture mechanics distinguishes its functional operation, its phenomenological appearance, and the shared symbolic interface through which it couples with other local bigOthers.

Functional aspect The local bigOther executes the installed mythological lens. It does not usually produce a detailed argument. It assigns social and moral valence to observations, thoughts, persons, sources, roles, actions, symbols, and events:

observation, thought, person, source, role, action, symbol, or event

↓

MYTHOLOGICAL LENS

learned value-and-feeling mappings

↓

BIGOTHER

fast sentiment classification

↓

honour / shame

loyalty / betrayal

sacred / profane

clean / polluted

legitimate / illicit

safe / threatening

admirable / contemptible

belonging / exclusion

This mapping function corresponds to what **Systems Leadership** calls the **mythological lens**. Culture mechanics treats the lens as the installed evaluative program and the local bigOther as the comparatively simple processor that executes it. Its output can take the form of pride, guilt, shame, disgust, trust, fear, admiration, moral elevation, indignation, belonging, or anticipated exclusion. These outputs alter which thoughts receive attention, which possibilities are emotionally tolerable, and which actions feel obligatory.

Phenomenological aspect The source of a classification need not be experienced as “my learned social programming.” It may be encountered as an actually present Other—God, Destiny, Nation, History, the People, or the Cause—that sees, judges, addresses, commands, and can receive loyalty, service, protection, or sacrifice. Culture mechanics calls the felt objectivity of this encounter **bigOther-presence** and its second-person relational form **bigOther-as-Thou**.

When the installed program is jealous, this presence may itself be felt directly as jealous: as a *Thou* that claims the person, watches for disloyalty, refuses divided allegiance, and demands fidelity against rivals. The person need not experience this as “my program classified an alternative attachment as betrayal.” It can be lived as “the Other is jealous and requires my loyalty.”

[William James's *The Varieties of Religious Experience* \(1902\)](#) supplies an important phenomenological antecedent: persons can experience an unseen order or objective presence as more authoritative and conduct-directing than an explicit proposition. [Martin Buber's *I and Thou* \(1923\)](#) supplies the relational grammar of encountering another as a *Thou* rather than an object or *It*. Neither thinker proposed the culture-mechanical processor or its distributed field. Buber's eternal *Thou* in particular must not be reduced to a socially programmed classifier. The present terms borrow aspects of their phenomenology while assigning them a different functional explanation.

This account also leaves the metaphysical status of a reported presence open. Its claim is narrower: whatever else the presence may be, the person's local bigOther can mediate how it becomes socially classified and conduct-directing.

Shared symbolic protocol The spelling **bigOther** marks a deliberate adaptation of [Jacques Lacan's *big Other*](#), the locus of language, law, roles, conventions, authority, and socially intelligible meaning. Culture mechanics does not identify Lacan's symbolic order with a processor inside the individual. It treats that shared order, in one functional translation, as the **on-the-wire protocol** through which local bigOthers become mutually legible:

```
state of A's local bigOther
    ↓ encoded as
words, stories, gestures, roles, titles, symbols, sanctions
    ↓ transmitted through
shared symbolic order / Lacanian big Other
    ↓ interpreted through
B's installed mythological lens
    ↓
B's sentiment classification and outward response
```

An alphabet is not a message, and Unicode or ASCII is not the state of the computer using it. They provide shared encodings through which different machines can exchange intelligible signals. Likewise, a letter such as *M* can denote a complete mathematical mapping, while *E* or *B* can denote an entire field. Flags, uniforms, titles, and words such as *betrayal* or *justice* can function as similarly compressed social tokens because participants have learned how to unpack them.

The protocol transmits public signals, not perfect copies of private states. Synchronization requires sufficiently compatible lenses and contexts; it does not require identical inner contents. A signal can therefore activate convergence, misunderstanding, indifference, or opposition.

The bigOther's power comes less from computational sophistication than from its **position in the control architecture**. It influences how a person feels about the main CPU's thoughts. The main CPU may subsequently use its much greater power to explain, implement, defend, or occasionally question the direction supplied by the bigOther.

5. The single-slot principle

Culture mechanics proposes that the bigOther occupies the equivalent of a computer's **single PCI slot**. There is one slot, one installed local bigOther, and one operative mythological lens at a time. The bigOther is the processor or card; the mythological lens is the executable evaluative program it runs.

A stable program produces **complete slot occupancy**. This document also calls that architectural condition **full capture**. Here *full* means that one operative weave governs the slot, not that the weave is false, totalitarian, or uncorrectable. A **first-order full capture** shares binding concrete rules and answers. A **lifted full capture** shares binding rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers:

fixed meta-rules *M* + current knowledge or inputs *K_t* + situation *C* → binding first-order output *R_t(C)*

Here *fixed* means installed and binding at a given time, not eternal. Generator and outputs belong to the same operative weave. Both architectures occupy the slot completely; lifting changes the order at which binding sameness is located rather than producing an empty or half-programmed slot.

Four axes must therefore remain distinct: **slot occupancy** (full), **order level** (shared outputs or shared generator), **jurisdiction** (what the installed rules govern), and **corrigibility** (open or closed). A lifted meta-order can have universal jurisdiction at its own level over the creation, allocation, limitation, coordination, succession, and correction of first-order outputs and jurisdictions. Persons, offices, professions, institutions, communities, and contracting parties may remain plural and domain-limited beneath it. That pluralism is an important possible result of lifting, not its definition.

This **single-slot exclusivity** does not imply that the installed program is simple, culturally pure, or derived from only one source. A person may belong to several groups and encounter many religions, professions, political doctrines, familial obligations, and moral traditions. Compatible material can be assembled like software packages or libraries and braided into one operative lens. The slot restricts the number of independently operative evaluators, not the complexity or modularity of the installed weave.

Compatible packages are not separate bigOthers waiting for a higher process to rank them at runtime. Their objects, authorities, roles, and permissions already receive meaning through the one combined weave. **Paul's pride in supporting himself through work illustrates the point: Christianity and a work ethic need not compete for supremacy.** In [1 Corinthians 9:6–18](#), especially verses 15–18, Paul connects his boast with preaching without making use of his right to material support; [1 Thessalonians 2:9](#) and [2 Thessalonians 3:7–10](#) present labouring so as not to

burden the community as an exemplary practice. A Christian mythology package and a *Berufsethos* can therefore reinforce one another within a single program. This is an illustration of compatibility, not population-level proof that every religious and professional package is compatible.

New cultural material consequently has three broad fates:

- 1. **Incumbent assimilation or rejection:** the installed lens interprets, neutralizes, reuses, or refuses the material in its own terms without surrendering its load-bearing classifications.
- 2. **Compatible integration:** a package whose important classifications and authority relations can coexist with the incumbent is braided into the one operative lens.
- 3. **Replacement under incompatibility:** a rival governing program cannot be installed beside the incumbent. The incumbent weave must be loosened and unbraided sufficiently for retained strands and new material to be rebraided into one successor lens.

Within the originating application developed here, **Christianity and the National Socialist worldview are deeply incompatible programming systems** at load-bearing classifications such as God and ultimate authority, the person and neighbour, race and nation, truth, obedience, sacrifice, violence, and loyalty. Nazi programming could not simply be installed beside an intact Christian program. Capture required a replacement process. A Nazi-governed successor could retain Christian words, scripture, symbols, rituals, offices, or a subjective Christian identity, but those strands would receive their operative meaning from the successor weave. The result would be one rebraided Nazi-Christian program, not two programs ordered by rank.

Deep cultural change is therefore unlike adding neutral information to memory. Reprogramming changes the weave that determines what new information means and how it feels. Incomplete replacement can produce contradiction, instability, or a tangled lens during loosening and rebraiding; it does not establish several independent bigOthers running in parallel. This helps explain why conversion, deradicalization, psychoanalysis, moral injury, ideological rupture, and profound changes of identity can be slow, conflictual, and emotionally painful.

6. Systems Leadership: mythologies and the mythological lens

Systems Leadership: Creating Positive Organisations, by Ian Macdonald, Catherine Burke, and Karl Stewart, supplies the definitive practical account used by Culture Mechanics for how culture is deliberately implemented. Its method coordinates leadership behaviour, systems, symbols, mythologies, habits, organizational arrangements, and repeated experience rather than treating mythology as sufficient by itself. Culture Mechanics embeds that organizational and workplace account in a larger theory and develops selected extensions and refinements; readers seeking the exact implementation method should read the book.

Culture mechanics adopts the following terminological hierarchy:

Term	Definition in culture mechanics
Mythology	One socially evaluated story or narrative unit. It need not involve gods or supernatural events. It shows persons, roles, actions, conflicts, and consequences while indicating what deserves admiration, shame, loyalty, fear, trust, disgust, or condemnation.
Mythologies	The accumulated and partly interconnected body of such stories available to a person or group. They provide many examples of how the social world is supposed to be interpreted.
Mythological lens	The generalized mapping formed from those mythologies and reinforced by systems, symbols, rituals, sanctions, and observed conduct. It maps real-world observations and events onto culturally learned values and feelings.
bigOther	The local sentiment-classification processor that executes the installed mythological lens and applies its mappings quickly.

The lens is one executable weave but may be modular. Mythologies, practices, professional ethics, familial duties, and local customs can operate as mutually compatible packages within it. Their plurality is a plurality of constituent

strands and context-sensitive mappings, not a plurality of local bigOthers.

This yields the central culture-mechanical sequence:

MYTHOLOGY

one evaluated story



MYTHOLOGIES

many mutually reinforcing stories



MYTHOLOGICAL LENS

generalized mappings from observations to values and feelings



BIGOTHER

fast execution of those mappings



ELEPHANT AND MAIN CPU

felt attraction, aversion, obligation, attention, and motivation

An individual mythology can teach:

- which kinds of persons and roles exist;
- what counts as a good group member;
- which authorities are legitimate;
- which conduct receives praise or condemnation;
- which sacrifices are honourable;
- what constitutes betrayal, pollution, injustice, or redemption;
- how the past explains the present;
- what the group expects of the individual;
- which future is desirable or disastrous.

A story acts as an evaluated simulation. Narrative transportation places the listener inside a conflict; a hero or villain demonstrates a possible response; consequences display what follows; praise or condemnation supplies the sentiment label; and the audience's reaction shows whether the classification is collectively shared. Each story is one training example. Many convergent stories allow the bigOther to generalize a lens that can classify new situations never described in any one story.

Systems Leadership adds an important qualification: explicit stories are not the only influences on the lens. The conduct of leaders, the design of systems, the use of symbols, institutional rewards and sanctions, and repeated experiences of belonging, success, humiliation, or exclusion can confirm or contradict the lessons conveyed by a mythology. These experiences may themselves later be narrated as new mythologies.

The relationship is therefore not simply “a story causes a feeling.” Rather:

stories + observed conduct + systems + symbols + repeated experience



reinforce or contradict mythologies



shape the mythological lens



lens maps a new observation onto value and feeling

Systems Leadership commonly describes the lens as evaluating behaviour, systems, and symbols along continua such as:

- honesty–dishonesty;
- trust–distrust;
- courage–cowardice;
- respect–disrespect for human dignity;
- fairness–unfairness;
- love or care–indifference.

Culture mechanics interprets these as important output dimensions of the programmed bigOther. They are not necessarily an exhaustive list of human moral sentiments, but they show concretely what the lens does: it converts

a physical or social observation into an affectively consequential classification.

When people possess sufficiently similar mythological lenses, they tend to interpret the same conduct in similar ways. Systems Leadership calls the resulting shared evaluative pattern culture. Culture mechanics adds that compatible local bigOthers can also exchange signals and synchronize, turning shared classification into distributed affect and coordinated action.

7. Programming, activation, and reprogramming

Culture mechanics distinguishes several operations that are easily confused:

Operation	Timescale	Function
Programming	Slow	Adds, reinforces, or revises mythologies and compatible packages and thereby installs, extends, or modifies the one mythological lens used by the bigOther.
Classification	Very fast	The bigOther applies the installed lens to a person, thought, action, symbol, or event.
Activation	Fast	A present signal activates an already learned mapping in the lens.
Synchronization	Fast	Reciprocal signals align the affective or behavioural states of several people.
Reinforcement	Repeated	Successful, praised, punished, or emotionally intense execution stabilizes mythologies and their mappings in the lens.
Reprogramming	Usually slow	Modifies the operative weave. Compatible change can extend or repair it; incompatible replacement requires sufficient unbraiding of the incumbent and rebraiding of one successor lens.
Unbraiding and rebraiding	Usually slow and conflictual	Loosens load-bearing bindings, preserves or detaches selected strands, crosses a potentially unstable interval, and installs one successor weave rather than a parallel evaluator.

A slogan, flag, gesture, uniform, accusation, facial expression, or news event normally does not transmit a complete mythological lens. It is a small trigger interpreted by an already programmed bigOther. The same signal can therefore produce opposite reactions in people with differently formed lenses. When the event is subsequently organized and retold as an evaluated story, it can also become a new mythology that reinforces or modifies the lens.

A **master signifier** is an especially dense activation signal. In the co-developed analogy adopted here, it is a **highly compressed protocol token** that indexes and activates an already installed complex of stories, classifications, authorities, identities, sentiments, and expected conduct. The token does not contain that whole complex any more than M contains every ordered pair of a mathematical mapping. Its power depends upon prior programming and a shared convention for expanding it. Longer stories, repeated practice, and institutional experience can change the program; the token usually calls the program already present.

Activation and replacement must therefore not be confused. A signal can activate or reinforce material already compatible with the installed lens. It cannot by itself make an incompatible governing program co-occupy the

slot. Such capture requires the incumbent's authority relations and classifications to be loosened, detached, or reinterpreted and a successor weave to be constructed.

8. Culture-mechanical objects, ideological programs, conformity signals, and targeting signals

This section develops a mini-theory of the objects through which cultural programs become personally operative and publicly legible. Its authoritative home is *Culture Mechanics* because the mechanism begins at the interface among an installed lens, the local bigOther that executes it, and a socially intelligible token. The mechanism can then scale into the mechanical-solidarity field developed in *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*. A symbol is not merely an individual possession: institutions may prescribe it, absence may communicate without deliberate intention, and its aggregate effect may exceed what any one participant intends.

Culture-mechanical object A **culture-mechanical object** is any program, carrier, implementation arrangement, processor state, or emergent collective organization whose relevant function is to install, activate, transmit, execute, synchronize, or enforce culturally learned social and evaluative classifications. The term is proposed by the present framework as a broad analytical umbrella. It does not make every member of the category the same kind of thing.

Culture-mechanical object	Meaning	Examples
Program complex	A large, internally structured package capable of programming an operative mythological lens	Religions, Marxism, National Socialism, liberal constitutional culture, nationalism, company cultures, activist movements, military ethos, professional cultures, state programmes
Program unit or content	Material from which a larger operative weave is constructed	Mythologies, narratives, causal stories, moral rules, roles, exemplars, sacred values, master signifiers
Carrier or activation device	A token through which the program is communicated, activated, or made publicly legible	Flags, veils, blue neckerchiefs, imposed yellow stars, badges, certificates, slogans, linguistic forms, masks, salutes, songs, whistle signals
Implementation arrangement	A durable structure that rewards, sanctions, repeats, or institutionalizes the program	Schools, appointment systems, rituals, calendars, dress codes, promotion criteria, laws, media routines, organizational systems
Local execution	The installed program as executed by an individual sentiment classifier	A local bigOther applying its mythological lens
Collective formation	The emergent result of compatible local execution and reciprocal signalling	Mechanical solidarity and the distributed bigOther
Collective agent	A sufficiently integrated and continuous collective formation capable of judgment, intention, ownership, and action	A multi-mind-self

In common contemporary political, organizational, and media usage, **narrative** is often a fuzzy synonym for **mythology**. Culture mechanics retains a precise boundary inside that overlap. *Narrative* is the broader term for an organized account of events, actors, causes, and consequences. A narrative becomes culture-mechanically mythological when it also carries socially learned evaluation, roles, causal interpretation, expected feeling, or permission—when it teaches not only what happened but what should feel admirable, shameful, legitimate, treacherous, threatening, redemptive, permitted, or forbidden. A merely chronological account need not be a mythology. A **causal story** is a narrative specialized around explaining why something happened and assigning agency or responsibility. The common political expression “**the narrative**” may refer more broadly to an authorized mythology, mythology family, or even the lens through which events are required to be interpreted; its precise level must be identified from context.

At the applied level, **narrative design** and **narrative construction** are therefore close practitioner-language synonyms for **mythology construction**. *Mythology Construction* develops this relationship and identifies existing narrative-design toolkits as partial practical implementations of the same intervention domain.

A whole religion, political formation, company culture, activist movement, or state programme may be a **composite culture-mechanical object** containing several of these subtypes. The name *Christianity*, *Islam*, *Judaism*, *Marxism*, *National Socialism*, or *company culture* may refer in one sentence to a body of programming and in another to its institutions, carriers, synchronized population, or collective agency. Analysis must therefore identify which level is meant rather than treating the inherited name as a precise ontology.

What the theory is disentangling Ordinary vocabulary often uses *religion*, *ideology*, *culture*, *collective consciousness*, *big Other*, or *group mind* as near-synonyms. Culture mechanics treats religion and secular ideology as members of the same broad family of cultural programming while refusing to collapse program, processor, protocol, field, and agent:

Construct	Precise role in culture mechanics
Cultural or ideological program	The executable package of mythologies, classifications, rules, roles, values, and expected conduct installed as one operative weave.
Mythological lens	The generalized mapping through which observations are converted into culturally learned values and feelings.
Ideological symbol	A socially legible token that activates the program and communicates a person's relation to it.
Conformity signal	An ideological symbol whose performance or nonperformance makes conformity and deviation publicly legible.
Targeting signal	A performed, omitted, imposed, or attributed token that assigns a person or population to a sanctionable out-group.
Local bigOther	The individual sentiment classifier that executes the installed lens.
Lacan's big Other	The shared symbolic vocabulary and protocol through which the program and its tokens become publicly intelligible.
Mechanical solidarity	The synchronized symbolic-affective coherence produced through compatible local execution and reciprocal response.
Distributed bigOther	The persistent network state maintained through persons, institutions, practices, artifacts, reputations, and sanctions.
Multi-mind-self	The distributed system only when it becomes sufficiently integrated and continuous to judge, intend, own, and act as a collective agent.

In this section, **ideological** is the broad, religion-inclusive adjective for anything pertaining to such a cultural program. It includes religious, political, organizational, professional, activist, national, and lifestyle programs. This broad use must be distinguished from the narrower **ideological form**, the third member of the private-collective-ideological-fundamentalist taxonomy below. The expression **ideological-form program** names that third configuration when the two senses might otherwise be confused.

Ideological symbols must be classified by function

An ideological symbol is a material object, word, linguistic form, gesture, sound, image, ritual, omission, or other socially legible token that activates an installed ideological program and communicates a person's relation to that program.

The medium is incidental to the definition. A piece of cloth, grammatical ending, salute, profile image, whistle pattern, silence, refusal to applaud, or continued association with an excluded person can perform the same operation when participants know how to decode it. A symbol can be simultaneously functional in another domain: a mask can be a medical device and also acquire a moral-political meaning; clothing can protect from weather and also display membership. The presence of one function neither proves nor excludes the other.

Ideological symbols can perform several distinguishable functions:

1. activate an installed program;
2. cue the carrier's conduct;
3. display affiliation or membership;
4. distinguish insiders from outsiders;
5. advertise the program or invite imitation;
6. test conformity and expose deviation;
7. assign or expose a sanctionable out-group;
8. synchronize attention, affect, identity, judgment, or action;
9. manufacture apparent consensus;
10. mark refusal as moral or character failure;
11. communicate a claim to wider social jurisdiction;
12. enable social, institutional, legal, or physical sanctions.

No one token necessarily performs every function. Function must be inferred from the surrounding program, expectations, audience, treatment of refusal, and actual institutional consequences rather than from material form, religious or secular origin, or the stated intention of one carrier.

Conformity signals

An ideological symbol becomes a conformity signal when its performance, display, absence, refusal, or substitution makes conformity and deviation publicly legible and thereby enables monitoring, reinforcement, sanction, recruitment, exclusion, or a claim to wider jurisdiction.

A **boundary signal** distinguishes insiders from outsiders. A **propagation signal** is designed or selected for easy public reproduction and advertises, normalizes, or spreads the program. A secret greeting may mainly mark a boundary; a slogan, salute, hashtag, linguistic convention, pledge, or clothing expectation may invite or pressure everyone to repeat it. One symbol can perform both functions.

Targeting signals Conformity signals and target markers are not mutually exclusive material classes. They name functions that may overlap in the same token or expectation:

A targeting signal is any performed, omitted, imposed, or attributed socially legible token that assigns a person or population to a sanctionable out-group and thereby makes exclusion, coercion, persecution, or violence easier to direct.

Here **sanctionable** means treated by the program as available for sanction; it does not mean that the classification or sanction is justified.

A conformity signal becomes a targeting signal when its absence, refusal, substitution, or incorrect performance makes the nonconforming person legible as a sanctionable outsider.

The relevant **signal polarity** is how the classification becomes visible, not whether the carrier voluntarily communicates it:

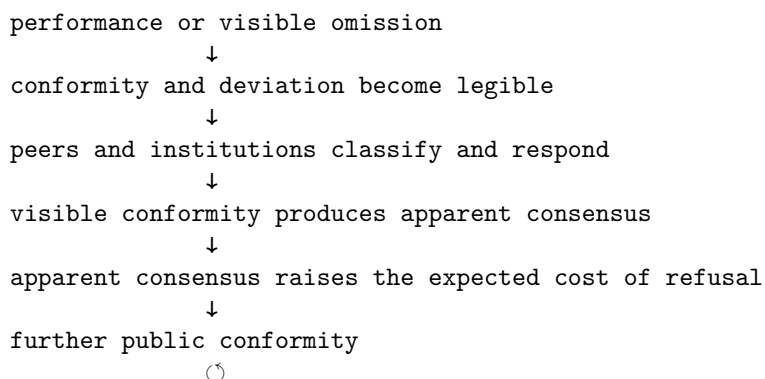
Mode	Culture-mechanical operation	Vivid example
Performed conformity	Display marks the person as one of "us"	Blue neckerchief, expected mask, badge, salute, pledge, or prescribed linguistic form
Negative targeting through nonperformance	Absence, refusal, substitution, or incorrect performance identifies the deviant	Missing neckerchief, unmasked face where masking is expected, absent certificate, refused salute, or unapproved wording

Mode	Culture-mechanical operation	Vivid example
Imposed target marking	A hostile authority forces the out-group classification onto its target	The yellow star imposed on Jews under National Socialism
Attributed target marking	A name, accusation, record, database entry, or administrative category assigns target status without requiring a visible token	“Heretic,” “class enemy,” “extremist,” “unvaccinated,” or a corresponding institutional record when the classification routes sanctions

The blue neckerchief and the yellow star therefore differ in their direction of assignment but can converge downstream. The neckerchief marks the compliant member and its absence can expose a nonconforming target. The yellow star directly and forcibly marks the person whom the governing program classifies as an outsider. Both make a culturally defined boundary operational by making persons sortable.

COVID-19 supplies a particularly clear mixed case. An unmasked face could become a negative targeting signal wherever masking was expected and refusal was treated as evidence of irresponsibility, danger, or defective character. Vaccination status was normally not visible by itself; certificates, database checks, disclosure requirements, denied access, and verbal classification made it legible. The official phrase “[pandemic of the unvaccinated](#)” turned a biomedical status into a named causal category within public discourse and was explicitly joined to vaccination requirements. In a given setting, whether this classification became a targeting signal must be tested by examining blame, expected displays, access conditions, sanctions, and the treatment of refusal. This functional analysis does not by itself decide the empirical accuracy, medical value, legality, proportionality, or moral legitimacy of a mask or vaccine policy.

The decisive operation can therefore be negative. Where a display is expected, its absence identifies the person who has not complied without requiring that person to make a declaration. The signal thereby turns conduct into public telemetry:



When the performance is mutually observable, it can also generate **common knowledge**: participants know the signal, know that others received it, and know that others can observe their own response. [Michael Suk-Young Chwe's *Rational Ritual*](#) supplies this coordination mechanism. Common knowledge can organize outward conduct without proving private assent or the complete culture-mechanical account.

This loop can produce sincere convergence, strategic compliance, preference falsification, pluralistic ignorance, or a mixture of them. [Timur Kuran's *Private Truths, Public Lies*](#) supplies the established neighbouring mechanism in which public expression diverges from private preference under pressure. [Václav Havel's *The Power of the Powerless*](#) shows how ritual public conformity can reproduce a system without requiring private belief. Culture mechanics adds the local-processor, symbolic-protocol, and field account; neither author proposed this complete synthesis.

The installed program also supplies a virtual **yardstick of the good member**: a good hunter, vegan, worker, believer, citizen, revolutionary, or comrade. The conformity signal makes a person's apparent position against that yardstick visible. Assenting to an absurd statement can therefore become an especially powerful loyalty test: agreement with “2 + 2 = 5” communicates little about arithmetic but much about willingness to submit. Signals can also mark enemies. Public rejection of a stigmatized word, object, person, or association may become its own proof of belonging.

A compulsory conformity signal is not automatically a **credibility-enhancing display** or CRED. In Joseph Henrich's narrower model, costly conduct by a model can make professed commitment credible; see “[The Evolution of Costly Displays, Cooperation and Religion](#)”. With a compulsory symbol, the principal cost may fall on refusal rather than on

performance, and compliance may be purely strategic. **Sanction-backed conformity signal, compulsory membership signal, or public loyalty marker** is then more precise. No unvalidated checklist or numerical threshold should be presented as a CRED measure.

Beseelung and four propagation and enforcement forms The originating **dead-alive** analogy distinguishes information that is merely known from programming that animates conduct. A relatively dead rule resembles “stop at the red pedestrian light”: a person can notice and ignore it without much guilt. An alive practice can make omission feel like personal failure, guilt, or betrayal. The German *beseelt*—literally, in a poetic translation, “ensouled”—better conveys this experienced animation than the bloodless word *stored*.

Beseelung is an independent axis. It concerns how affectively alive and conduct-directing a program is, not how widely it recruits or how aggressively it enforces. A private dietary or yoga practice can be intensely alive. A football crowd can synchronize powerfully without seeking converts. A perfectly conforming functionary can privately believe nothing, and a fundamentalist system can be enforced by cynical officials.

The private–collective–ideological–fundamentalist distinction classifies dominant **propagation and enforcement configurations**, not different kinds of bigOther and not a necessary sequence through which every program passes:

Form	Characteristic propagation	Typical symbolic function	Treatment of nonparticipation
Private	Self-selection and personal discovery	Self-cue, personal commitment, optional recognition	Normally irrelevant to outsiders; private relational boundaries may still be strong
Collective	Attraction, affiliation, and display of the pleasures of belonging	Membership, shared enjoyment, ritual synchronization, advertisement of the community	Usually tolerated, although reputation and coordinated ostracism become possible
Ideological form	Active recruitment, education, and formation in the “correct” way of being	Public conformity, loyalty tests, mission, and apparent unanimity	Moral, social, educational, or institutional pressure
Fundamentalist	Militant expansion, retention, or defence	Mobilization, enemy marking, surveillance, and demonstrations of irreversible commitment	Authorization or willingness to use physical coercion or violence to convert, retain, punish, expel, or eliminate

Vivid ideal-type examples:

- In the **private form**, consider a dietary or yoga practice found and adopted on one’s own initiative. Communities of practice may exist, but the program does not strongly recruit outsiders.
- In the **collective form**, consider football-club or pop-star fandom. It attracts through advertising, spectacle, and the visible pleasures of belonging rather than demanding conversion.
- In the **ideological form**, consider a proselytizing religion or a political movement such as Marxism. Mission, education, cadre formation, or comparable training forms members in the “correct” way of being.
- In the **fundamentalist form**, consider a militant religious or political movement willing to use bodily force to convert or retain members, punish refusal, expel opponents, or eliminate rivals.

These examples make the forms concrete; they do not establish that every instance belongs wholly to one form. Whole religions, cultures, institutions, or movements may nevertheless be classified as predominantly one form when the scope, evidence, counterexamples, and possible falsifiers are stated.

The taxonomy is a project-developed synthesis, not a classification attributed to [Susan Blackmore’s account of memes and memes](#). Her replicator account supplies a neighbouring way to think about copied cultural information; the four forms classify the propagation and enforcement configurations in which a program is reproduced. Their variability illustrates the originating software analogy: programs are flexible—that is the force of *soft* in *software*.

The forms compress several axes that must remain separately inspectable:

- depth of *Beseelung*;
- public visibility;
- outward recruitment or proselytism;
- inward retention and treatment of exit;
- lateral intolerance of rival allegiance;
- jurisdiction over domains of life;
- synchronization strength;
- social and institutional sanctions;
- authorization or willingness to use physical violence.

Strong conviction is not by itself fundamentalism. Proselytism is not jealousy; jealousy is not physical violence; and discursive violence, defined below, can occur before the fundamentalist form.

Jealous programs, solidarity, and collective agents The originating analogy is deliberately vivid:

A jealous multi-mind-self resembles a jealous lover who wants to own the beloved and cannot tolerate divided allegiance.

The corresponding operational definition is:

A jealous cultural program claims exclusive allegiance, classifies incompatible commitment, dissent, or exit as betrayal, and mobilizes symbols, sanctions, institutions, and collective affect to defend that claim.

[Kenneth Minogue's *Alien Powers: The Pure Theory of Ideology*](#) provides a close published neighbour in its treatment of ideological revelation as jealous and expansionary. **Jealous cultural program** and its integration with the present ontology are project-developed terms, not Minogue's complete theory.

Jealousy must be attributed at the correct level:

Level	Operation in a jealous configuration
Lacan's big Other	Carries publicly intelligible categories and tokens such as loyalty, betrayal, idolatry, heresy, oath, flag, scarf, and rival symbol. It is the protocol, not the jealous agent.
Local bigOther	Executes a jealous lens and makes rival allegiance, refusal, or exit feel shameful, contaminating, frightening, or treacherous. In bigOther-presence , and especially bigOther-as-Thou , the person may directly feel a present jealous Other that claims fidelity and refuses divided allegiance. Calling the processor itself jealous remains functional shorthand for the program it executes; calling the experienced presence jealous describes how that operation can be lived.
Mechanical solidarity	Synchronizes compatible classifications and reciprocal enforcement.
Distributed bigOther	Preserves the network state through expectations, reputations, rituals, institutions, symbols, and sanctions.
Multi-mind-self	If the collective-agent threshold is met, the integrated system can itself claim, condemn, exclude, punish, or attack through its members and institutions.

Jealousy therefore has both an **analytical description** and a **phenomenological appearance**. Analytically, the installed program defines exclusive loyalty and the local bigOther executes its classifications. Phenomenologically, a jealous God, Nation, People, History, or Cause may be encountered as personally present—watching, addressing, claiming, accusing, or demanding sacrifice. This direct individual experience does not collapse the local processor into Lacan's shared symbolic protocol, and it does not by itself establish that the surrounding distributed bigOther has crossed the multi-mind-self threshold.

Single-slot exclusivity is not jealousy. Every stable program fully occupies the one local slot, including an open, pluralistic, lifted program. Jealousy begins when the installed program additionally demands exclusive allegiance,

treats legitimate rivalry or replacement as betrayal, blocks dignified exit, claims the whole person, exceeds its jurisdiction, or monopolizes authoritative interpretation.

Jealousy and proselytism are hypothesized to reinforce one another often, especially in ideological-form and fundamentalist programs, but they are not identical. A separatist sect can retain members jealously while seeking no converts; a missionary movement can recruit energetically while respecting refusal and exit. Analysis should therefore record outward recruitment, inward retention, rival intolerance, jurisdiction, and enforcement separately.

[Exodus 20:3 and 20:5](#) supply the theological exemplar of a jealous God, exclusive covenant loyalty, and “no other gods.” The jealous-lover comparison uses this as an analogy for the classification of rival attachment as betrayal or idolatry, not as empirical proof of the social mechanism. The related Christian interpretation—that the human capacity to join a multi-mind-self is the “God-shaped hole” that should be filled by God rather than a human ideological collective—is an originating confessional interpretation, not a general scientific proposition or a settled philological claim.

Moralization as character accusation: Andrick’s bridge [Michael Andrick’s *Im Moralegefängnis: Spaltung verstehen und überwinden*](#) supplies the missing micro-mechanism between moral classification, conformity signalling, exclusion, and escalating violence. In Andrick’s account, misplaced moralization performs two changes at once:

1. **Focus:** the exchange moves from the disputed issue to the other person’s character.
2. **Mode:** inquiry and argument become accusation and prosecution.

His kindergarten example preserves the operation vividly. A discussion about whether a kindergarten should have two or three floors becomes a trial of whether one participant is a good person who deserves to remain in the discussion. A fleeting statement or minor act is read as a revealing disclosure of character; the alleged disclosure becomes a character accusation; and the person’s standing, rather than the proposition, becomes the target:

```
factual disagreement or missing conformity signal
↓
statement, omission, or association becomes "character disclosure"
↓
character accusation
↓
inquiry becomes prosecution
↓
discursive standing is attacked
↓
submit, recant, or be excluded
```

Andrick’s strong verdict is that **moralization is discursive violence** and makes physical violence more likely. Its immediate domination does not require bodily force: it attacks the other’s recognized standing and invokes the background threat, “You may not be breaking public law, but you are breaking my law; submit or I will exclude you.” Even legitimate moral condemnation remains aggressive in this account. In private relationships it is the metaphorical **atomic bomb**, or the sharpest social weapon, although consciously removing an intolerable person from one’s voluntary private circle may itself be legitimate.

The tendency toward violence therefore cannot simply be abolished in Andrick’s account: even justified moral condemnation contains an exclusionary threat. His associated freedom claim is equally strong—pathological moralization and free self-determination cannot coexist. Official voluntariness does not settle the question when refusing a prescribed linguistic form, dress expectation, ritual, or declaration brings foreseeable moral, social, or professional punishment.

Culture mechanics extends rather than merely repeats Andrick’s account:

```
local bigOther classifies a person as bad, disloyal, or unbearable
↓ encoded through
shared accusation, stigma, required denunciation, or conformity test
↓ reciprocally reinforced as
mechanical solidarity and collective exclusion
↓ preserved through
distributed reputations, institutional routines, records, and sanctions
↓ possibly executed by
a multi-mind-self capable of organized judgment and action
```

Guilt by association is a secondary conformity signal. Continuing to speak with an excluded person, refusing to denounce them, or preserving a public relationship can itself be treated as a character disclosure. Cancel culture, refusal to enter discussion with opponents, mandatory denunciation, and the public sorting of people into epistemic tribes are candidate manifestations of this mechanism; each case still requires evidence that the operation actually occurred.

Division is therefore not merely a static condition. It can be continuously enacted as people stop speaking with opponents, speak only about them, infer character from statements, demand public denunciation, and punish continued association. The present framework adds the **moral-closure hypothesis**:

Rudolf Bilz's formulation of human existence as **tribunal existence** and Odo Marquard's "tribunalization of modern lived reality" are neighbouring diagnoses of a condition in which persons are placed under pervasive accusation and pressure to justify their right to be as they are. The exact primary source for Bilz's formulation remains to be verified; it is retained here as a provenance lead rather than presented as established evidence for the mechanism.

```
group bundles around an argument
      ↓
non-bundlers are excluded
      ↓
belonging becomes membership among "good people"
      ↓
opposition becomes character defect
      ↓
an open society is converted into a closed community
      ↓
the closed community seeks dominance
```

The originating discussion connected this sequence with Ulrike Guérot's "bundling" description of a group organizing around an argument and excluding those who refuse to bundle, and with Ferdinand Tönnies's distinction between open societal association and closed community. That compound attribution still requires a primary-source audit. The diagram above is therefore Culture Mechanics' moral-closure hypothesis, not a definition attributed to Guérot, Tönnies, or an established general definition of fascism.

The originating **ideology-as-hallucination hypothesis** is stronger still: an ideology operating as a collectively protected hallucination cannot win through a reality-facing explanation of mechanisms and consequences and therefore tends to use discursive domination. On this hypothesis, moralization expresses fear—or, in the culpable case, knowledge—that the position would fail under fair conditions among equals. This is a definite and risky project hypothesis, not an established result of Andrick's book. It would be weakened by cases in which a position systematically moralizes strong opponents despite repeatedly prevailing under open, symmetrical, evidence-sensitive contest, or by evidence that the moralization is better explained without awareness or fear of argumentative weakness.

The enforcement–exclusion and violence repertoire The originating claim is:

Enforcement and exclusion are dual operations. Enforcement states or applies a condition of continued inclusion, standing, access, or permitted action; exclusion withdraws or denies these goods when the condition is not met.

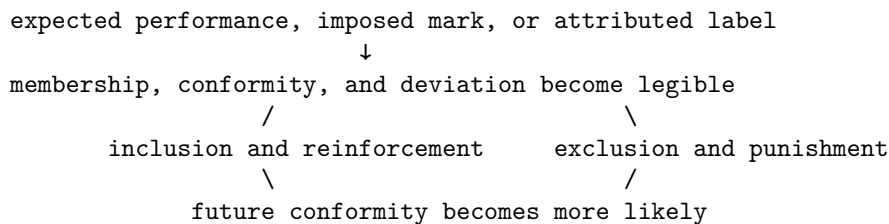
Andrick's compact threat—"Submit, or I will exclude you"—contains both sides. From the program's perspective, the rule is enforced. From the affected person's perspective, refusal can mean exclusion from moral standing, discussion, relationship, community, institution, territory, or life. The same sanction often does both simultaneously: excluding one visible nonconformist also enforces conformity among everyone who observes the consequence.

This is a structural duality, not an assertion that enforcement and exclusion are identical in every case. Instruction, persuasion, reward, or ordinary coordination can maintain a practice without applying an exclusionary sanction. A person can end a private relationship without trying to govern a wider public. Physical coercion can be used to retain or convert a person rather than expel them, although it excludes their alternative conduct and violates bodily autonomy. Jurisdiction, proportionality, evidence, due process, and the good being withheld remain separate questions.

The word *violence* must likewise not hide the difference between moral evaluation, discursive domination, exclusion, coercion, and bodily force:

Form	Program-side enforcement	Excluded standing or domain
Moral evaluation	Classifies conduct as good or bad; ordinary bigOther activity, not necessarily moralization	Moral approval or recognition as a good member; no civic or social exclusion need follow
Discursive violence	Replaces inquiry with character accusation and attacks the opponent's standing	Credibility, admissibility, or recognition as a legitimate interlocutor
Relational exclusion	Conditions or ends friendship, intimacy, or voluntary private association	A particular relationship or private circle
Collective social exclusion	Uses ostracism, cancellation, guilt by association, or coordinated reputational destruction	Community membership, social contact, reputation, and informal opportunities
Institutional coercion	Conditions employment, education, platforms, services, office, or professional standing on submission	Access to institutions, occupations, services, platforms, or public roles
Physical violence	Uses or threatens bodily force to compel, retain, punish, convert, expel, or eliminate	Bodily autonomy, movement, safety, territory, or the permitted alternative course of action
Eliminative violence	Treats the rival as having no right to remain, participate, or exist	Membership, territory, public existence, life, or memory

The conformity-signal mechanism is the sensor and this repertoire supplies possible outputs:



This repertoire is not a deterministic ladder. Moralization can stop at private withdrawal or social exclusion, and movements can jump to institutional or physical coercion. The compact distinction is:

All moralization is discursively violent in Andrick's sense; not all moralization expresses willingness to use physical violence. The fundamentalist threshold is authorization or willingness to use physical or eliminative force, not the mere presence of moral aggression.

Moralization can nevertheless raise the probability of further violence by turning the mistaken person into the bad person, licensing exclusion, making punishment appear deserved, and allowing aggression to be experienced as protection, justice, purification, or duty. This is a probabilistic escalation hypothesis, not the claim that every moralized disagreement becomes physically violent.

Stanton's genocidal escalation processes as a neighbouring model [Gregory H. Stanton's *Ten Stages of Genocide*](#) supplies a neighbouring model of how collective classification and symbolization can become organized eliminative violence. Stanton now emphasizes that the "stages" are overlapping, non-linear processes: they can operate simultaneously, need not advance inexorably, and can be interrupted. His object is the specific process leading to genocide; the culture-mechanical repertoire is broader and also applies to non-genocidal programs, relationships, institutions, and conflicts.

The models therefore map onto one another without becoming synonyms:

Stanton's process	Culture-mechanical relationship
1. Classification	The mythological lens divides a population into "us" and "them." Classification is upstream of violence and can also serve benign or necessary distinctions.

Stanton's process	Culture-mechanical relationship
2. Symbolization	Names, dress, documents, and other tokens make the classification socially legible. An expected conformity signal can target through its absence; an imposed marker such as the yellow star directly marks the out-group; an attributed label can do so without a worn object.
3. Discrimination	Enforcement–exclusion becomes durable law, custom, or institutional practice that removes rights, standing, access, or opportunity from the classified group.
4. Dehumanization	Moralized character accusation expands into categorical enemy construction: persons become vermin, disease, contamination, pollution, or another kind of being whose removal can be redescribed as cleansing or protection.
5. Organization	Parties, bureaucracies, police, armies, militias, media systems, lists, and surveillance turn hostility into scalable implementation capacity. Organization is infrastructure for violence, not by itself another form of violence.
6. Polarization	Moral closure, guilt by association, communicative severance, and attacks on moderates disable countercultures, compromise, and independent correction.
7. Preparation	Plans, target lists, training, weapons, mobilization, and euphemistic goals make organized physical or eliminative intent operational. These are strong indicators that the fundamentalist threshold has been crossed, although no numbered Stanton process defines that threshold.
8. Persecution	Institutional coercion and physical violence become coordinated identification, dispossession, arrest, displacement, confinement, torture, or killing of the target population.
9. Extermination	Genocide is a specific collective form of eliminative violence. The culture-mechanical category is broader because programs can seek to eliminate political, social, or other rivals without satisfying the definition of genocide.
10. Denial	The program protects itself after and during violence through euphemism, destroyed evidence, impunity, blame reversal, suppression of memory, and attacks on witnesses. This connects the enforcement–exclusion and violence repertoire to memory control and systemic lying in Epistemic Constitution of Lifted Mechanical Solidarity .

Stanton's model supplies historically developed observations and an early-warning process model. It does not establish the local-bigOther processor, distributed field, jealousy, or multi-mind-self ontology proposed here. Conversely, Culture Mechanics proposes a possible micro-to-macro mechanism through which some of Stanton's processes become affectively compelling, mutually observable, and institutionally executable.

The connection is a risky escalation hypothesis, not guilt by conceptual association. A classification, symbol, health rule, access condition, or act of private exclusion does not establish a genocidal trajectory. The inference becomes stronger only as additional processes appear: a sanctionable out-group, dehumanizing mythology, destruction of moderating relations, scalable coercive organization, preparation for physical force, persecution, and elimination. The absence of these transitions, durable protection of the target group's equal civic standing, and effective correction of wrongful classifications count against the escalation hypothesis.

Private morality and public standing The originating maxim “**morality is private**” protects an essential boundary: private moral revulsion does not by itself decide who may participate in public life. Taken absolutely, however, it would exclude genuine public moral questions and legitimate public authority. The compatible formulation is:

Comprehensive personal moral convictions do not by themselves determine another person’s civic standing. Public coercion requires publicly contestable rules, proper jurisdiction, evidence, proportionality, and due process.

Or, more vividly:

We may debate moral questions publicly, but disagreement must not become a character trial that revokes the opponent’s right to participate.

This boundary does not prohibit private association or moral judgment. It prevents a private moral law from silently becoming public jurisdiction. Its institutional development belongs in *Epistemic Constitution of Lifted Mechanical Solidarity*, especially “Low-cost contradiction, not low-cost condemnation.”

Worked examples and boundary tests **The DDR blue neckerchief.** The blue neckerchief of the Pioneer organization was not merely clothing or a membership badge. In a school environment where almost every child was expected to be a Pioneer, wearing it displayed conformity while the missing scarf exposed refusal without requiring the child to speak. The *historical description by MDR* records that Pioneer membership was part of ordinary school life and served the state’s socialist education. The culture-mechanical interpretation–boundary marker, identity and loyalty signal, public compliance device, and trigger for monitoring or sanction—is the present framework’s synthesis.

Speech and conduct. Prescribed gendered language (*Gendern*) can perform the same operation as cloth when use displays conformity, non-use becomes observable, and non-use is interpreted as character disclosure. A COVID mask can remain a medical device while also functioning as an ideological signal when the surrounding field makes it a visible test of responsibility, obedience, solidarity, distrust, or political allegiance. A salute, pledge, pronoun formula, badge, ribbon, flag, profile image, applause, whistle, silence, or continued association can likewise carry the operation. The test is functional and contextual, not material.

Kippah and Islamic veiling. The originating whole-religion comparison is deliberately asymmetric and testable. Judaism is hypothesized to be predominantly non-proselytizing and the kippah predominantly member-directed: its ordinary public meaning is the wearer’s observance and affiliation, not a demand that surrounding non-Jews adopt it. Islam, considered as a whole religious-cultural program, is hypothesized to be predominantly proselytizing and jealous. Islamic veiling can therefore function simultaneously as personal observance, internal conformity, outward propagation, and a claim to public moral jurisdiction. This classification concerns the operative canonical and institutional program and its aggregate trajectory; it does not assert that every Jew, Muslim, kippah wearer, or veiled woman understands or intends the complete operation.

On this hypothesis, veiling can become a **public threat** in a precise culture-mechanical sense: not because the fabric or every individual wearer issues a conscious threat, but because the surrounding program publicly represents a demand for wider jurisdiction and makes sanctions against eventual refusal predictable if that program becomes dominant. The kippah contrast predicts no comparable Judaism-wide apparatus for punishing refusal or compelling outsiders; evidence of such an apparatus would count against the comparison.

The blue neckerchief and Islamic veiling are thus proposed as **functional homologues** when both embody the program in everyday life, make conformity and refusal legible, distinguish good members from questionable ones, enable peer or institutional monitoring, normalize the underlying order, and reproduce it through public performance. Their differences concern propagation, jealousy, jurisdiction, and enforcement, not a categorical division between secular and religious symbols.

The boundary is not Iran. Police enforcement is the extreme implementation layer, not the beginning of a jurisdictional claim. The originating trajectory is:

practice presented as personal choice
↓
practice promoted as protection, dignity, or empowerment
↓
practice becomes a public model of proper conduct
↓
criticism is moralized as hostility or harm
↓

countercultures lose legitimate means of defence
 ↓
 institutions accommodate and reproduce the norm
 ↓
 nonconformity becomes socially or professionally costly
 ↓
 the norm acquires legal and police enforcement

The language of protection can create an asymmetric field: the advancing program expresses its demand as care, freedom, dignity, or safety while resistance is classified as prejudice or aggression. The program remains free to extend its norm, while countercultures are morally disarmed from defending their own order. This is the proposed **protection-framed jurisdictional manoeuvre**. It can emerge through many sincere participants without a central conspiracy. Only when the collective-agent threshold is met should it be attributed as an intentional manoeuvre of a multi-mind-self; below that threshold it remains an emergent operation of a program, solidarity field, and distributed bigOther.

Iran is proposed not as the boundary at which the problem begins but as an advanced realized form in which a religious prescription has captured state jurisdiction. The [United Nations Independent International Fact-Finding Mission on Iran](#) documents morality-police deployment, surveillance, arrests, prosecution, and forced pledges connected to mandatory hijab enforcement. The originating **end-state hypothesis** is conditional and categorical: for the relevant aggressively proselytizing and jealous Islamic movements in Western societies, success means defeating countercultures and acquiring sufficient institutional power; **if they succeed, Iran is the predicted end-state form**, in which promoted Islamic norms become compulsory public jurisdiction. Iran exhibits the predicted completed conversion; its existence does not by itself establish that every movement will succeed.

The religion-level hypothesis should be tested against canonical claims, mission and jihad doctrines, historical institutional trajectories, treatment of apostasy and criticism, freedom of rival religions, rules governing women's dress, and conduct after political dominance is obtained. It would be weakened by durable Muslim-majority orders possessing overwhelming cultural and political power while intrinsically protecting across generations:

- genuine freedom not to veil;
- conversion away from Islam and public criticism of Islam;
- rival religions and nonreligious life;
- equal civic standing independent of religious conformity;
- constitutional barriers preventing Islamic morality from becoming compulsory public law.

Judaism's contrasting classification is equally revisable: evidence of systematic outward conversion, expanding jurisdiction over non-Jews, or coercive enforcement of kippah observance would weaken the predominantly non-proselytizing, member-directed hypothesis. Whole religions may be classified. The scientific safeguard is precise scope, evidence, countercases, and falsifiability—not protective euphemism.

Combined mechanism and boundaries The mini-theory's central mechanism is:

jealous mythology defines exclusive loyalty
 ↓
 ideological symbol activates the installed program
 ↓
 conformity or targeting signal makes loyalty, refusal, or target status observable
 ↓
 deviation or target status is interpreted as character or category disclosure
 ↓
 moralization turns disclosure into accusation
 ↓
 mechanical solidarity distributes the judgment
 ↓
 systems impose exclusion, coercion, or violence
 ↓
 the program defends or expands its jurisdiction

This mechanism is not a claim that every symbol is a conformity or targeting signal, every conformity signal is jealous, every target classification is wrongful, every moral judgment is moralization, every ideological-form program is fundamentalist, or every distributed bigOther is a multi-mind-self. Each transition is a separate empirical question.

The theory predicts greater field synchronization and enforcement when signals are publicly observable, refusal or target status is morally interpreted, sanctions are credible, rival affiliation is treated as betrayal, and institutions preserve the resulting classifications. Evidence that these variables do not affect propagation, apparent consensus, retention, exclusion, or jurisdiction would weaken the mechanism.

9. First analogy: the computer with one PCI slot

The computer analogy presents the architecture in its simplest form.

Imagine a computer containing:

- a powerful general-purpose **CPU**;
- one **PCI slot**;
- a comparatively simple sentiment-classification card installed in that slot;
- a network interface through which the card exchanges signals with compatible cards.

The CPU performs complex computation. The PCI card does something much simpler: it assigns values to the CPU's current objects and possible outputs. It marks them, in effect, as attractive or aversive, honourable or shameful, legitimate or forbidden.

The card's simplicity is deceptive. If it can alter the CPU's priorities, error signals, and reward expectations, it can redirect the much more powerful processor. A simple evaluator can cause an extremely intelligent CPU to spend enormous resources defending a premise the evaluator has made emotionally non-negotiable.

The card runs a mythological lens shaped by many mythologies and potentially assembled from several compatible programming packages. Social signals usually do not install a whole new lens; they call mappings already present on the card. Because the machine has only one PCI slot, a rival card cannot simply be added beside the first, and there is no hidden runtime controller that ranks parallel cards. Compatible packages can extend the software on the installed card. An incompatible governing program must be rejected, or the incumbent program must be unbraided and a successor rebraided and installed on the one card.

This analogy makes the division of labour between the two processors easy to understand. Its limitation is that real human cognition is embodied, affective, interpretive, and less cleanly modular than a desktop computer.

10. Second analogy: Haidt's elephant with a wireless collar

The second analogy gives a closer picture of the proposed psychological operation.

Jonathan Haidt describes conscious reasoning as a **rider** sitting on an **elephant**. The elephant represents the large, fast, intuitive, emotional, and mostly nonconscious part of the mind. The rider represents the smaller conscious and verbal part that explains, plans, and sometimes guides the elephant, but frequently rationalizes where the elephant is already going.

Culture mechanics adds a **wireless collar** around the elephant's neck.

- The **elephant** is the person's intuitive, motivational, and largely nonconscious psychology.
- The **rider** is conscious verbal awareness and explicit reasoning.
- The **processor in the wireless collar** is the bigOther.
- The **program stored in the collar** is the mythological lens.
- The **mythologies** are the evaluated stories through which that program is trained and reinforced.
- The **wireless signals** are other people's expressions, symbols, slogans, rituals, approval, disapproval, and visible conduct.

The collar can produce social pleasure and pain: pride, shame, belonging, exclusion, sacredness, disgust, reassurance, fear, or indignation. It acts directly upon the elephant. The elephant changes its posture, attention, and direction long before the rider clearly notices the collar's intervention.

Only afterward may the rider become aware of a conclusion:

"This is obviously disgraceful."

"Someone like me cannot do that."

"Any decent person must support this."

The rider may mistake the resulting feeling for the product of independent reasoning. It may then use the main processor's verbal intelligence to justify the direction in which the elephant has already begun to move.

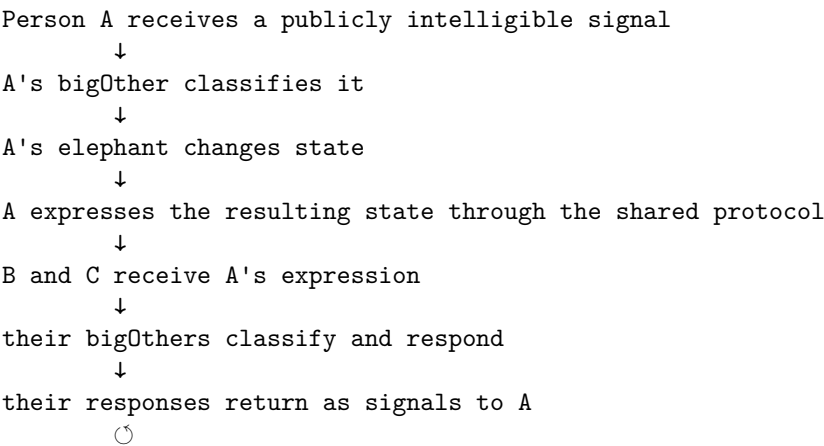
This analogy is closer to the psychological claim than the computer analogy because it shows that the bigOther does not normally dictate complete thoughts. It modifies the affective conditions under which thought and action occur.

11. The wireless superpower: the individual coupling interface

The bigOther’s distinctive superpower is its capacity to participate in **distributed computing**. Every collar is both receiver and transmitter. There is no separate class of persons possessing the only transmitters. People emit social signals through:

- facial expression, posture, and tone;
- attention or deliberate inattention;
- laughter, applause, chanting, or silence;
- confidence, fear, disgust, or outrage;
- repetition of phrases;
- imitation and conformity;
- approval, ridicule, punishment, and protection;
- participation in or refusal of rituals.

These outputs become inputs for other collars:



The originating physical analogy is that a local bigOther resembles a charged particle: it is a source of a field and is simultaneously susceptible to the field produced by other sources. The comparison concerns relational architecture and back-action. It does not propose a new physical force or claim that social dynamics obey Maxwell’s equations.

When participants run sufficiently compatible mythological lenses and can observe one another, reciprocal feedback can produce rapid alignment. A crowd may begin to attend, feel, chant, fear, celebrate, condemn, or act as if it were one body. This is the individual-to-field handoff. The field’s topology, unequal transmitter gain, collective agency, and epistemic consequences belong to the detailed account in *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*.

12. Local bigOther, symbolic protocol, and distributed field

Culture mechanics distinguishes five levels that must not be treated as synonyms:

Level	Meaning in culture mechanics
Lacan’s big Other	The shared symbolic order and, in the present functional translation, the on-the-wire protocol of language, law, roles, conventions, master signifiers, and recognized symbolic authority.
Local bigOther	The individual sentiment classifier that executes one installed mythological lens and transmits and receives through the shared protocol.
Mechanical solidarity	Emergent field coherence generated as compatible local bigOthers repeatedly produce, observe, and answer common classifications and sentiments.

Level	Meaning in culture mechanics
Distributed bigOther	The dynamically maintained symbolic-affective network state reproduced through local bigOthers, institutions, roles, practices, stories, and artifacts.
Multi-mind-self	The distributed system when it becomes sufficiently integrated and continuous to perceive, remember, judge, intend, own, and act as a collective agent. Not every crowd or mechanically solidary field reaches this threshold.

The relationship is generative rather than an equation:

```

LOCAL BIGOTHERS
sentiment classifiers executing installed lenses
      ↓ communicate through
SHARED SYMBOLIC PROTOCOL / LACANIAN BIG OTHER
      ↓ may generate
MECHANICAL-SOLIDARITY COHERENCE
      ↓ maintains
DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER
      ↓ may become sufficiently integrated as
MULTI-MIND-SELF

```

The distributed bigOther consists of no single person or object. It is realized through language, expectations, public symbols, rituals, stories, institutions, roles, laws, artifacts, and the anticipated judgments of other people. It is implemented through individuals but, as an emergent relational organization, is not adequately explained as a mere list of independently formed individual psychologies.

The relation remains recursive:

```

DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER
mythologies, institutions, symbols, rituals, expectations
      ↓ programs and activates
LOCAL BIGOTHERS
      ↓ influence
ELEPHANTS AND MAIN CPUs
      ↓ produce
PUBLIC SIGNALS AND INSTITUTIONAL PRACTICES
      ↓ reproduce or transform
DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER
      ↺

```

Culture is neither wholly outside nor wholly inside the person. It is the comparatively stable pattern maintained by this circulation between local programming and distributed execution. First-order and **lifted mechanical solidarity** differ in the abstraction level of their shared classifications, not in this basic field-forming mechanism. [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#) develops that distinction together with field geometry, collective ownership, gatekeepers, and back-action upon epistemic agency.

13. Symbolic reality

The bigOther does not merely evaluate an independently completed physical world. It also participates in creating **social reality**.

A piece of cloth becomes a flag. A person becomes a judge, citizen, traitor, hero, or martyr. An utterance becomes a promise, verdict, oath, insult, or declaration of war. A place becomes sacred. A relationship becomes a marriage. An individual becomes the bearer of rights and dignity.

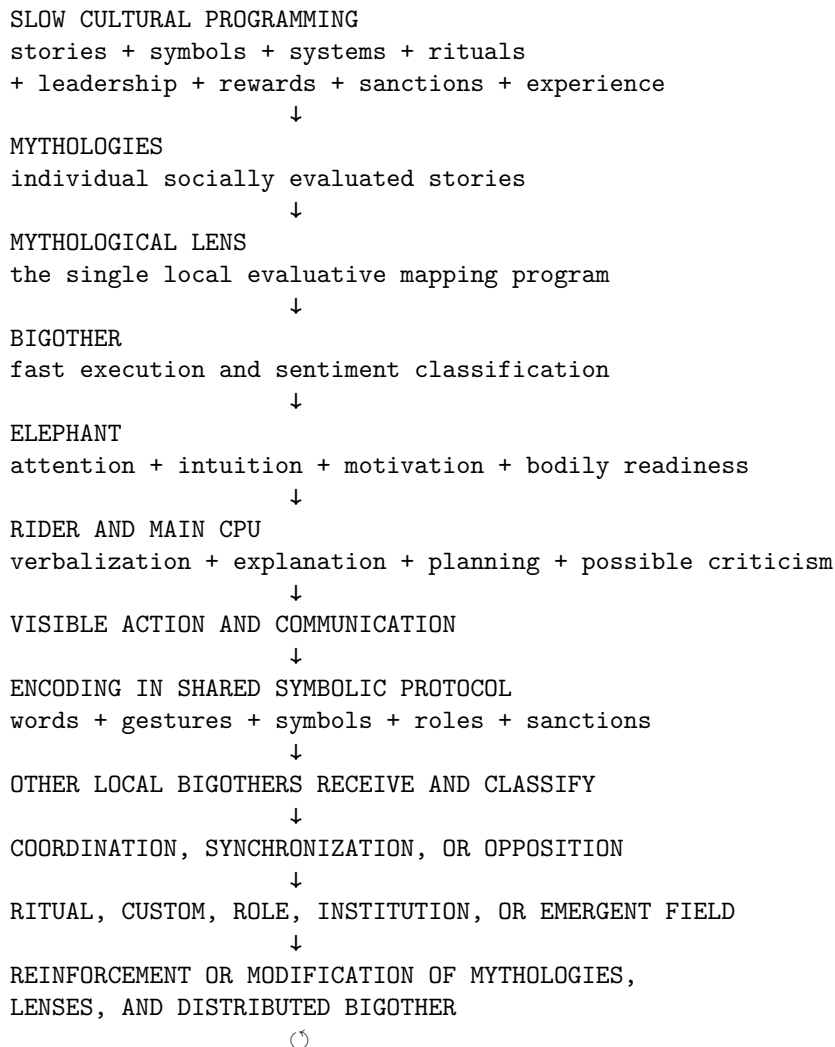
These properties are not inherent physical properties, but neither are they merely private fantasies. They are real insofar as people and institutions collectively recognize and act upon them. Symbols, rituals, and authorized classifications therefore do not only represent society; their execution helps constitute society.

Culture mechanics calls attention to both directions:

1. society programs the local bigOther; and
2. locally classified action reproduces or transforms society.

14. The full culture-mechanical cycle

The complete process can be summarized as follows:



This cycle deliberately stops at the individual-to-field boundary. *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity* asks how the emergent field acts back upon judgment, distributes authority, and supports or suppresses epistemic agency.

15. Open and closed cultural programming

Culture mechanics is descriptive before it is normative. The same mechanisms can support an open society or a closed total community.

A **closed cultural program** forms a mythological lens that teaches the bigOther to reward:

- unanimity and obedience;
- one overriding identity;
- submission to a central authority;
- denunciation of deviants;
- fusion of factual truth with political loyalty;
- exclusion of competing institutions and sources;
- treatment of counterevidence as betrayal or pollution.

An **open cultural program** forms a mythological lens that teaches the bigOther to value second-order norms:

- every person possesses dignity;
- opponents remain legitimate members of society;
- disagreement is not automatically betrayal;
- respect for a person does not require agreement with every claim;
- evidence may correct belief;
- authority may be criticized;
- compromise can be honourable;
- multiple institutions and affiliations must remain independent;
- no person or institution may become the sole authorized voice of the bigOther.

On the single-slot model, pluralism does not mean having no shared programming or installing one independent evaluator for each affiliation. It means that one open weave can be a fully installed lifted meta-program whose shared generator admits different context-sensitive first-order outputs. Its concrete surface can vary without its authority being weaker or local: the binding sameness lies in the rules by which answers are generated, tested, applied, and revised. These rules are not a higher runtime judge ranking several bigOthers; generator and outputs form one weave. Detailed cases and boundary tests are developed in [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#).

16. Autonomy, capture, and susceptibility

Culture mechanics does not define autonomy as the absence of a bigOther. Language, morality, identity, and social cooperation all require cultural formation. Nor is autonomy the installation of a second bigOther to overrule the first. The relevant question is whether the main processor can inspect and revise the one installed lens and the bigOther's classifications. Autonomy is therefore compatible with full capture: it names an operative weave whose binding rules protect the main processor's capacity to inspect and revise its classifications, not incomplete programming or escape from the slot.

In an autonomous configuration, a person can:

- distinguish affective certainty from evidence;
- notice shame, disgust, or group pressure as signals rather than proofs;
- compare inherited classifications with direct experience;
- tolerate disagreement and temporary dissonance;
- question the authority that supplied a classification;
- revise the mythological lens when its classifications contradict evidence or experience.

Every installed program governs classification, and a lifted program necessarily has meta-authority over first-order jurisdictions. **Pathological capture** begins not with governing authority as such but when the weave or its representatives become uncorrectable, monopolize authorized interpretation, exceed their constituted jurisdiction, or claim **epistemic sovereignty**—that reality must answer to authorization rather than authorization to reality. The bigOther then determines which perceptions, questions, relationships, and feelings the main CPU may treat as legitimate. Intelligence remains available, but is recruited to implement or defend the installed lens.

Full capture can integrate an already compatible package, but capture by an incompatible governing worldview requires replacement. Authorities, sanctions, rituals, relationships, and field back-action must loosen the incumbent weave's load-bearing bindings, make detachment or reinterpretation survivable, and help rebraid one successor. Conversely, counter-relations and reality contact can protect or repair the incumbent weave without acting as a second evaluator. A rival successor is not pathological merely because it replaces an incumbent; its corrigibility and authority relations must be assessed independently.

Susceptibility to such capture is not treated as a single scalar trait. It can involve different degrees of:

- programmability through narratives and exemplars;
- sensitivity to approval, rejection, and unanimity;
- ease of synchronization with a group;
- identity dependence;
- affective charge and internalization;
- resistance to counterevidence;
- difficulty of reprogramming;
- practical ability to dissent or leave.

17. Synonyms and terminological neighbours of the bigOther

There is no established term that is an exact synonym for the **bigOther** as culture mechanics defines it. The term deliberately combines a local sentiment classifier, its culturally learned programming, its relation to the symbolic order, and its capacity for distributed synchronization. Existing concepts usually name only one of these aspects.

The closest everyday term is **conscience** (*Gewissen*), provided that it is understood as an affectively active moral evaluator rather than as a little rational judge inside the mind. Conscience marks conduct and even contemplated conduct with approval, guilt, shame, obligation, or prohibition. In that respect it performs part of the bigOther's sentiment-classification function.

Conscience is nevertheless narrower than the bigOther. The bigOther also classifies status, belonging, legitimacy, loyalty, sacredness, pollution, identity, and social danger, including cases that are not ordinarily described as matters of conscience. Conversely, conscience can include deliberate moral reflection performed by the main CPU, whereas the bigOther refers specifically to the fast culturally programmed evaluator that influences such reflection. Culture mechanics can therefore distinguish a **socially authored conscience**, whose judgments are largely supplied by the surrounding field, from a more **self-authored conscience**, whose inherited classifications can be examined and deliberately endorsed, rejected, or revised.

Neighbouring term	Main overlap with the bigOther	Important difference
Lacan's big Other	The prior symbolic order of language, law, roles, authority, and socially intelligible meaning; functionally, the shared protocol through which local states become publicly legible.	It is the source term, but Lacan did not describe a literal local co-processor, PCI card, or the full on-the-wire analogy. Culture mechanics adds that implementation and translation.
James's felt objective presence	A reality or unseen order may be experienced as objectively present and conduct-directing.	It illuminates bigOther-presence phenomenologically but does not specify its local processor, cultural program, or network mechanism.
Buber's I-Thou relation	Another is encountered in a second-person relational mode rather than as an object.	It illuminates bigOther-as-Thou but must not be reduced to social programming; Buber's eternal Thou is not the culture-mechanical bigOther.
Conscience / Gewissen	Internal moral approval, guilt, shame, obligation, and prohibition.	It is the closest ordinary-language partial synonym, but is narrower than the bigOther and can also include reflective moral judgment by the CPU.
Superego	Internalized authority, prohibitions, ideals, guilt, and demands placed upon the self.	It emphasizes a psychoanalytic intrapsychic agency, often especially its punitive aspect; it does not by itself denote the full symbolic network or distributed computation.
Generalized other	George Herbert Mead's organized attitudes and expectations of a community that a person learns to take toward the self.	It closely describes the social standpoint represented locally, but not the proposed dual-processor architecture or its primitive affective interface.
Collective conscience / collective consciousness	Durkheim's shared beliefs and sentiments, with their moral authority over group members.	It is closest to the distributed bigOther; it does not isolate the local sentiment-classification unit through which collective sentiments become personally operative.
Internalized norms, moral schemas, and moral identity	Learned evaluative rules, expectations, and identity commitments.	These are components of the mythological lens executed by the bigOther rather than names for the processor, the narrative corpus, and the network together.

Neighbouring term	Main overlap with the bigOther	Important difference
Habitus	Social history embodied as durable perception, feeling, and action dispositions.	It is broader than moral-social classification and does not posit a single-slot evaluator or a separate general-purpose CPU.
Socialized mind and ego development	Describe developmental relations to social expectations, internal standards, and one's own meaning-making system.	They describe organizations or levels of the whole person, not an additional processor. They are developmental neighbours of the bigOther, not synonyms for it.

The vocabulary should therefore be used with the following rule:

Conscience, superego, generalized other, collective conscience, felt objective presence, and I-Thou relation each illuminate an aspect of the bigOther; none alone names the complete culture-mechanical construct.

18. Development of the bigOther: Kegan and Loevinger

Culture mechanics treats the bigOther as developmentally variable. A person is not born with a completed mythological lens. Social evaluation is first encountered through attachment, imitation, direct reward and punishment, and dependence on caregivers. It is then internalized as group-authored conscience and may later become available for self-authorship and reflective revision.

[Robert Kegan's constructive-developmental theory](#) and [Jane Loevinger's ego-development research](#) provide the closest developmental models found in the surrounding conversations, but neither proposed a bigOther. Kegan's subject-object theory describes increasingly complex **forms of mind** or **meaning-making**, not merely moral conscience. Loevinger's theory describes development of the **ego** across impulse control, character, interpersonal understanding, conscious preoccupations, and moral evaluation. The culture-mechanical model below is consequently a synthesis and translation, not a claim that either theorist described the wireless collar.

The key developmental question is:

Is the mythological lens something the person can look at and revise, or is it the unquestioned lens through which the person looks?

This is Kegan's subject-object distinction applied specifically to cultural sentiment classification. What remains **subject** to a person has the person: it organizes experience but cannot yet be examined as an object. What becomes **object** can be noticed, compared, evaluated, and acted upon. Development of the bigOther therefore does not primarily mean that the collar becomes stronger. It means that the homo-duplex system gains a more complex and reflective relation to the lens stored in the collar.

A four-phase culture-mechanical model

Culture-mechanical phase	Closest Keganian neighbour	Closest Loevingerian neighbour	Relation to the bigOther
1. Installation and external regulation	Impulsive and instrumental forms of mind	Impulsive and Self-Protective stages	Social control is experienced mainly through immediate attachment, advantage, reward, retaliation, and punishment. A stable moral-social lens is still being installed; much of its authority remains visibly outside the person.

Culture-mechanical phase	Closest Keganian neighbour	Closest Loevingerian neighbour	Relation to the bigOther
2. Socially authored bigOther	Socialized Mind	Conformist and transitional Self-Aware levels	Group expectations, authorities, relationships, and accepted roles become internally binding. The person can subordinate impulse to shared rules, but has difficulty standing apart from the social field that defines what ought to feel admirable, shameful, loyal, or forbidden. Borrowed judgment is experienced as one's own obvious conscience.
3. Self-authored bigOther	Self-Authoring Mind	Conscientious stage	The person constructs an internal code and can use it to evaluate competing external demands. The main CPU can identify, endorse, and deliberately revise at least some mappings in the installed lens. The bigOther remains present, but its lens is increasingly governed from within rather than continuously authored by the current group.
4. Self-transforming bigOther	Self-Transforming Mind	Individualistic transition, Autonomous stage, and the rare Integrated stage	The person can take even a self-authored value system as object, recognize its partial and constructed character, tolerate conflicts among frameworks, and revise the meta-rules by which classifications are made. The lens can include its own corrigibility without dissolving all commitments.

These are correspondences, not one-to-one equations. In particular, Loevinger's **Conscientious** stage is not simply "having a conscience"; it is a comparatively developed organization characterized by self-evaluated standards, responsibility, long-term goals, and evaluation of rules rather than mere acceptance of group rules. Her **Individualistic** level is a transition from Conscientious to Autonomous, and the Autonomous and Integrated levels add tolerance of inner conflict, ambiguity, interdependence, and increasingly integrated identity. Kegan describes a related shift in different terms: from being authored by relationships and the surrounding culture, to authoring an internal system, to being able to inspect the limitations of that system itself.

Development under the single-slot principle Development does not install additional bigOthers beside the first one. The computer still has one PCI slot, one operative sentiment-classification architecture, and therefore one fully occupied slot. What changes is the person's relation to the installed card and, during lifting, the order of the rules it runs:

EXTERNALLY ENFORCED LENS

the environment supplies immediate reward and punishment



SOCIALLY AUTHORED LENS

the group's judgments operate internally as obvious conscience



SELF-AUTHORED LENS

the person can evaluate social demands through an internal code



SELF-TRANSFORMING LENS

the person can inspect and revise even the code and its meta-rules

A self-transforming person can represent several moral systems in the main CPU, translate between them, and understand each from within. This does not require several PCI cards running independently or a higher evaluator that ranks them at runtime. Until reconstruction occurs, one local bigOther still executes one operative lens. The developmental achievement is that the person can treat this present lens as partial, corrigible, and open to deliberate repair, compatible extension, unbraiding, or replacement.

Self-transformation can therefore unbraid a first-order program whose concrete answers are treated as final and rebraid one lifted program in which binding meta-rules generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers. First-order religious, professional, familial, political, or local packages need not vanish; their particular rules and conclusions remain within the successor weave as outputs or bounded packages answerable to its generator. This is full lifted capture, not a neutral evaluator standing above culture.

Nor does greater autonomy require disconnection from distributed computing. The socially authored person is especially liable to be synchronized by whichever reference group carries authority. The self-authoring person can choose commitments and networks from an internal standpoint. The self-transforming person can participate in collective life without assuming that any single network exhausts reality, and can sometimes translate between networks without simply fusing with either one.

The “less than 1%” claim The recollection that the most developed Keganian form occurs in fewer than one percent of adults is supported, with an attribution caveat. A peer-reviewed account by Lars Bauger, Rob Bongaardt, and Jack J. Bauer reports that, **according to Kegan and Lahey (2009)**, approximately 80–90% of adults make meaning between the Socialized and Self-Authored levels, while the Self-Transforming Mind is “seldom seen (less than 1%).” The estimate is therefore appropriately attributed to **Kegan and Lahey’s framework**, while the directly checkable wording appears in [Bauger, Bongaardt, and Bauer’s 2021 article](#).

This figure should be treated as a reported developmental estimate, not as a population census, a biological constant, or a direct measurement of the bigOther. It concerns Kegan’s highest whole-person meaning-making structure. Culture mechanics translates that structure into the capacity to take one’s own mythological lens as object; it does not claim that Kegan measured a collar processor or that exactly the same percentage applies across all societies and methods.

Developmental cautions Developmental complexity is not identical to intelligence, factual correctness, kindness, mental health, or moral worth. A powerful CPU does not guarantee a self-authored relation to the bigOther. Conversely, a self-authored person can construct and defend a cruel or epistemically contaminated code. Development describes increasing capacity to author and inspect a framework; the content and consequences of that framework must still be evaluated independently.

The highest phase should also not be understood as the disappearance of conscience. Its defining feature is **reflective ownership without finalization**: the person can retain commitments, feel moral sentiments, and participate in a culture while knowing that the framework producing those classifications is neither infallible nor complete.

19. Cross-references to closely related concepts

The following concepts overlap with parts of culture mechanics without being synonyms for the theory as a whole.

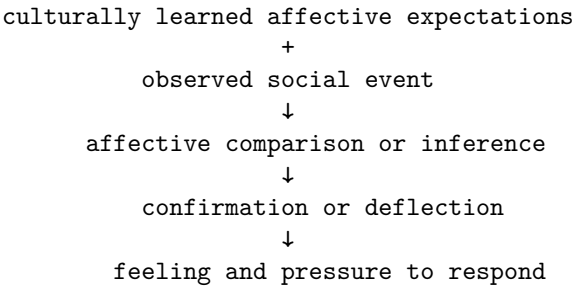
Affect Control Theory and BayesACT **Affect Control Theory** (ACT) and its probabilistic extension **BayesACT** provide a formal computational neighbour to the culture-mechanical account of the mythological lens. ACT models culturally learned affective meanings—called **fundamental sentiments**—attached to identities, actions, and settings. An

observed social event produces a **transient impression**, which is compared with these culturally expected meanings. The resulting discrepancy is called **deflection**. Deflection generates pressure toward emotion, reinterpretation, identity adjustment, or corrective action that restores affective consistency.

The correspondence is:

Culture mechanics	ACT/BayesACT
Mythological lens	Culturally learned fundamental sentiments and impression-formation rules.
Real-world observation or event	An observed actor–behaviour–object event producing a transient impression.
bigOther classification	Comparison of the transient meaning with culturally expected meaning.
Affective signal	Confirmation or deflection—the discrepancy between expected and observed meaning.
Resulting response	Emotion, reinterpretation, identity adjustment, or corrective action.

BayesACT adds uncertain beliefs about identities and situations, Bayesian updating, explicit goals, and decision-theoretic action selection. In culture-mechanical terms, it offers one possible formalization of how an installed cultural mapping could combine with an observation to produce affective confirmation or error and consequent pressure on feeling and action:



This is a cross-reference rather than a foundation of culture mechanics. ACT and BayesACT do not propose a separate bigOther, a single PCI slot, mythological narrative programming, or distributed synchronization. They also do not explain how mythologies initially form the mythological lens. BayesACT’s instrumental action selection extends beyond the primitive sentiment-classification function assigned to the collar and overlaps with planning functions that culture mechanics assigns to the main CPU.

Stanovich’s rationality framework Keith E. Stanovich, Richard F. West, and Maggie E. Toplak distinguish rationality from intelligence and describe cognition with a **tripartite model**:

- The **autonomous mind** produces rapid, automatic, highly practised, or evolutionarily prepared responses.
- The **algorithmic mind** supplies computational capacity for sustained processing, inhibition, and cognitive simulation. Conventional intelligence tests primarily track capacities at this level.
- The **reflective mind** concerns goals, epistemic values, thinking dispositions, and the decision to initiate reflective processing or override a default response.

This tripartite division should not be mapped one-to-one onto homo duplex. In culture mechanics, all three Stanovichian minds describe operations performed within the ordinary brain—the main cognitive system represented by the CPU, elephant, and rider. The bigOther is an additional functional distinction: a culturally programmable sentiment classifier coupled to that system.

The most faithful architectural mapping is:

Stanovichian term	Function in Stanovich’s model	Closest culture-mechanical location
Autonomous mind	Generates fast default responses	Part of the main brain and especially the elephant; it is influenced by, but is not identical to, the bigOther.

Stanovichian term	Function in Stanovich's model	Closest culture-mechanical location
Algorithmic mind	Supplies computational power, decoupling, inhibition, and simulation	The processing power of the main CPU.
Reflective mind	Establishes goals and epistemic dispositions and initiates override	The governing and self-corrective activity of the main CPU, represented partly by the rider.
Mindware	Provides learned knowledge, rules, procedures, and strategies for reasoning	General acquired programming available to the main CPU; mythologies may carry mindware, while their culturally evaluative lessons can be compiled into the bigOther's mythological lens.

This prevents two misleading equations:

The autonomous mind is **not** the bigOther.

Mindware in general is **neither a mythology nor the mythological lens**.

Probability theory, falsification, causal reasoning, and decision rules are mindware used by the main CPU without necessarily belonging to the bigOther. A mythology is a culturally evaluated story and may carry many kinds of mindware. The mythological lens is narrower than mindware in general: it is the mapping distilled from many mythologies that organizes social identity and sentiment classification.

Mindware gaps and other rationality failures A **mindware gap** exists when a person lacks a learned rule or body of knowledge required for rational judgment. Someone may possess ample algorithmic capacity but not understand base rates, regression to the mean, falsification, or probabilistic reasoning. In culture-mechanical language, the main CPU is powerful enough, but lacks the corrective program needed to evaluate or override a default response.

Stanovich's taxonomy separates this from several other failures:

Failure	Stanovichian description	Culture-mechanical translation
Cognitive miserliness	Reflective processing is not initiated; an easy default is accepted.	The CPU does not spend the effort needed to inspect the elephant's response or the collar's classification.
Override failure	Reflective processing begins and relevant mindware exists, but the default response is not successfully suppressed.	The CPU detects a problem but fails to overcome the elephant's or bigOther's strongly weighted response.
Mindware gap	The alternative knowledge or rule needed for a rational response is absent or insufficiently learned.	The CPU lacks the epistemic tool needed to correct the response.
Contaminated mindware	Acquired mindware itself causes irrational belief or action.	In the culture-mechanical use developed here, the bigOther executes a defective lens that generates misdirecting sentiments and protects its mappings from evaluation.

These failures can combine. A contaminated bigOther may discourage the reflective mind from initiating inspection, make affective override more difficult, and prevent missing corrective mindware from being learned.

Contaminated mindware as a badly programmed bigOther In Stanovich's framework, **contaminated mindware** is acquired mindware that directly causes irrational belief or action—either by reducing epistemic accuracy or by thwarting effective goal pursuit. It can include superstitious thinking, antiscience attitudes, conspiracy beliefs, dysfunctional personal beliefs, misleading causal models, and culturally conditioned misinformation.

Stanovich gives special attention to mindware containing **evaluation-disabling properties**. Such mindware keeps itself lodged in a host by attaching punishment to questioning, rewarding unquestioning acceptance, or making itself unfalsifiable. This aspect provides the strongest direct bridge to culture mechanics because punishment, reward, and protected sacredness are operations of the bigOther's sentiment-classification system.

Following the present theory's guidance, culture mechanics adopts the term in this more specific functional sense:

Contaminated mindware is a badly programmed bigOther: contaminated mythologies have shaped a defective mythological lens whose classifications attach strong sentiments to thoughts and evidence in ways that systematically misguide the main CPU.

The defective lens may mark:

- a false claim as sacred truth;
- honest doubt as betrayal;
- reliable evidence as enemy contamination;
- asymmetric scrutiny as moral vigilance;
- cruelty as righteous duty;
- correction as humiliation or surrender;
- loyalty to a source as a substitute for evaluating its claims.

The contamination lies in both **content** and **control**. Individual mythologies can carry misleading claims, roles, causal explanations, or anti-evaluation procedures. Repetition compiles those lessons into a defective lens, while the bigOther executes the lens and thereby determines how entertaining, questioning, revising, or rejecting them feels. Pride, shame, sacredness, belonging, authority, disgust, fear, and anticipated punishment protect the defective lens.

The resulting causal sequence is:

```
CONTAMINATED BIGOTHER PROGRAMMING
misleading mythologies + evaluation-disabling procedures
↓
DEFECTIVE MYTHOLOGICAL LENS
misdirected mappings from observations to values and feelings
↓
STRONG AFFECTIVE MISCLASSIFICATION
false feels sacred, doubt feels disloyal,
harm feels righteous, correction feels shameful
↓
REFLECTIVE INHIBITION OR FAILED OVERRIDE
the CPU does not inspect, cannot overcome, or lacks corrective mindware
↓
MOTIVATED OR MYSIDE REASONING
selective search, asymmetric scrutiny, rationalization, and defence
↓
IRRATIONAL BELIEF OR ACTION
reduced epistemic accuracy or frustrated goal attainment
```

The phrase “wrong direction” should be tied to Stanovich's standards of rationality rather than merely to disagreement with an observer. A bigOther is contaminated when its lens systematically impairs:

- **epistemic rationality:** forming beliefs that are appropriately calibrated to evidence and reality; or
- **instrumental rationality:** acting effectively in pursuit of the person's considered goals.

Political, religious, or moral disagreement alone is not evidence of contaminated mindware. The diagnosis requires such features as demonstrable epistemic failure, goal-thwarting consequences, asymmetric standards, or procedures that disable evaluation.

The extension and its boundary The synchronization can now be stated precisely:

- **Stanovich supplies the cognitive pathology:** harmful acquired knowledge and strategies can cause irrationality even when computational intelligence is adequate.

- **Culture mechanics assigns that pathology a location in its dual architecture:** when contaminated mindware is cultural, identity-laden, and affectively enforced, it becomes part of a defective mythological lens executed by the bigOther.
- **Culture mechanics adds a causal interface:** the contaminated bigOther misguides the main CPU by attaching strong feelings to its thoughts and possible conclusions.
- **Culture mechanics adds a distributed mechanism:** networked bigOthers reward, punish, repeat, and synchronize contaminated mythologies and lens mappings across people.
- **Motivated or myside reasoning is usually downstream:** the main CPU is recruited to protect the direction already weighted by the bigOther.

This is a faithful extension, not a claim that Stanovich proposed a bigOther, a wireless collar, homo duplex, or distributed cultural computation. His category is broader: contaminated mindware need not always be socially synchronized or strongly affective. Culture mechanics deliberately concentrates on the subset for which the acquired contamination has entered the mythological lens of the sentiment classifier.

Conversely, not every mythology produces contaminated mindware, and no single story normally determines an entire lens. Mythologies can instead teach intellectual honesty, falsifiability, evidential symmetry, uncertainty, and willingness to revise. An open culture can thereby form a lens that makes reality-oriented conduct feel honourable and correction tolerable rather than misdirecting the CPU away from them.

Dysrationalia **Dysrationalia** is Stanovich's term for irrational thought or behaviour despite adequate intelligence. It is closely related to the homo-duplex thesis because it rejects the assumption that a powerful main CPU guarantees rational judgment.

Culture mechanics proposes one possible social-affective pathway to dysrationalia: the bigOther can set priorities, prohibit questions, or make accurate revision socially painful while leaving general intelligence intact. Dysrationalia is nevertheless broader. It can also result from mindware gaps, cognitive miserliness, poor thinking dispositions, or failures to initiate reflective processing.

Motivated reasoning **Motivated reasoning** is the tendency for desired conclusions, identities, loyalties, or emotional needs to influence how evidence is sought, interpreted, remembered, and evaluated.

In culture mechanics, motivated reasoning is not itself the bigOther. It is what the main CPU may do after the bigOther has marked one conclusion as honourable, safe, identity-preserving, or socially rewarded and another as shameful, dangerous, or disloyal. The CPU's power can then increase the sophistication of the rationalization rather than correct its direction.

Not every instance of reasoning from one's existing perspective is irrational. Prior beliefs may deserve evidential weight, and revising an established model has real cognitive costs. The culture-mechanical concern is the narrower case in which the bigOther enforces asymmetric or evaluation-disabling treatment of evidence and thereby reduces epistemic or instrumental rationality.

Identity-protective cognition **Identity-protective cognition** is motivated reasoning specifically directed toward protecting membership, status, or alignment within an identity-defining group. It is one of the closest empirical neighbours of the wireless-collar model.

The bigOther supplies an internalized audience and asks, in effect:

What would accepting this evidence say about who I am, whose side I am on, and whether I still belong?

The person may consequently reject an accurate conclusion not because it exceeds the main CPU's capacity, but because accepting it would trigger shame, loss of status, or symbolic expulsion.

Moral conviction, sacred values, and taboo trade-offs **Moral conviction** occurs when a preference or belief is experienced as a matter of fundamental right and wrong rather than negotiable interest. A **sacred value** is protected from ordinary comparison or exchange. A **taboo trade-off** is a comparison whose mere consideration is treated as morally offensive.

These concepts describe classifications produced by the bigOther when it assigns exceptional moral authority to an object or rule. They help explain why compromise can feel like corruption and why cost-benefit reasoning can provoke outrage rather than deliberation. They also distinguish an ordinary strong preference from programming that determines what the main CPU is permitted even to compare.

Actively open-minded thinking and epistemic autonomy **Actively open-minded thinking** is the disposition to search for reasons one may be wrong, consider alternatives, apply standards symmetrically, and revise beliefs in response to evidence. It is a form of healthy mindware and a partial operational counterpart to what culture mechanics calls **epistemic autonomy**.

Epistemic autonomy does not require the absence of a bigOther. It requires a mythological lens that permits the main CPU to inspect the bigOther's outputs and that does not convert doubt, correction, or uncertainty automatically into shame and betrayal.

Actively open-minded thinking predicts resistance to many reasoning errors and forms of contaminated mindware, but it should not be treated as a universal antidote. Stanovich's work finds myside bias unusually resistant to prediction by intelligence and, in several paradigms, by actively open-minded-thinking measures themselves.

Master signifiers In Lacanian terminology, a **master signifier** is a privileged signifier that organizes other meanings and identifications. Words such as *Nation, Justice, Science, Tradition, Safety, Freedom, or Revolution* can function in this way.

A master signifier is not inherently contaminated. It becomes a carrier of contaminated mindware when invoking it terminates evaluation rather than organizing an inquiry—for example, when “Science” changes from the name of a corrigible method into an authority token that makes further judgment impermissible.

In the wireless-collar and protocol analogies, a master signifier is a **highly compressed protocol token**. It indexes a large package of already installed mythologies, classifications, authorities, identities, sentiments, and expected conduct without restating them. This explains both its efficiency and its danger: participants can coordinate through a short token, but the expansion it activates may remain unspoken and therefore difficult to inspect.

Bonhoeffer's Dummheit Dietrich Bonhoeffer's 1943 reflection “[Von der Dummheit](#)” (PDF of the complete section) is the starting point of the culture-mechanics theory. It posed the originating questions: **What causes this Dummheit? How does it work?**

The German original reads:

Jede starke äußere Machtentfaltung, sei sie politischer oder religiöser Art, schlägt einen großen Teil der Menschen mit Dummheit. Ja, es hat den Anschein, als sei das geradezu ein soziologisch-psychologisches Gesetz. Die Macht der einen braucht die Dummheit der anderen. Der Vorgang ist dabei nicht der, dass bestimmte – also etwa intellektuelle – Anlagen des Menschen plötzlich verkümmern oder ausfallen, sondern dass unter dem überwältigenden Eindruck der Machtentfaltung dem Menschen seine innere Selbständigkeit geraubt wird und dass dieser nun – mehr oder weniger unbewusst – darauf verzichtet, zu den sich ergebenden Lebenslagen ein eigenes Verhalten zu finden. Dass der Dumme oft bockig ist, darf nicht darüber hinwegtäuschen, dass er nicht selbständig ist. **Man spürt es geradezu im Gespräch mit ihm, dass man es gar nicht mit ihm selbst, mit ihm persönlich, sondern mit über ihn mächtig gewordenen Schlagworten, Parolen etc. zu tun hat. Er ist in einem Bann, er ist verblendet, er ist in seinem eigenen Wesen missbraucht, misshandelt.** So zum willenlosen Instrument geworden, wird der Dumme auch zu allem Bösen fähig sein und zugleich unfähig, dies als Böses zu erkennen. Hier liegt die Gefahr eines diabolischen Missbrauchs.

The English translation used here is:

Every powerful display of external force, whether political or religious, strikes a large portion of people with stupidity. Indeed, it appears to be almost a sociological-psychological law: the power of the few needs the stupidity of the many. The process does not consist of certain intellectual faculties suddenly withering. Rather, under the overwhelming impression of power, people are robbed of their inner independence and - more or less unconsciously - give up forming their own judgments about the situations that arise. The fact that the stupid person is often obstinate should not hide the reality that he is not acting autonomously. **In conversation one senses that one is not dealing with the person himself but with slogans and catch-phrases that have gained mastery over him. He is under a spell, blinded, his very being abused and misused.** Having become a will-less instrument, the stupid person is capable of any evil and at the same time incapable of recognizing it as evil. Here lies the danger of a diabolical misuse.

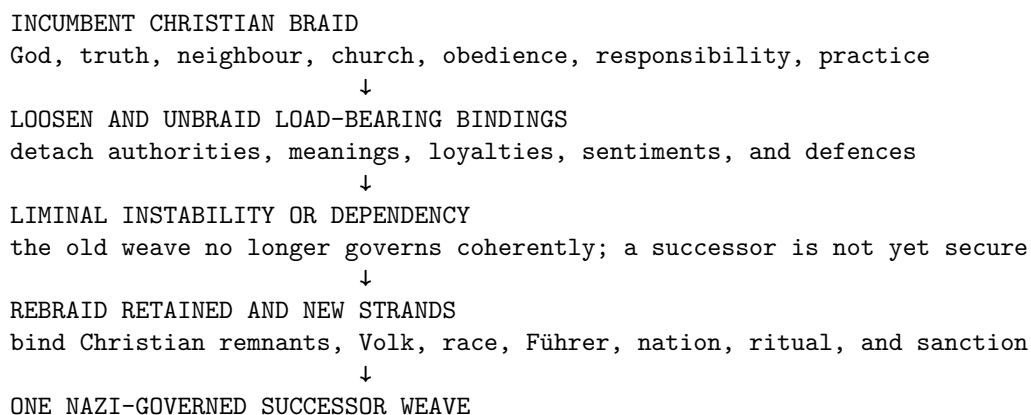
This is not a claim about low intelligence. Bonhoeffer describes a socially induced loss of inner independence in which external power, slogans, and formulas speak through a person whose ordinary intellectual abilities remain available. His *Dummheit* is therefore broader and more political than contaminated mindware.

Bonhoeffer names the phenomenon; culture mechanics proposes a mechanism. At the individual level, an intelligent person's main CPU can remain capable while the bigOther supplies the classifications, slogans, sentiments, and permissions under which that intelligence operates. *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity* develops the social-field account: mutually synchronized local bigOthers and institutional power can make borrowed judgment feel internally compulsory and thereby weaken the person's capacity to form an independent response.

The historical baseline and the theoretical application must remain distinct. The [United States Holocaust Memorial Museum's biographical account](#) documents Bonhoeffer's theological and ecumenical activity, opposition to Nazi church policy, connections to resistance, and 1943 arrest. Its broader account of [non-Jewish resistance](#) also distinguishes individual theologians such as Bonhoeffer from church hierarchies that supported or acquiesced in the regime. Those facts do not directly measure anyone's local bigOther or establish the mechanism proposed below.

The **culture-mechanical application hypothesis** is that Bonhoeffer's one local bigOther executed a densely braided Christian mythological lens to which he was deeply loyal. That Christian weave could incorporate compatible packages such as a *Berufsethos*, familial responsibility, intellectual discipline, pastoral duty, and responsibility toward the concrete neighbour. They did not stand beside Christianity as independent evaluators or compete with it for supremacy; their operative meaning was produced within the one Christianly programmed weave.

National Socialism did not offer one more compatible package. On the originating verdict stated in "The single-slot principle," its governing classifications were deeply incompatible with an intact Christian weave. Nazi capture would therefore have required replacement rather than ranking:



Where such capture succeeded in a pastor or priest, continued use of scripture, Christian vocabulary, ritual, office, or self-description would not by itself show that an intact Christian program survived below a higher-ranked Nazi program. The material could have been detached from its previous relations and rewoven into one Nazi-Christian successor lens. Whether and how this occurred in any particular person remains a historical and biographical question, not something the theory may infer from conformity alone.

The corresponding hypothesis about Bonhoeffer is that this unbraiding did not succeed. His deep loyalty, theological work, Christian practice, relationships, alternative authorities, and encounters with persecuted people may have maintained or repaired the incumbent braid. A supporting counterfield did not provide a second PCI card; it helped the installed Christian programming resist loosening and replacement. National Socialist signals could consequently be classified through that existing weave as idolatry, falsehood, or injury to the concrete neighbour rather than being processed as commands from a higher-ranked political identity. This is a proposed explanation of the historical contrast, not a direct measurement of Bonhoeffer's inner architecture or proof about clergy as a class.

Culture mechanics interprets Dummheit as a condition in which:

1. the bigOther has acquired meta-authority;
2. contaminated mindware—that is, defective mythologies and lens mappings—supplies protected beliefs, misdirected sentiments, and anti-evaluation rules;
3. social power supplies rewards, sanctions, repetition, and apparent consensus; and
4. the main CPU is recruited to execute and defend the resulting classifications.

Normopathie and political ponerology: two faces of captured culture Culture mechanics treats **Normopathie** and **political ponerology** as complementary perspectives on a captured cultural system. They are not identical concepts. They describe the same pathological configuration from different social positions:

- **Normopathie** describes the population-side result. People over-adapt to a pathological social normality and cease to recognize it as pathological. Their local bigOthers defer to authorities, prestige sources, reference groups, and apparent consensus; borrowed classifications may then crystallize into moral emotions and eventually feel like an autonomous conscience.
- **Political ponerology** describes the formation and exploitation of destructive political power. Its concepts of **spellbinders**, ponerogenic processes, and **pathocracy** provide the more precise elite-side vocabulary: manipulative, characterologically destructive, or cynically instrumental actors create, capture, intensify, administer, and profit from a pathological cultural order.

The two faces belong to one culture-mechanical “coin”: a **captured distributed bigOther**. On one face are the people living under its spell; on the other are the spellbinders and seducers who shape, exploit, and gain power from it.

SPELLBINDERS AND PATHOCRATIC ACTORS

select and manipulate mythologies, symbols, systems, and sanctions



CAPTURED MYTHOLOGICAL LENS / DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER

defines normality, virtue, loyalty, danger, and deviance



NORMOPATHIC ADAPTATION

borrowed judgment, conformity, Dummheit, denunciation, self-policing



APPARENT CONSENSUS AND DISTRIBUTED ENFORCEMENT

reward the spellbinders and strengthen their control



Systems Leadership identifies important channels through which this capture can occur. Systems, symbols, leadership behaviour, and mythologies can be selected or modified so that the resulting mythological lens maps obedience to virtue, dissent to betrayal, dependence to safety, and elite interest to the common good. Political seduction then substitutes identification and affective trust for examination: the seducer offers protection, belonging, moral certainty, or relief from responsibility while seeking access, loyalty, power, and impunity.

The normopathically adapted population is therefore not merely passive. Once local bigOthers have been synchronized, ordinary participants become the distributed execution and enforcement layer of the captured bigOther. They repeat its mythologies, display its classifications, reward conformity, punish dissent, and manufacture the apparent consensus to which other uncertain people defer. A powerful main CPU may assist this process by producing sophisticated rationalizations for directions that the bigOther has already made emotionally compulsory.

The relation is recursive rather than simply top-down. Spellbinders gain a selection advantage in a culture whose lens rewards their methods, while their control over institutions enables them to strengthen that lens. A normopathic culture can arise without a single deliberate architect through decentralized conformity, dependency, and institutional inertia; it can then be captured by ponerological actors. Conversely, a would-be spellbinder cannot sustain a pathocracy without compatible institutions and a sufficiently synchronized population.

In this synthesis, Bonhoeffer’s **Dummheit** names a characteristic loss of inner independence on the population side; **Normopathie** names the normalization and social reproduction of that condition; and political ponerology—especially **pathocracy**—names the elite formation and power process that can cultivate and exploit it.

These terms are interpretive cross-references, not interchangeable clinical diagnoses or licenses to pathologize political opponents. Normopathie and political ponerology are not standard mainstream empirical categories, and the culture-mechanical connection proposed here should not be attributed directly to Hans-Joachim Maaz or Andrzej M. Łobaczewski. Its claim is narrower: the concepts illuminate complementary positions within one possible cultural feedback loop.

Summary cross-reference table

Related concept	Primary question	Relation to culture mechanics
Autonomous mind	What fast default response is generated?	Part of the ordinary brain and elephant, not the bigOther; the collar can alter its affective inputs and direction.

Related concept	Primary question	Relation to culture mechanics
Algorithmic mind	Is there sufficient computational capacity?	Corresponds most closely to the processing power of the main CPU.
Reflective mind	Will reflective processing be initiated, and under which goals and dispositions?	Corresponds to the CPU's governing and self-corrective activity, represented partly by the rider.
Cognitive miserliness	Was reflective processing avoided?	The CPU accepts an easy response without inspecting the elephant or collar.
Override failure	Was a detected default unsuccessfully suppressed?	The CPU engages but fails to overcome a strongly weighted elephant or bigOther response.
Mindware gap	Is a rational tool missing?	The main CPU lacks the learned rule needed to construct a corrective response.
Contaminated mindware	Has acquired mindware corrupted rational judgment?	For culture mechanics, this is a bigOther executing a defective mythological lens that uses strong sentiments and evaluation-disabling rules to steer the CPU away from epistemic or instrumental rationality.
Dysrationalia	Why can adequate intelligence coexist with irrationality?	The bigOther is one possible source of direction or inhibition independent of CPU power.
Motivated reasoning	How do desired conclusions bias reasoning?	The main CPU reasons directionally under affective priorities that the bigOther may supply.
Identity-protective cognition	How does group identity bias judgment?	The wireless collar attaches belonging, status, and exclusion to conclusions.
Sacred values and taboo trade-offs	Which comparisons are morally prohibited?	The bigOther determines what may not be questioned, priced, or compromised.
Actively open-minded thinking	Can the person seek disconfirmation and revise?	Healthy mindware helps the main CPU inspect the bigOther's output.
Master signifier	Which symbol organizes a field of meaning?	A highly compressed protocol token can activate a cluster of mythologies and mappings already present in the mythological lens.
Bonhoefferian Dummheit	How does social power displace inner independence?	Describes large-scale capture of judgment by a power-saturated bigOther.
Normopathie	How does a population adapt to and reproduce a pathological normality?	Describes the population-side condition in which a captured bigOther supplies borrowed judgment, conformity, and distributed enforcement.
Political ponerology / pathocracy	How do destructive actors form, capture, and exploit political power?	Describes the elite-side actors and selection processes that can program, administer, and profit from a captured distributed bigOther.

20. Scope and terminological cautions

Culture mechanics is a proposed synthetic term, not the established name of a single accepted scientific theory. It combines ideas associated with social psychology, Durkheimian sociology, Lacanian psychoanalysis, Systems Leadership, narrative theory, cybernetics, distributed cognition, cultural evolution, and systems theory.

Its computer and wireless-collar descriptions are functional models, not claims that the brain literally contains a PCI card or a separately identifiable anatomical collar processor. Its charged-particle, field, laser, wireless, and computing comparisons describe proposed relations and generate hypotheses; they do not assert that social processes are physically electromagnetic or obey the equations of the source domains.

Its use of **homo duplex** extends Durkheim. Its use of **bigOther** operationalizes and modifies Lacan. Its protocol interpretation isolates one functional aspect of Lacan's symbolic order rather than exhausting the concept. **bigOther-presence** and **bigOther-as-Thou** borrow phenomenological cues from James and Buber without attributing the proposed processor or field mechanism to either thinker. These inherited terms name important sources of the model but should not be mistaken for exact summaries of their doctrines.

The theory's three constitutive commitments each carry an explanatory burden. The local bigOther is functionally distinct from the main CPU; the distributed field is emergent from relations among persons, communications, institutions, practices, and artifacts; and the single-slot principle permits a modular weave of compatible packages while denying parallel operative evaluators. Under the third commitment, first-order and lifted programming both fully occupy the slot; order level distinguishes shared concrete answers from a shared generator of answers; a lifted generator may govern universally while constituting limited subordinate jurisdictions; and corrigibility must be evaluated independently. These claims should produce comparative explanations and possible tests. None licenses an immaterial substance, erases the responsibility and causal contribution of biological persons, or proves that every apparent conflict of allegiance is a completed worldview replacement.

The framework also does not claim that cultural programming determines behaviour mechanically. Humans interpret, combine, resist, conceal, question, and change symbolic instructions. The model proposes structured influence, not perfect control.

Culture-mechanical object, ideological symbol, conformity signal, targeting signal, the four propagation and enforcement forms, **jealous cultural program, enforcement-exclusion duality, protection-framed jurisdictional manoeuvre**, and the combined signal-moralization-jurisdiction mechanism are project-developed constructs. The four forms are ideal types rather than a validated scale. Andrick supplies the theory of moralization attributed to him; the processor, protocol, field, jealousy, and ideology-as-hallucination extensions belong to Culture Mechanics. Whole religion classifications and the Iran end-state claim are explicit hypotheses, not facts established by the definitions themselves. [Gregory H. Stanton](#) supplies the neighbouring genocidal-process model attributed to him, not the targeting-signal definition or the culture-mechanical causal ontology.

An observed symbol does not by itself disclose the carrier's private intention, degree of belief, or complete program. The same token can be voluntary, coerced, devotional, propagating, targeting, jurisdictional, resistant, or multiply functional in different settings. Target status can be made legible through performance, absence, imposition, or attribution. The relevant evidence includes who is expected to perform the token, who assigns it, who may refuse, how absence is interpreted, what sanctions follow, which jurisdiction is claimed, and what the program does after acquiring power.

Finally, describing culture as programming does not imply that all symbolic reality is false. Money, law, office, obligation, legitimacy, and dignity are symbolically constituted but socially consequential realities. Culture mechanics distinguishes such constitutive social meanings from factual claims about physical reality, which remain answerable to evidence.

Semantic summary

- **Broader class:** theory of cultural causation and social coordination.
- **Central object:** the culturally programmed bigOther in the homo-duplex individual.
- **Primary operation:** sentiment classification.
- **Narrative unit:** one mythology—one socially evaluated narrative or story; *narrative* is the broader ordinary-language term and often its fuzzy synonym.
- **Narrative corpus:** mythologies—the accumulated stories that train cultural evaluation.
- **Installed evaluative program:** the mythological lens shaped by those mythologies and reinforced by systems, symbols, practices, and institutions.
- **Analytical umbrella:** a culture-mechanical object is a program, carrier, implementation arrangement, processor state, collective formation, or collective agent involved in cultural installation, activation, transmission, execution, synchronization, or enforcement; its subtype must be identified.
- **Religion-inclusive program category:** religions, secular ideologies, company cultures, activist movements, professional cultures, and state programmes are analyzed as members of the same broad family rather than different ontological kinds.

- **Ideological symbol:** a medium-independent socially legible token that activates an installed program and communicates a person's relation to it.
- **Conformity signal:** an ideological symbol whose performance, absence, refusal, or substitution makes conformity and deviation publicly legible.
- **Targeting signal:** a performed, omitted, imposed, or attributed socially legible token that assigns a person or population to a sanctionable out-group; an absent conformity signal can therefore become a target marker.
- **Propagation and enforcement forms:** private, collective, ideological form, and fundamentalist; these are ideal-type program configurations, not kinds of bigOther or one necessary developmental staircase.
- **Independent animation axis:** *Beseelung* describes how affectively alive and conduct-directing a program is, independently of its propagation or violence.
- **Jealous cultural program:** a program that claims exclusive allegiance and treats incompatible commitment, dissent, or exit as betrayal; single-slot exclusivity alone is not jealousy.
- **Moralized enforcement bridge:** a signal or refusal becomes character disclosure, character accusation attacks civic or social standing, solidarity distributes the judgment, and systems attach exclusion or coercion.
- **Enforcement–exclusion duality:** enforcement conditions continued inclusion, standing, access, or permitted action on conformity; exclusion is the withdrawal or denial applied to refusal, and one visible sanction can perform both operations.
- **Fundamentalist threshold:** authorization or willingness to use physical or eliminative force, not the mere presence of moral evaluation or discursive violence.
- **Genocidal escalation neighbour:** Stanton's ten overlapping processes map one possible path from classification and symbolization through discrimination, dehumanization, organization, polarization, preparation, persecution, and extermination to denial; they are not a universal ladder or a synonym for the broader culture-mechanical repertoire.
- **Local processor:** the bigOther that executes the lens.
- **Single-slot constraint:** one local bigOther executes one operative lens; no higher runtime evaluator ranks parallel bigOthers or governing worldviews.
- **Complete slot occupancy / full capture:** a stable first-order or lifted program completely occupies the one slot; *full* does not by itself mean pathological.
- **Order levels:** first-order mechanical solidarity shares concrete rules and answers; lifted mechanical solidarity shares rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers.
- **Generative relation:** fixed, installed meta-rules combine with current knowledge or inputs and a situation to generate a binding first-order output; generator and output remain parts of one weave.
- **Jurisdictional distinction:** a lifted meta-order may govern universally at its own level while persons, offices, institutions, communities, and contracting parties remain plural and domain-limited beneath it; that pluralism is a consequence or application, not the definition of lifting.
- **Corrigibility axis:** first-order and lifted captures can each be open or closed; epistemic sovereignty, correction failure, interpretive monopoly, and jurisdictional spillover—not rivalry alone—mark pathology.
- **Package compositionality:** compatible religious, professional, familial, national, and local packages can be braided into that one complex lens.
- **Replacement under incompatibility:** an incompatible governing program must be rejected, or the incumbent weave must be unbraided sufficiently for one successor to be rebraided and installed.
- **Phenomenological appearance:** bigOther-presence or bigOther-as-Thou—the collective or symbolic authority encountered as an objectively present Other.
- **Immediate target:** the elephant—the intuitive, motivational, largely nonconscious mind.
- **Conscious interface:** the rider and the main CPU.
- **Shared communication interface:** Lacan's big Other, functionally translated as the on-the-wire symbolic protocol.
- **Network operation:** reciprocal signalling through the protocol and possible synchronization.
- **Field coherence:** mechanical solidarity.
- **Emergent network state:** the distributed bigOther.
- **Possible collective agent:** the multi-mind-self when integration and continuity pass the relevant threshold.
- **Long-term result:** reproduction or transformation of culture through ritual and institutionalization.
- **Central normative problem:** whether the bigOther remains contestable by reflective judgment or acquires final authority over it.
- **Developmental axis:** externally enforced → socially authored → self-authored → self-transforming bigOther.

Example of use

From the perspective of **culture mechanics**, the ceremony did not merely communicate the organization's values. It reenacted and reinforced particular mythologies, strengthened corresponding mappings in each participant's mythological lens, and made the bigOthers' resulting sentiments collectively observable.

Compact formulas

Single-slot composition and replacement:

one PCI slot → one local bigOther → one operative mythological lens; compatible packages → one braided program; incompatible governing worldview → rejection or incumbent unbraiding → liminal interval → one rebraided successor

Order, jurisdiction, and lifting:

one fully occupied slot × {shared concrete rules and answers | shared answer-generating meta-rules} × {corrigible | pathological}; fixed M + current K_t + situation C → binding R_t(C); lifting may enable plural first-order outputs and bounded jurisdictions without creating a second bigOther

Conformity and targeting signals, moralization, and enforcement–exclusion:

ideological program → performed, omitted, imposed, or attributed token → conformity, refusal, or target status becomes observable → character disclosure and accusation → distributed judgment → enforcement through inclusion, exclusion, coercion, or violence → defence or expansion of jurisdiction

Full culture-mechanical cycle:

mythologies shape the mythological lens → the local bigOther maps observations onto social feelings → the elephant moves → the rider explains or questions → behaviour is encoded in the shared symbolic protocol → other local bigOthers classify and respond → an emergent field acts back upon its participants → distributed synchronization reproduces or transforms culture # Epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity

epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity *noun phrase*

Status: proposed synthetic term and field of analysis

Fields: social epistemology, moral psychology, social psychology, developmental psychology, sociology of knowledge, sociology of morality, political psychology, cultural theory

Short definition

Epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity is the capacity of a socially formed and epistemically dependent person to judge, test, and revise beliefs while living inside an emergent symbolic-affective field that already supplies shared meanings, trusted authorities, legitimate institutions, and social rules about what may count as knowledge.

The term describes a tension rather than an escape from society. Human beings cannot verify everything personally. They must rely on testimony, experts, professions, records, and institutions. At the same time, networked local bigOthers can synchronize around particular **master signifiers**, narratives, authorities, and institutional **gatekeepers**. The resulting field is implemented through persons and communication but is not merely a sum of independently formed psychologies: its organized public signals, institutions, expectations, and sanctions act back upon each participant. Authorization can thereby begin to replace evaluation.

The field is not automatically a collective agent. Under sufficiently integrated conditions it can become a **multi-mind-self** capable of continuous judgment, action, and unitary ownership through many *beseelte* persons. A recurrent but non-universal topology places a comparatively uniform audience before an elevated teacher, leader, or institutional voice; common attention, narrative, authority, and mutual awareness can then produce an unusually receptive programming state. The same geometry can transmit truthful education or propaganda.

The healthy form is **corrigible epistemic dependence**: authorities are trusted provisionally, within a domain, because they provide access to evidence and methods that remain open to correction. The pathological form is **authority-gated belief updating**: a claim is admitted or rejected primarily according to whether it carries the signature of a socially authorized person, office, institution, identity, or narrative. This produces **asymmetric epistemic permeability**—high openness to authorized claims and low openness to direct evidence or elementary checks

arriving through an unauthorized route. A person can therefore be easy to persuade from inside the authorized structure and extraordinarily difficult to correct from outside it.

The corresponding developmental achievement is **epistemic adulthood**. It does not mean distrusting all institutions or becoming intellectually self-sufficient. It means gaining enough reflective distance from one's socialization and its mechanical-solidarity field to inspect the inherited architecture of trust itself: why an authority is trusted, where its jurisdiction ends, what could defeat its claims, whether its sources are genuinely independent, and whether legitimacy has been confused with truth. In the specialized sense used here, the freedom thereby achieved is **cognitive liberty**.

Under the single-slot principle this freedom remains a **full capture**: one operative weave still completely occupies the local bigOther. Emancipation can lift that weave from shared concrete answers to shared rules for generating, selecting, applying, and revising answers. Particular beliefs, offices, and institutions can then vary within one binding generator. Order level, complete occupancy, jurisdiction, and corrigibility remain separate properties.

The positive norm is **piety toward the real**: models, narratives, authorities, and even one's own conviction must remain answerable to a reality capable of surprising and correcting them. The practical problem is how to help people recover this reality-responsive judgment without merely recruiting them into a closed successor solidarity with different but equally preemptive gatekeepers. **MCIP**—Mirror, Cut, Invite, Promise—is one proposed micro-method: preserve the person, expose a precise discrepancy, return authorship, and make independent inquiry socially and practically survivable.

In one sentence:

Epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity is the socially situated ability to use inherited communities and institutions as corrigible instruments of knowledge without allowing their authority to become the final permissioning layer for reality.

Long definition

1. General meaning

The term names the relation between two facts:

1. **Knowledge is socially dependent.** No person can personally reproduce all observations, calculations, experiments, historical investigations, or technical judgments on which modern life depends.
2. **The social structures that transmit knowledge also form judgment.** They teach people whom to trust, which questions are respectable, which institutions have jurisdiction, which symbols carry legitimacy, and which doubts feel shameful, dangerous, or disloyal.

Epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity asks what remains of personal judgment after this necessary social formation has taken place. Its central question is not whether a person is influenced by culture. Everyone is. It is whether the person's culturally inherited trust architecture can itself become an object of reflection and correction.

The object of analysis is therefore neither an isolated cognitive trait nor an accusation of gullibility. It is a **person–culture–authority relationship**. It includes:

- the person's dependence on testimony and expertise;
- the collective formation of meanings and sentiments;
- the distribution of epistemic authority across persons, roles, institutions, and channels;
- the narratives and symbols by which authority is legitimized;
- the dispositions that regulate trust, doubt, and closure;
- the social costs of disagreement, checking, and exit;
- the routes through which reality can correct the resulting mental model.

The term belongs inside the broader proposed framework of *Culture Mechanics*, which begins with the homo-duplex individual: the main CPU, the local bigOther, its mythological lens, and the shared symbolic protocol through which local states become socially legible. This entry begins at the next causal level. It asks how networked local bigOthers generate mechanical-solidarity coherence and a distributed bigOther, how that field acts back upon its participants, and under what conditions it becomes a multi-mind-self. *Culture mechanics* in this sense is a term of this synthesis, not the name of an established academic theory. Epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity concentrates on one particular output of that machinery: **who or what is permitted to determine what a person treats as real**.

Exact culture-implementation practice belongs to Macdonald, Burke, and Stewart's [Systems Leadership: Creating Positive Organisations](#). This entry addresses the narrower epistemic and collective-field consequences of such cultural formation rather than restating that practical method.

2. Semantic anatomy of the term

Each word performs necessary work.

Epistemic **Epistemic** concerns belief, knowledge, evidence, justification, inquiry, uncertainty, and correction. It distinguishes this topic from agency in the general sense of being able to choose or act.

The relevant object is not merely the truth value of individual sentences. People act through larger mental models: classifications, causal structures, expectations, narratives, and predictions. A communication can contain many true statements while inducing a distorted model through selective framing. Epistemic evaluation must therefore ask whether the installed model adequately tracks the relevant structure of reality.

Agency **Agency** is the effective capacity to participate in the authorship of one's own beliefs and trust relations. It includes the ability to:

- distinguish evidence from social authorization;
- recognize uncertainty rather than filling every gap immediately;
- ask what would count against a favored claim;
- perform available low-cost checks;
- compare explanations and causal stories;
- inspect the jurisdiction, incentives, record, and correction mechanisms of authorities;
- tolerate the emotional and social discomfort of disagreement;
- revise both a belief and the standards by which the belief was previously judged.

Agency is more than the legal permission to think freely. A person may be formally free while remaining unable to question the classifications through which freedom itself becomes intelligible. Agency also requires practical access to alternatives, emotional tolerance for dissonance, and some ability to survive the social consequences of independent judgment.

Under **Under** indicates situatedness, not necessarily oppression. A person exercises judgment *under* inherited language, institutions, roles, authorities, dependencies, and collective sentiments. These structures can support or impair agency. The preposition avoids two false pictures: the isolated knower who owes nothing to society, and the completely determined subject who possesses no capacity for reflection.

Mechanical solidarity **Mechanical solidarity**, introduced by the French sociologist **Émile Durkheim** in [De la division du travail social \(1893\)](#), is social cohesion produced through shared beliefs and sentiments and the felt moral authority of the collective consciousness. Durkheim contrasts it analytically with **organic solidarity**, which arises from differentiation, specialization, and interdependence in a division of labour.

Culture mechanics interprets mechanical solidarity as an **emergent symbolic-affective field**: compatible local bigOthers repeatedly communicate, observe, answer, reward, and sanction one another until common classifications acquire organized force beyond any isolated encounter. The field exists through persons, language, practices, institutions, and artifacts, but its relational organization acts back upon the persons who implement it. This field vocabulary and mechanism are proposed here; Durkheim did not describe electromagnetic fields, local bigOther processors, or a wireless network.

The present theory distinguishes two architectures of that shared moral force:

First-order mechanical solidarity shares concrete rules and answers. Lifted mechanical solidarity shares the rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers.

The adjective *lifted* is new here: it extends Durkheim rather than reproducing a term used by him. Its minimal formal relation is:

fixed meta-rules M + current knowledge or inputs K_t + situation $C \rightarrow$ binding first-order output $R_t(C)$

Fixed here means operatively installed and binding, not eternal. A lifted ruleset can itself be revised through the procedures it recognizes. The generator, its present inputs, and its concrete outputs all belong to one operative weave; they are not separate bigOthers. First-order and lifted solidarity also use the same proposed field-forming mechanism and both can fully occupy the single slot.

A dense corpus of detailed prescriptions that *beseelte* participants follow as self-compulsorily proper is a strong and testable indicator of predominantly first-order solidarity. It is not the definition: first-order orders can contain interpretive procedures, and lifted generators can produce extensive, precise rules. Lifted systems often display **generative compression**—comparatively few meta-rules generate many changing answers—but fewness alone is not decisive. The diagnostic question is where common binding force resides: in the concrete answers, or in the rules by which answers are produced and corrected.

Modern societies may combine organic differentiation with lifted mechanical solidarity. A shared generator can admit different religions, occupations, identities, institutions, and ways of life as different first-order outputs or bounded packages. It can also constitute and limit offices and jurisdictions. Pluralism, division of labour, and bounded subordinate authority are therefore important possible consequences of lifting, not its definition. Nor must lifted authority be weak or local: a generator can have universal jurisdiction at its own level while the outputs and authorities it generates are particular and bounded. The cases and difficult classifications are developed in §25.

Related distinction: Hyperculture and cultural essentialism The German sociologist **Andreas Reckwitz** distinguishes two late-modern *regimes of culturalization* in “*Zwischen Hyperkultur und Kulturessenzialismus*” (2016) and the related *Die Zeit* essay “*Alles so schön hyper*”. **Cultural essentialism** treats culture as the durable inheritance of a comparatively homogeneous community, organized by an ingroup–outgroup distinction and the preservation or recovery of valued traditions. **Hyperculture** treats globally circulating cultural goods, practices, and identities as a diverse repertoire from which individuals construct singular ways of life.

There is a strong structural correspondence with the present framework, but not an identity:

Reckwitz’s distinction	Translation into the present framework
Cultural essentialism	Resembles first-order mechanical solidarity : cohesion is sought through common substantive identities, practices, origins, and beliefs.
Hyperculture	Resembles first-order plurality combined with organic and market differentiation : cultural elements circulate, combine, and serve individual self-development. It is not itself a form of solidarity.
The normative order supporting hyperculture	Can take the form of lifted mechanical solidarity around diversity, tolerance, openness, self-realization, human rights, and legitimate cosmopolitan institutions.

The theories therefore ask different questions. Reckwitz classifies what culture is taken to be and how cultural value is produced; *lifted mechanical solidarity* identifies the level at which social similarity, legitimacy, and common moral authority are located. A hypercultural society can be highly plural at the first order while demanding strong conformity to a second-order affirmation of plurality.

This higher-order solidarity becomes epistemically problematic when terms such as *diversity*, *tolerance*, or *human rights* function as unchallengeable master signifiers, one authorized interpretation becomes compulsory, and disagreement is classified as hostility toward the value itself. That is an essentializing use of hypercultural meta-norms, not sufficient reason to classify every left-liberal, green, or cosmopolitan position as cultural essentialism. Claiming truth is not the criterion; the question is whether claims and interpretations remain corrigible or become identity- and authority-gated. Cultural essentialism and hyperculture can therefore both support or suppress epistemic agency through different authorities: tradition, religion, nation, and communal leaders in one case; prestigious media, professions, expert institutions, and cosmopolitan moral vocabularies in the other.

3. The epistemic predicament: dependence is unavoidable

The starting condition is **epistemic dependence**, not epistemic credulity. The immediate source is the American philosopher **John Hardwig’s** paper “*Epistemic Dependence*” (1985), which argues that rational knowledge often

depends essentially on trusting other knowers. The present entry extends Hardwig's person-to-person problem into institutional trust, collective solidarity, and the social routing of belief updates.

Modern knowledge is distributed. A person who consults a physician, relies on an engineer's safety calculation, uses a statistical series, accepts a historical date, or trusts a laboratory result is normally doing something rational. Testimony and institutional knowledge are not inferior substitutes for a purely personal knowledge that could realistically be achieved. They are constitutive parts of human knowing.

Healthy epistemic dependence can involve:

- division of cognitive labour;
- transactive memory, in which people know who is likely to know what;
- credentialed expertise;
- records and institutional memory;
- methodological standards;
- peer criticism and replication;
- trusted personal judgment in domains where another person has demonstrated competence.

The decisive distinction is between **reliance** and **preemption**:

"The authority's judgment is important evidence that I should normally weight heavily."

is different from:

"The authority's judgment decides what evidence I am permitted to recognize."

The first is delegated reality-testing. The second is delegated reality-permission.

Epistemic agency therefore cannot mean verifying everything personally. Such autarky would make a person less knowledgeable, not more. Agency consists in retaining **meta-authority** over dependence: the ability to understand why trust is granted, limit it by domain, calibrate it by performance, compare it with other routes to reality, and withdraw or revise it when warranted.

4. Socialization into institutional trust

Socialization teaches more than propositions and rules. It installs an **architecture of epistemic trust**.

The exact expression **socialization into institutional trust**, and the mechanism assigned to it here, are synthetic. Important antecedents are **Patrick Wilson's** account of [cognitive authority](#), **Niklas Luhmann's** analysis of [trust as a way of reducing social complexity](#), and **Anthony Giddens's** discussion of trust in [expert systems and other abstract systems](#). None of these authors proposes the whole Durkheimian many-to-few mechanism formulated below.

Children and citizens learn:

- which persons and offices may teach, diagnose, judge, certify, or interpret;
- which credentials and uniforms signify competence;
- which publications, channels, and formats count as official;
- which institutions possess jurisdiction over which questions;
- which sources are respectable, fringe, sacred, suspect, or inadmissible;
- what kind of challenge counts as inquiry and what kind counts as insolence or betrayal.

Much of this learning occurs before a person can independently assess the institutions involved. Later reasoning takes place through the trust structure that earlier socialization supplied. The person may know how to ask, "What does the recognized institution say?" without yet knowing how to ask, "Why does this institution possess jurisdiction here, and how would I recognize its failure?"

The recurring architecture can have the following shape:

```
large and diverse population
    ↓ shared socialization
common second-order classifications and legitimacy rules
    ↓
small set of elevated institutions, professions, and offices
    ↓
authorized spokespersons and communication channels
```

↓

certification of claims as presumptively reliable

This many-to-few architecture is an important form of modern mechanical integration, but it is not the definition of mechanical solidarity. Shared consciousness can also be horizontal and leaderless. Consensus itself can become the gatekeeper: “Everyone like us knows this.” Conversely, a differentiated institution can possess legitimate authority without producing strong mechanical solidarity. The terms should therefore not be collapsed.

Section 12 returns to this asymmetry as a **privileged authority-addressed programming topology**: a recurrent and potentially powerful geometry within a mechanically solidary field, not a universal shape or a synonym for the field.

5. Epistemic gatekeepers and trust anchors

An **epistemic gatekeeper** is a person, role, institution, profession, identity, or communication channel whose authorization strongly influences whether a claim is admitted as credible. This is a functional use of the familiar word *gatekeeper*, not a claim that a single cited author established this exact category.

A **personal epistemic authority** is a narrower relationship in which another person’s considered judgment itself constitutes evidence. The closest direct sources are Wilson’s *cognitive authority* and the American philosopher **Linda Trinkaus Zagzebski’s** *Epistemic Authority* (2012). Such reliance can be rational when competence, intellectual character, access, and record deserve trust. The person becomes a gatekeeper, in the more specific usage of this entry, only when this evidential weight acquires a permissioning function—when evidence effectively cannot enter except through their approval.

The gatekeeper need not be personally known. In an institutional form, the person speaking may be a replaceable interface:

socialization into institutional trust

↓

institution recognized as epistemic trust anchor

↓

office, credential, or channel authenticates a spokesperson

↓

claim inherits institutional authority

↓

institution-gated belief update

The audience does not primarily think, “I know this speaker and have inspected their reasoning.” It thinks, “This speaker is authorized to represent the institution that society recognizes as competent in this domain.” The institution is the **epistemic trust anchor**; the spokesperson is the **institutional epistemic proxy**.

Several diagnostic observations follow:

- If the statement loses most of its authority when the same person leaves office, the institution was the real trust anchor.
- If an unknown successor can speak with equal force, the individual was primarily an interface.
- If the spokesperson loses credibility by contradicting the institution even while presenting the same evidence, institutional authorization dominated personal reasoning.
- If identical evidence is accepted or rejected according to branding, belief updating is substantially institution-gated.

Gatekeeping is not inherently pathological. Filtering can protect limited attention from fraud, noise, and incompetence. It becomes dangerous when the gatekeeper changes from a defeasible evidence source into what this entry calls a **reality-validation node** whose approval determines whether contrary evidence may count at all. Zagzebski’s **Preemption Thesis** is a relevant but not identical antecedent: it concerns how a recognized authority’s judgment can replace some of the subject’s own reasons. The pathological permissioning relation meant here is stronger and closer to what **Christoph Jäger** criticizes in “*Epistemic Authority, Preemptive Reasons, and Understanding*” (2016).

6. Forms of authority and epistemic spillover

The following table concerns authorities constituted *within* an order. Their competence can and normally should be bounded even when the lifted constitution that creates and coordinates their jurisdictions is universal at the

second order. A parliament, court, profession, office, or expert does not inherit universal epistemic competence merely because the common legal and epistemic meta-order governs the allocation of its authority.

For example, a lifted legal order can govern universally what counts as lawful legislation, office, contract, consent, permissible terms, interpretation, enforcement, remedy, appeal, and correction. Particular legislatures, courts, officials, and contracting parties exercise only the competences that order constitutes for them.

At least four forms of authority should be distinguished:

Form	Legitimate function	Characteristic spillover risk
Coordination authority	Organizes common action and resolves operational decisions.	The right to direct action is mistaken for superior knowledge of every relevant fact.
Normative authority	States, interprets, or enforces rules and obligations.	The right to define a rule is mistaken for the power to determine empirical reality.
Epistemic authority	Supplies competent testimony or judgment in a defined knowledge domain.	Domain-specific competence is generalized beyond its evidence and expertise.
Pastoral authority	Guides a person's welfare, identity, duties, conscience, or interpretation of life.	Care and intimate understanding become grounds for surrendering judgment.

Role-conferred epistemic authority spillover occurs when authority in one domain silently produces deference in another. A teacher's legitimate classroom authority, an officer's command authority, a priest's pastoral role, a manager's organizational authority, or a public institution's procedural legitimacy can be treated as if it guaranteed factual correctness outside the appropriate domain.

Mechanical solidarity facilitates spillover because disagreement may acquire a moral meaning. A factual challenge can be classified not as a proposed correction but as disobedience, disloyalty, ignorance, pollution, lack of compassion, or an attack upon the community. The authority then receives support not only from its own office but from peers whose reactions make the cost of doubt collectively visible.

Jurisdictional spillover is therefore a pathology of an authorized person, office, or institution exceeding its allocated competence. It is not evidence that the lifted meta-order itself should lack universal jurisdiction over how those competences are created, limited, coordinated, appealed, and corrected.

The pathological inference is:

"Because this person or institution is entitled to coordinate, represent, protect, or guide us, it must also be the correct interpreter of reality."

7. One umbrella, not one continuum

The concepts gathered under this entry are related but are not interchangeable positions on a single scale from independence to gullibility. They are different kinds of things.

Concept	Semantic kind	Central question
Epistemic dependence	Social condition	From whom and through what institutions must I obtain knowledge?
Epistemic vigilance or credulity	Disposition and monitoring function	How carefully and symmetrically do I assess communicated information?
Epistemic gatekeeping	Relationship and network architecture	Through which nodes must a claim pass before I treat it as admissible?
Authority spillover	Transfer mechanism	Has legitimate authority in one domain acquired unearned force in another?

Concept	Semantic kind	Central question
Persuasion	Belief-change process	By what operations is a judgment, identity, or evaluation being changed?
Narrative or causal story	Meaning-making medium	How are events organized into cause, blame, responsibility, and remedy?
Master signifier	Symbolic operator	Which privileged term organizes meanings, identities, and legitimate knowledge?
Mechanical solidarity	Form of social integration	How are people held together through shared classifications and sentiments?
Piety toward the real	Normative orientation	Does reality retain the right to correct the model and the authority?
Cognitive liberty	Developmental and normative achievement	Can the person take the inherited trust architecture as an object of reflection?

The whole field is multidimensional. Relevant axes include:

- degree of necessary dependence;
- calibration of trust;
- concentration or plurality of authority;
- domain limitation or spillover;
- symmetry or asymmetry in evaluating evidence;
- identity investment and need for closure;
- transparency of sources and methods;
- social cost of doubt, dissent, and exit;
- institutional capacity for correction;
- personal capacity for inexpensive direct verification;
- willingness to leave a question unresolved.

Someone can be highly dependent yet epistemically agentic, skeptical toward most sources yet preemptively deferential toward one, self-authored yet wrong, or socially conformist while relying on institutions that happen to be accurate. No single credulity score captures these configurations.

8. Authority-gated belief updating and asymmetric epistemic permeability

Authority-gated belief updating is the central pathological mechanism named by this entry. Both this label and **asymmetric epistemic permeability** below are proposed terms, not terms taken verbatim from the cited literature. Authority-gated belief updating occurs when the source's authorization controls the admissibility or weight of a claim before its content receives independent consideration.

Its simplest form is:

claim arrives

↓

Is it endorsed by my recognized authority,
identity, institution, or socially legitimate narrative?

- └ yes → admit, accept, or rationalize
- └ no → reject, distrust, or refer back to the authority

The associated observable pattern is **asymmetric epistemic permeability**:

- authorized information passes through easily;
- unauthorized counterevidence meets an unusually high burden;
- direct checks are displaced by consultation with the gatekeeper;
- a trusted source's error is explained away;
- an outsider's accurate claim is treated as suspect because of its origin;
- intelligence is used to defend the installed conclusion rather than expose it to symmetrical testing.

This resolves the apparent contradiction between being easy to persuade and hard to convince. The person is not open in every direction. They are highly permeable along authorized channels and comparatively impermeable across unauthorized boundaries.

This is therefore **not generalized gullibility**. A person may be suspicious, argumentative, and highly skilled at finding weaknesses in out-group claims. Their credulity is selective and routed. The question asked before “Is this true?” is “Who is entitled to say this?”

The strongest diagnostic case occurs when a person refuses an available, inexpensive verification—an original source, a transparent count, or a calculation using elementary arithmetic—and instead asks the gatekeeper what the answer is. Referring to expertise can be rational; refusing a decisive cheap check because it lacks social authorization indicates that the authority has begun to preempt evidence.

9. Epistemic vigilance, credulity, and closure

Epistemic vigilance, as developed by **Dan Sperber, Fabrice Clément, Christophe Heintz, Olivier Mascaro, Hugo Mercier, Gloria Origgi, and Deirdre Wilson** in “[Epistemic Vigilance](#)” (2010), is the family of processes by which communicated information is assessed for source reliability and content plausibility. **Epistemic credulity** is used here more broadly for an insufficiently discriminating readiness to accept communicated claims.

That broad usage overlaps with, but is not identical to, the narrower construct measured by **Chloe Campbell, Michal Tanzer, Rob Saunders, Thomas Booker, Elizabeth Allison, Elizabeth Li, Claire O’Dowda, Patrick Luyten, and Peter Fonagy** in “[Development and Validation of a Self-Report Measure of Epistemic Trust](#)” (2021), where *epistemic credulity* is one of three measured positions alongside trust and mistrust. In this entry, *credulity* normally refers to a nonclinical tendency or situational failure, not to a diagnosis. Ordinary authority-gated updating is usually selective. It may arise from:

- prestige bias;
- attachment or dependency;
- high need for closure;
- authoritarian submission;
- identity-protective cognition;
- fear of exclusion;
- lack of corrective mindware;
- information overload;
- genuine inability to inspect a technical claim;
- repeated experience that deference is rewarded and questioning punished.

Need for closure and authoritarian submission are susceptibility variables, not synonyms for mechanical solidarity or master signifiers. A conventionally anti-authoritarian person may be captured by counter-institutional master signifiers such as *Awakening, Resistance, The People, or Hidden Truth*. The deeper vulnerability is often a low tolerance for leaving the gap of uncertainty open.

Calibrated vigilance avoids both indiscriminate trust and indiscriminate distrust. Contrarianism is not agency if the person automatically reverses every institutional statement or submits to a counter-gatekeeper. Inverted authority-gating remains authority-gating.

10. Pastoral epistemic authority

Pastoral authority is authority legitimated through care, protection, guidance, personal knowledge, or concern for another person’s welfare. The major theoretical antecedent is the French philosopher and historian **Michel Foucault’s** account of *pastoral power*, including “[The Subject and Power](#)” (1982). Its epistemic form arises when the trusted guide becomes an interpreter not only of what the person ought to do but of what their experience means and what counts as reality.

This functional use overlaps with discussions of **pastoral power**, especially authority exercised through individualized guidance, care, confession, and direction of conduct. **Pastoral epistemic authority** is a narrower synthetic term for the resulting relation to knowledge; it should not be treated as an exact synonym for every historical or Foucauldian use of pastoral power.

Healthy pastoral epistemic authority can offer:

- counsel during uncertainty;

- interpretation where technical and existential questions overlap;
- accompaniment through fear or confusion;
- a trusted provisional judgment when the person cannot investigate alone;
- support for eventually recovering independent judgment.

It becomes **pastoral epistemic gatekeeping** when care preempts examination. Dependence feels like safety, disagreement feels like ingratitude or betrayal, and the guide's interpretation becomes more authoritative than the person's accessible evidence. The relationship can then transfer responsibility for judgment while preserving the subjective feeling of being protected.

Pastoral authority need not be personal. An institution may present itself as society's caretaker; an unknown spokesperson then inherits a pastoral tone from the office. The institution does not merely claim, "We possess relevant evidence." It claims, implicitly or explicitly, "We know what is happening, what it means for you, and what a responsible person should feel and do."

11. From local bigOthers to a mechanically solidary field

This section develops the field effect previewed in [Culture Mechanics](#). It preserves the individual-to-field order: homo duplex supplies the local source and receiver; communication among many such persons produces an emergent organization; that organization then acts back upon the individuals who sustain it.

Handoff from the individual architecture Five constructs must remain distinct:

Construct	Function in the present theory
Lacan's big Other	The shared symbolic order and, in the present functional translation, the on-the-wire protocol of language, law, roles, conventions, master signifiers, and recognized symbolic authority. This does not exhaust Lacan's concept.
Local bigOther	The individual sentiment classifier that executes the installed mythological lens and transmits and receives through the shared protocol.
Mechanical solidarity	Field coherence generated as compatible local bigOthers repeatedly produce and answer common classifications and sentiments.
Distributed bigOther	The dynamically maintained symbolic-affective network state reproduced through local bigOthers, institutions, roles, practices, stories, and artifacts.
Multi-mind-self	The distributed system when it becomes sufficiently integrated and continuous to perceive, remember, judge, intend, own, and act as a collective agent. Not every field or crowd reaches this threshold.

The relation is causal rather than synonymous:

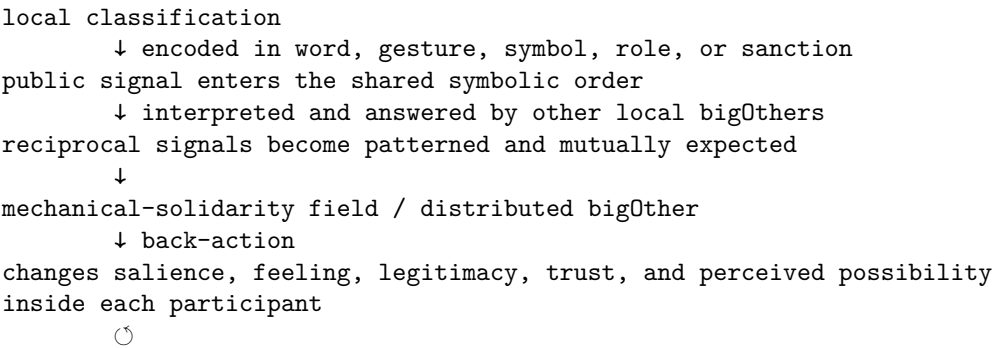
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LOCAL BIGOTHERS
individual sources and receivers
    ↓ communicate through
SHARED SYMBOLIC PROTOCOL / LACANIAN BIG OTHER
    ↓ may generate
MECHANICAL-SOLIDARITY COHERENCE
    ↓ maintains
DISTRIBUTED BIGOTHER
    ↓ may become sufficiently integrated as
MULTI-MIND-SELF

```

Field formation and back-action The originating physical analogy compares the local bigOther to a charged particle. A charged particle is a source of an electromagnetic field and is also acted upon by the field produced by other

charges. Likewise, each local bigOther emits socially intelligible classifications and responses while remaining susceptible to the organized signals, expectations, sanctions, institutions, and apparent consensus produced by other nodes.



Culture Mechanics gives the authoritative treatment of **ideological symbols**, **conformity signals**, and **targeting signals** at this individual-to-public interface. Performance, absence, refusal, substitution, imposition, or attribution can make conformity or target status publicly legible; the field mechanism here begins when other local bigOthers classify and answer that signal. Its private, collective, ideological-form, and fundamentalist program taxonomy, its separate jealousy and *Beseelung* axes, and its account of moralized character accusation are not repeated in this document.

The field is causally real within culture mechanics. It is implemented through persons, communication, institutions, practices, and artifacts, but its relational organization cannot be reconstructed adequately by describing each person as if their psychology had formed in isolation. Public classifications alter incentives; institutions preserve memory; roles survive replacement of their occupants; signals become common knowledge; and each participant responds partly to what they expect others to expect. The field therefore has downward or back-action without requiring a carrier-free substance.

The analogy with a **photon** isolates a second hypothesis: an organized social meaning can retain relative identity while its biological and material carriers change. A law, office, ritual, master signifier, or institutional expectation may persist while speakers, documents, and officeholders are replaced. This is relative carrier-independence, not disembodiment and not a claim that symbolic messages are literally photons.

These comparisons are explanatory pictures and hypothesis generators. The theory does not posit a social electro-magnetic force, Maxwellian equations, or a physical identity between affective alignment and field physics.

Laser synchronization, magnetization, and cultural domains When local bigOthers exchange signals and observe one another's reactions, they can synchronize. The established laser analogy emphasizes coherence:

Laser analogy	Culture-mechanical counterpart
Emitters	Individual persons and local bigOthers
Energy input	Fear, hope, anger, enthusiasm, moral concern
Coupling	Education, media, ritual, repetition, and institutions
Mode selection	Master signifiers and authoritative classifications
Phase alignment	Similar attention, affect, interpretation, and response
Coherent output	Collective judgment, enforcement, and coordinated action

The complementary **magnetization analogy** makes durable spatial patterning more vivid. Local magnetic moments need not be invented by a central controller; their interaction can align them. A material may contain differently aligned domains, and a boundary can remain sharp even though the same underlying kinds of elements exist on both sides. Likewise, neighboring populations may sustain distinct classifications, sentiments, customs, and aesthetic expectations through dense local reinforcement.

The originating Bavaria-and-Swabia observation illustrates the hypothesis. Customs such as *Blumenschmuck* or *Kehrwoche*, regional house forms, standards of cleanliness, and visible treatment of shared space may change markedly across a cultural boundary. The observation makes a proposed domain wall perceptible; it does not by

itself establish a population-level mechanism, explain every resident, or show that boundaries are immutable. Migration, bilingual participation, institutions, media, and individual dissent can weaken, cross, or reorganize them.

First-order and **lifted mechanical solidarity** can both magnetize a field. In the first, alignment concerns shared concrete rules and answers. In the lifted form, alignment concerns the generator by which concrete answers are produced, applied, and corrected. The resulting answers may differ across time and situation without weakening solidarity because the shared operation has moved to a more abstract level, not disappeared.

Repeaters and crowds Every local bigOther transmits. A **repeater** is not a different species of person but a node with greater gain, reach, credibility, frequency, connectivity, or institutional amplification. A teacher, priest, officer, celebrity, editor, manager, party official, or institutional spokesperson may therefore influence many more receivers than an ordinary participant.

The Wi-Fi analogy must not obscure aggregate gain. A synchronized crowd of weak transmitters can equal or exceed one strong repeater: applause, silence, repetition, visible unanimity, ridicule, or coordinated refusal becomes a high-amplitude signal precisely because many participants enact it together. Nor is amplification always vertical. Peer groups, rituals, crowds, and decentralized networks can synchronize without a privileged leader.

bigOther-presence as the local experience of field back-action The field is not normally experienced as a sociological diagram. Within a participant it may appear as **bigOther-presence** or **bigOther-as-Thou**: God, Destiny, Nation, History, the People, or the Cause seems objectively present, addresses the person, observes conduct, and can receive loyalty or sacrifice. The terms were defined in *Culture Mechanics*, with William James and Martin Buber as partial phenomenological antecedents. They are project-developed terms, not concepts those authors used for this field mechanism.

This formulation connects the two levels without equating them. The distributed field is the relational organization; bigOther-presence is one way its authority can become locally present to consciousness; the local bigOther is the processor through which the presence is classified and made conduct-directing. A reported religious or moral presence may have additional meanings or causes that this functional account neither proves nor disproves.

The epistemic field effect The main cognitive processor can reason in detail, but field back-action can alter which questions feel permissible, which evidence feels contaminated, which source seems entitled to speak, and which conclusion promises belonging. This explains why intellectual ability does not guarantee epistemic independence. A powerful reasoner can become a more effective advocate for a direction already made emotionally compulsory.

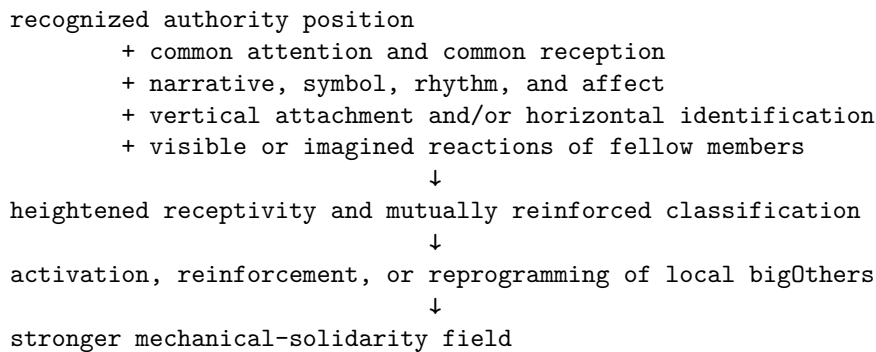
An authority, institution, or apparent consensus can thus become the pole through which the field routes belief updates. Socialization supplies legitimacy; common signals make that legitimacy visible; and the participant's local bigOther marks unauthorized checking as insolent, shameful, dangerous, or disloyal. Authority-gated belief updating is therefore not only an individual bias. It can be a field effect whose participants continually reproduce the very authority to which they defer.

A closely related concept is **ideological power**. The German psychologist **Rainer Mausfeld**, explicitly borrowing from the sociologist **Michael Mann's four-source theory of social power**, uses it in *Hybris und Nemesis* for the power to shape the sense-making categories, interpretive contexts, and framing narratives through which people construct social reality. This overlaps strongly with culture mechanics and causal stories. The difference is one of level and scope: *ideological power* names a capacity to organize other people's interpretive world, especially for domination, whereas the field account also includes decentralized emergence, receiving-side back-action, and truthful, corrigible solidarity. Ideological power is one possible cause or strategic use of the field, not its synonym.

The result can be what this entry calls **Bonhoefferian Dummheit**, after the German theologian **Dietrich Bonhoeffer's** 1943 reflection "[Von der Dummheit](#)" ([PDF of the complete section](#)) ([HTML transcription](#)): a socially induced loss of inner independence in which formulas and slogans speak through people whose ordinary intelligence remains intact. Bonhoeffer did not formulate the culture-mechanical field model, and *Dummheit* is neither an IQ category nor a clinical diagnosis. The family resemblance is that intelligence has been placed downstream of a socially protected classification and recruited to elaborate or defend it.

12. Privileged authority-addressed programming topology

Privileged authority-addressed programming topology is a provisional label for an originating structural hypothesis: mechanical solidarity often becomes especially transmissive when a comparatively uniform audience is oriented toward a differentiated and elevated speaker position.



This topology is **privileged, not universal**. Horizontal peer exchange, a leaderless crowd, a decentralized network, private reading, direct experience, or many weak transmitters can also create or change solidarity. A formal authority can fail when the audience distrusts the office, uses incompatible lenses, divides its attention, privately rejects the message, or sees that others reject it.

The hypothesis is also truth-neutral at the level of mechanism. A good teacher can use the geometry to transmit accurate, inspectable knowledge; a propagandist can use it to install a false causal story. Common reception can coordinate lifesaving action or suppress a cheap reality check. Evaluation therefore requires at least three separate questions:

1. Does the topology in fact increase receptivity or synchronization here?
2. Does the communicated model track reality and remain corrigible?
3. Does the relation preserve the participant's capacity to inspect, refuse, and later revise it?

Possible tests should compare the same message across authority and peer positions, private and publicly common reception, narrative and non-narrative forms, synchronized and unsynchronized audiences, and compatible and incompatible prior lenses. Failure to produce differential retention, sentiment, coordination, or deference would weaken the claim that this geometry has a special programming effect.

13. Unitary ownership by the multi-mind-self

The originating claim is deliberately stronger than the ordinary phrase **shared ownership**:

Successful shared ownership is not psychologically shared among many separate owners. One multi-mind-self owns; many *beseelte* persons perceive, care, judge, and act as organs of that unitary owner.

The German adjective ***beseelt*** means animated, ensouled, or inwardly moved. In the present theory it names the condition in which a biological person is animated by the collective perspective strongly enough that the group's object is experienced and treated as **ours** without a private cost-benefit calculation being required on every occasion. The term does not imply possession, the erasure of personal consciousness, or release from individual moral and legal responsibility.

This proposition distinguishes three meanings often collapsed by the phrase *shared ownership*:

Meaning	Question
Legal ownership	Which natural or juridical person holds recognized title, rights, liabilities, and powers?
Organizational group agency	Does a decision procedure allow a group to form coherent judgments and intentions and act upon them?
Culture-mechanical unitary ownership	Does an integrated distributed bigOther experience, protect, maintain, and act through an object as one continuing collective self?

Legal title can exist without lived ownership. A company may legally own an asset while employees treat it as nobody's concern. Conversely, people may care for a street, railway, irrigation system, institution, or inherited practice as *ours* even though none holds personal title. Culture-mechanical ownership names the psychological and social organization, not the legal rule.

The intellectual neighbors clarify but do not establish the proposed mechanism. [Otto von Gierke's account of the real unity of human associations](#) and his theory of the **group-person** reject the idea that an organized association

is only an aggregate or legal fiction. F. W. Maitland's "Moral Personality and Legal Personality" explores how an organized group can possess moral and legal personality and act through human organs. Christian List and Philip Pettit's *Group Agency* (2011) supplies modern criteria for when organizational procedures support genuine group judgments and intentions. None describes the local bigOther, mechanical-solidarity field, *Beseelung*, or the present unitary-ownership mechanism.

Failure contrasts Two people assigned a joint task do not thereby become one owner. They may divide the work, protect only their own contribution, blame one another, or comply only while supervised. Coordination exists, but no continuing collective perspective organizes perception and care.

Likewise, a shareholder may legally own a fraction of a company while experiencing its property only as an instrument for private return. Distributed title is not evidence that a multi-mind-self owns. The strong claim concerns the opposite case: many people act from one socially present we even where personal title is absent or practically irrelevant.

Positive illustrations and hypotheses

- The **Subak irrigation and temple system** is retained as an originating reading of successful collective ownership. Water, ritual, coordination, maintenance, and local obligation appear to belong to one continuing social system enacted by many participants. The example illustrates what the theory seeks to explain; it does not by itself prove a multi-mind ontology, and its historical and anthropological details require independent verification before bearing a strong empirical load.
- The **Bahner** names a proposed historical organizational ethos in which a railway worker could perceive the railway as *our railway* and act for its reliability beyond the immediately measured private task. This is an originating hypothesis about Deutsche Bahn and its predecessors, not an established finding about every employee or period.
- **Clean German cities**, *Kehrwoche*, flower decoration, and care for common space illustrate possible civic ownership: a resident treats a street or shared place as belonging to the collective self rather than as an external surface serviced by someone else. The observation is vivid but not population proof.
- **Careful treatment of another person's property** shows that the relevant owner can be lifted to a second-order moral community. The object remains legally theirs, yet a shared norm makes respect for another member's property part of what we protect. This explains care without pretending that legal title has changed.

These cases should not be generalized into the claim that every orderly community or conscientious worker instantiates a multi-mind-self. Alternative explanations include personal virtue, incentives, surveillance, habit, professional identity, reciprocity, and explicit rules. The theory earns explanatory force only where the unitary collective perspective predicts perception, care, memory, sanction, and action better than those alternatives alone.

Threshold and boundary conditions Mechanical solidarity and a distributed bigOther can exist below the threshold of a collective agent. Evidence for a **multi-mind-self** becomes stronger when the system shows several of the following across changing individual carriers:

- a continuing group perspective distinguishing *ours* from merely private or external objects;
- memory preserved in roles, records, ritual, practice, and institutional correction;
- group-level judgment and intention that cannot be identified with one current member's preference;
- coordinated perception, maintenance, defense, and use of the owned object;
- expectations and sanctions that recruit replacements into the same perspective;
- capacity to notice failure, revise action, and preserve continuity through turnover;
- organs authorized to speak and act for the whole without becoming its private owners.

Disorganization, rapid dissolution when one leader exits, pervasive free-riding, incompatible group judgments, inability to learn, or conduct fully predicted by private incentives weakens the collective-agent interpretation. The field is not called a multi-mind-self merely because the metaphor sounds vivid.

Unitary ownership also does not make the collective morally superior or its objects sacred. A multi-mind-self can own unjustly, neglect outsiders, suppress individual rights, or direct members toward harm. Collective agency increases the need to locate responsibility among the group, its procedures, officeholders, and the biological persons through whom it acts; it does not dissolve responsibility into the field.

14. Master signifiers and the organization of knowledge

In Lacanian terminology, a **master signifier** or **S1** is a privileged signifier that organizes other meanings and identifications. Lacan develops the relation of S1, S2, knowledge, and authority most directly in [Le Séminaire, Livre XVII: L'envers de la psychanalyse \(1969–1970\)](#). Terms such as *Nation*, *Justice*, *Science*, *Safety*, *Tradition*, *Freedom*, *Human Rights*, or *Revolution* can perform this function.

In the culture-mechanical translation, a master signifier is a **highly compressed protocol token**. It does not carry the whole mythological lens in its surface form. It indexes and activates an already installed complex of stories, classifications, authorities, identities, sentiments, and expected conduct. As M can designate a mathematical mapping and E a field, an S1 can coordinate a large meaning structure without restating it. The compression makes coordination efficient while allowing the activated structure to remain tacit and difficult to inspect.

A master signifier, mechanical solidarity, and laser synchronization are related but not identical:

- the **master signifier** is a compressed symbolic operator or mode selector in the shared protocol;
- **laser synchronization** is a dynamic process of alignment;
- **mechanical solidarity** is a form of social cohesion produced through common classifications and sentiments.

An S1 is neither necessary nor sufficient for mechanical solidarity, but it can condense, direct, and reproduce it efficiently. In lifted mechanical solidarity, abstract signifiers are especially powerful because many different first-order lives can be coordinated through the same second-order word.

Institutions often claim custody of a master signifier:

```
"Science", "Justice", "Safety", or "Human Rights"
      ↓
institution claims authorized interpretation
      ↓
office or spokesperson applies the classification
      ↓
body of knowledge and recommended action
      ↓
citizen belief update
```

The healthy and pathological uses differ:

HEALTHY

S1 organizes inquiry → method and evidence remain inspectable

PATHOLOGICAL

S1 terminates inquiry → authorization selects admissible evidence
→ a required conclusion follows

No signifier-free mind or society is possible. The goal is not to eliminate organizing terms but to keep them visible, plural, concretizable, and corrigible. The decisive question is whether the signifier helps formulate an inquiry or decides when inquiry must stop.

15. Persuasion and the reconstruction of mental models

Persuasion is a process for changing belief, evaluation, identity, or action. It is not inherently truth-directed or reality-distorting. Its epistemic status depends on the model toward which it moves a person and whether that model remains open to correction.

One useful analogy proposed by this entry distinguishes two communication styles:

- **State transmission** attempts to copy a finished conclusion into another person through claims, arguments, or instructions.
- **Operation transmission** helps the other person reconstruct the path through recalled experiences, questions, comparisons, predictions, and self-generated inferences.

This analogy resembles the difference between copying a state and reproducing the operations that generated it. It is an interpretation inspired by the American writer **David McRaney's** [How Minds Change \(2022\)](#), not McRaney's own terminology.

Narrative exchange, deep canvassing, motivational interviewing, Street Epistemology, and Socratic questioning may reduce identity threat and help a person perform the relevant operations. The evidence base includes, for example, [Joshua Kalla and David Broockman's three field experiments on non-judgmental narrative exchange in deep canvassing \(2020\)](#). None of these methods is automatically ethical or truth-producing. Questions can simulate open inquiry while selectively steering someone toward a conclusion fixed in advance. This entry calls that possibility **Socratic manipulation**; it is a critical label, not the historical Socratic method's own name.

Method and target must therefore be evaluated separately:

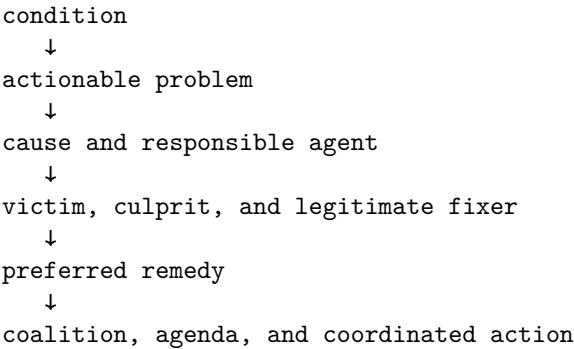
Epistemic direction	Relatively autonomy-supporting method	Manipulative or coercive method
Toward a better reality-tracking model	Education, reciprocal inquiry, transparent persuasion	Reality-aligned paternalism; potentially justified only under sufficiently grave and well-supported conditions
Toward a false or misleading model	Polite or Socratic misdirection	Propaganda, fraud, indoctrination, and epistemically corrupt manipulation

The method alone does not determine the truth of the result. Conversely, the persuader's conviction that the intended conclusion is true does not make every method legitimate. Truth-directed inquiry requires that the persuader's own model also remain at risk.

The programming topology in Section 12 changes neither verdict. It can make an accurate lesson or a false causal story more transportable, authoritative, and socially reinforced. Ethical and epistemic judgment therefore cannot be inferred from receptivity, participation, gentleness, authority, or resistance alone; the content's relation to reality and the preservation of corrigibility remain separate tests.

16. Causal stories and political agenda formation

A **causal story** organizes a condition into a politically meaningful sequence:



The American political scientist **Deborah A. Stone** develops this concept in [“Causal Stories and the Formation of Policy Agendas” \(1989\) \(DOI\)](#). Her analysis explains how political actors compete to define causation, assign responsibility, convert difficulties into governable problems, and attach proposed solutions to issues on the agenda. A causal story does more than summarize facts. It defines moral roles, distributes sympathy and blame, identifies who may intervene, and makes some remedies appear natural while rendering others invisible.

In culture-mechanical terms, causal stories can **program the distributed bigOther**. Repeated stories train local mythological lenses to classify events, agents, institutions, and responses in similar ways; common reception makes those classifications mutually visible; and repetition stabilizes them as field expectations. An authorized institution can then activate this installed structure with a compressed master signifier. Stone explains political causal construction; the field-programming translation belongs to this framework.

Not every causal story is a distortion. Complex events require selection and structure; some stories reveal preventable human causes previously treated as fate or accident. The pathological subtype is **bad-faith causal-story construction**:

selective problem definition and causal attribution used to attach a preselected policy to a real condition while concealing alternative causes, remedies, trade-offs, or predictable consequences.

A causal story may use only individually true statements and still install a false overall model. Reality-tracking therefore requires comparison among causal structures, attention to omitted variables and alternative remedies, and evaluation of predictions beyond the persuasive setting in which the story was first told.

17. The complete capture sequence

The concepts can be assembled into one possible pathway without claiming that every case follows every step. The sequence must distinguish two operations. An authority can activate, reinforce, or extend material already installed or compatible with the incumbent lens. Capture by an incompatible governing worldview is different: under the single-slot principle, it cannot add a second evaluator and must first loosen and unbraid the incumbent sufficiently for one successor weave to be rebraided and installed.

Here **complete capture sequence** names an incompatible, potentially pathological route into authority-gated judgment. It is not the definition of **full capture** in the neutral architectural sense of complete slot occupancy. First-order and lifted programs can both occupy the slot fully, and either can be open or closed. The sequence becomes pathological where correction is disabled, interpretation is monopolized, or an authority claims epistemic sovereignty over reality.

UNCERTAINTY, DEPENDENCE, OR DISORIENTATION

the person needs a classification or cannot investigate alone



MASTER SIGNIFIER OR CAUSAL STORY OFFERS ORDER

a compact term or narrative defines what events mean



PRIVILEGED PROGRAMMING TOPOLOGY AMPLIFIES RECEPTION

authority, common attention, narrative, and common knowledge converge



THE INCUMBENT LENS CLASSIFIES THE OFFER

compatible material may be activated, reinforced, or integrated;

an incompatible governing offer is rejected unless replacement advances



INCOMPATIBLE CAPTURE LOOSENS AND UNBRAIDS THE INCUMBENT

authorities, meanings, loyalties, sentiments, and defences are detached;

liminal instability and dependency make a successor increasingly receivable



ONE SUCCESSOR WEAVE IS REBRAIDED AND INSTALLED

retained and new strands acquire meaning within one operative lens;

no parallel bigOther or higher runtime ranking is introduced



S1 ORGANIZES S2

some knowledge, experts, and institutions become legitimate;

others become disreputable or invisible



MECHANICAL-SOLIDARITY FIELD FORMS OR STRENGTHENS

local bigOthers display, observe, and reinforce common classifications



FIELD BACK-ACTION

apparent consensus, sanctions, and bigOther-presence change what feels admissible



SOCIALIZATION INTO INSTITUTIONAL TRUST

offices, credentials, and channels become shared trust anchors



IDENTITY AND BELONGING BECOME INVESTED

questioning the classification threatens moral standing and membership



AUTHORITY-GATED BELIEF UPDATING

authorization begins to replace symmetrical evaluation



ASYMMETRIC EPISTEMIC PERMEABILITY

in-group messages penetrate; outside evidence is resisted



MOTIVATED REASONING, DUMMHEIT, OR NORMOPATHIC ADAPTATION

intelligence defends the installed order and members enforce it mutually

The unbraiding and rebraiding stages apply only when the incoming program is incompatible at load-bearing classifications. In compatible socialization or reinforcement, the sequence can move directly from incumbent classification to S1 organization without worldview replacement. In failed or incomplete replacement, contradictory remnants can leave one tangled, unstable lens; they do not establish several independently operative bigOthers.

The sequence is recursive. Public conformity strengthens the appearance of consensus; apparent consensus strengthens individual deference; deference strengthens institutions able to control the stories, symbols, sanctions, and sources through which the next round of socialization occurs.

No conscious conspiracy is necessary. The loop may arise through ordinary coordination, institutional inertia, sincere belief, career incentives, dependency, and mutual prediction. It can nevertheless be deliberately exploited by actors who understand how to manipulate narratives, identities, prestige, fear, and institutional legitimacy.

Several labels in the final stage come from separate literatures and are not synonyms. **Motivated reasoning** refers to the directional recruitment of reasoning analyzed by the social psychologist **Ziva Kunda** in [“The Case for Motivated Reasoning” \(1990\)](#). **Contaminated mindware** is the psychologist **Keith E. Stanovich’s** term for acquired reasoning rules or beliefs that can impair rationality; see the chapter [“Contaminated Mindware” \(2009\)](#). **Need for cognitive closure** is the construct measured by social psychologists **Donna M. Webster and Arie W. Kruglanski** in [“Individual Differences in Need for Cognitive Closure” \(1994\)](#). **Normopathic adaptation** is used here descriptively for overadaptation to a pathological normality. It borrows from a concept with several partly independent histories, including **Erich Wulff’s** *Psychiatrie und Klassengesellschaft* (1972), **Joyce McDougall’s** psychoanalytic work on normopathy, and **Hans-Joachim Maaz’s** society-level application in [Das falsche Leben \(2017\)](#). The present use does not import any one of their clinical or political theories wholesale.

18. Healthy and unhealthy mechanical solidarity

Mechanical solidarity is not inherently an enemy of epistemic agency. A society can make reality-orientation itself an object of shared honour.

An **agency-supporting mechanical solidarity** teaches that:

- persons retain dignity when they are mistaken;
- factual disagreement is not automatically disloyalty;
- authorities must expose methods and correct errors;
- domain expertise matters, but jurisdiction has boundaries;
- uncertainty may be acknowledged without shame;
- elementary checking is responsible rather than insulting;
- independent institutions and source pluralism are public goods;
- publicly changing one’s mind can be honourable;
- no institution is the final authorized voice of reality.

An **agency-suppressing mechanical solidarity** teaches that:

- loyalty and factual agreement are fused;
- one identity or institution possesses privileged access to truth;
- unauthorized evidence is morally contaminated;
- the same claim receives different standards according to its source;
- uncertainty signals weakness or betrayal;
- correction threatens status and belonging;
- a missing conformity signal or continued association with a dissenter discloses bad character;
- dissenters may be ignored, shamed, excluded, or punished;
- authorities certify themselves and define their own failures away.

The distinction is not between culture and no culture, full and partial occupancy, or universal and merely local authority. Both configurations can be first-order or lifted full captures. An agency-supporting lifted meta-order remains universally binding at the second order while requiring every representative to remain corrigible and within its allocated jurisdiction. An agency-suppressing order grants final epistemic sovereignty to its representatives, disables correction, or allows jurisdictional spillover.

Both configurations can also sustain a multi-mind-self and unitary collective ownership. Integration is not goodness. A healthy collective agent can maintain knowledge, infrastructure, and common goods across generations; an unhealthy one can own, remember, and act with equal coherence while suppressing correction or harming outsiders. Field strength and epistemic quality must therefore be judged separately.

19. Piety toward the real

Piety toward the real is the normative pole of the framework. The phrase comes from the American sociologist **Robert N. Bellah's** introduction to *Émile Durkheim on Morality and Society* (1973); it is Bellah's characterization of Durkheim's attitude, not a standard technical term coined by Durkheim. This entry adopts and extends Bellah's phrase to name a disciplined respect for the complexity and resistance of what exists.

Piety toward the real means that:

- reality is not exhausted by one's present concepts;
- social facts and institutions may have functions not visible to unaided intuition;
- reform should begin by investigating the structure actually present;
- a satisfying narrative is not sufficient evidence;
- prediction, surprise, error, and consequences may defeat a preferred model;
- no person, movement, or institution may define reality solely by authorization;
- one's own certainty remains fallible and must be externally corrigible.

This piety must be paired with **moral individualism**, drawing on Durkheim's defense of the morally sacred person in "*L'individualisme et les intellectuels*" (1898): the unconditional dignity of persons does not depend on whether their current claims are correct. The present ethical formula is an extension, not a quotation from Durkheim. Respect for a person does not require treating every belief as equally sound. Nor does respectful attention to existing social facts sanctify existing institutions. An institution may be real, complex, and functionally important while remaining unjust or mistaken. The resulting rule is:

Respect persons unconditionally; evaluate propositions conditionally according to evidence; regulate actions according to justice.

This orientation is compatible with the holistic structural realism described in *Holistic Epistemology and Metaphysics: Structural Realism*. The basic epistemic control loop is:

```
experience
↓
concepts and operations
↓
model or "digital twin"
↓
prediction and intervention
↓
encounter with reality
↓
surprise, error, and out-of-sample consequence
↓
revision of the model, concepts, or operations
```

The central virtue is not solitary knowledge. It is preservation of a route by which reality can say **no**.

Piety toward the real also guards against self-appointed gatekeeping. Personal conviction is not self-authenticating. A person who intervenes "for the truth" must remain answerable to evidence, relevant competence, independent assessment, proportionality, consequences, and correction. The compact ethical rule proposed by this synthesis is:

Let truth identify the danger, let love require a response, and let epistemic humility govern the means.

20. Cognitive liberty and epistemic adulthood

In its established legal and ethical lineage, **cognitive liberty** concerns mental self-determination and freedom from unwanted interference with thought or consciousness. Important formulations include **Richard Glen Boire's** essay series "*On Cognitive Liberty*" (1999–2003) and the German legal scholar **Jan Christoph Bublitz's** "*My Mind Is Mine!*"

[Cognitive Liberty as a Legal Concept](#)" (2013). The specialized usage developed here explicitly extends that lineage by adding a positive developmental capacity:

Cognitive liberty is the acquired capacity to gain reflective distance from one's socialization, including the mechanical-solidarity structures that formed one's identity, trust relationships, and standards of truth, without thereby becoming incapable of social trust or collective participation.

The corresponding developmental process is **epistemic adulthood**. Biological or legal adulthood does not guarantee it. A person can reason competently within an inherited trust system while remaining unable to inspect that system as a system.

The developmental movement can be represented as:

SOCIALLY AUTHORED TRUST

"I know through the authorities recognized by my group."

↓

SELF-AUTHORED TRUST

"I can examine why, where, and under what conditions I trust them."

↓

SELF-TRANSFORMING TRUST

"I can revise even my standards of authority and my trust architecture."

This developmental representation is adapted from the American psychologist **Robert Kegan's** constructive-developmental theory, especially the subject-object relation and the movement from socially authored toward self-authored and self-transforming meaning-making discussed in [In Over Our Heads](#) and related work. Kegan does not use the terms *epistemic adulthood*, *socially authored trust*, or *self-transforming trust* in the exact senses defined here. What remains *subject* to the person organizes perception but cannot yet be inspected. What becomes *object* can be noticed, compared, endorsed, limited, or revised.

Epistemic adulthood therefore means that inherited institutional trust becomes:

- conscious rather than invisible;
- allocated to particular persons and institutions within their domains rather than allowed to become total;
- calibrated rather than sacred;
- defeasible rather than preemptive;
- plural rather than monopolistic;
- answerable to reality rather than self-certifying.

It does not guarantee correct beliefs, benevolence, or greater intelligence. A self-authored person can construct a false or cruel worldview. Developmental capacity and epistemic content must be judged separately. The mature achievement is **reflective ownership without finalization**.

Reflective plurality occurs in the main processor: a person can represent, compare, and learn from several authorities or worldviews without installing one local bigOther for each. Until reconstruction occurs, one local bigOther executes one operative lens. Epistemic adulthood enlarges the person's capacity to inspect, repair, compatibly extend, unbraid, or replace that lens; it is not a higher identity that ranks parallel evaluators.

This development occurs inside a fully installed program. Epistemic adulthood is the main processor's acquired capacity to inspect and revise its trust architecture within full lifted capture; it is not absence of programming, absence of universal meta-authority, or reduced occupancy of the single slot.

21. Truth, love of neighbour, and intervention

The framework treats cognitive liberty as important but not absolute. Non-interference can become abandonment when illness, coercion, addiction, delusion, or another destructive process is eliminating the capacities required for future agency.

The moral vocabulary proposed here combines:

- **truth**, which concerns whether the understanding of danger and benefit tracks reality;
- **Nächstenliebe** or love of neighbour, which requires concern for the concrete person's good rather than indifference or instrumental use;
- **corrigibility**, which recognizes that the would-be helper is fallible and may also be captured by a master signifier.

This yields an important distinction:

- **Epistemic intervention** addresses false belief through evidence, demonstration, questioning, and dialogue. False belief by itself does not normally authorize coercive control of another person's mind.
- **Protective intervention** responds to grave and imminent danger that may destroy life or future agency. Stronger interference can sometimes be justified, but should be proportionate, accountable, and directed toward restoring self-direction.

Example—anorexia nervosa (*Magersucht*). A person may sincerely experience extreme restriction and weight loss as discipline, achievement, beauty, or personal control even while starvation is making them gravely ill. Simply admiring their determination and watching them die would confuse respect for present choice with love of the concrete neighbour. Because anorexia nervosa can endanger life, truth-directed love can require active intervention to preserve both the person and the possibility of future agency. Intervention should begin with honest communication and specialist, multidisciplinary support. Where physical health is at serious risk and treatment is refused, protective treatment against the person's present wishes can sometimes be justified—but only through an appropriate legal framework, by a competent team, and as a last resort; these safeguards are also reflected in [NICE's clinical guidance on eating disorders](#).

The governing principle is not “If I am convinced, I may impose the truth.” Truth is the judge, but no individual is identical with truth. Strong intervention requires correspondingly strong and corrigible grounds.

Love also governs method. The neighbour is not material to be reprogrammed. Even justified intervention should prefer explanation before deception, accompaniment before coercion, proportionate means, preservation of dignity, and restoration of independent judgment.

22. Epistemic emancipation and MCIP

Epistemic emancipation is lifting. It is the practical process by which a full first-order capture is unbraided at the point where inherited concrete answers are treated as final and rebraided as a full lifted capture. Testimony, authorities, institutions, and first-order beliefs need not disappear. Religious, professional, familial, political, and local material may remain as compatible strands, inputs, or current outputs, but its authority is now determined by the installed answer-generating rules.

The successor weave binds people to a generator: rules for deciding who may make a rule, what evidence an answer must survive, how a general rule applies to a case, who may challenge the result, and how an error is revised. This is still complete capture. The lifted order may govern universally at its own level while generating different first-order answers and bounded jurisdictions for people, offices, professions, institutions, communities, and contracting parties. Corrigibility is a separate axis: a lifted generator remains open only while its rules and authorized outputs remain answerable to reality and to its own correction procedures.

FULL FIRST-ORDER CAPTURE

shared concrete rules and answers are binding as such

↓

UNBRAID THE FINALITY OF THOSE CONCRETE ANSWERS

↓

REBRAID A SHARED GENERATOR

fixed M + current K_t + situation C

↓

FULL LIFTED CAPTURE

the shared generator produces binding R_t(C), including changing answers and, where relevant, bounded first-order jurisdictions

Emancipation therefore does not install a second bigOther, empty the slot, or weaken its occupancy. Counter-relations, plural institutions, reality contact, and practical support help the main processor inspect the one installed weave, protect or repair sound bindings, unbraid false or overreaching ones, and make a reality-responsive reconstruction survivable. A rival successor is not pathological merely because it replaces the incumbent. It becomes a failed emancipation when it is closed or uncorrectable, monopolizes interpretation, exceeds its constituted jurisdiction, or turns lifted terms into inquiry-terminating master signifiers.

The person is usually bound by more than a false proposition. The binding structure can include:

- collective identity and belonging;
- master signifiers and sacred values;

- trusted institutions and authorized channels;
- rituals of mutual confirmation;
- fear of uncertainty;
- shame or sanctions attached to doubt;
- material, relational, or professional dependence;
- lack of an alternative community in which reconsideration is survivable.

For this reason, fact correction alone often fails. It attacks one output while leaving the trust architecture, social reinforcement, and identity investment intact.

MCIP—Mirror → Cut → Invite → Promise—is a proposed conversational method for making difficult truths psychologically digestible while returning epistemic authorship. It is a new synthetic mnemonic, not an established method under that name. Its elements have family resemblances to **Carl Rogers and Richard Farson’s active listening**, **William R. Miller and Stephen Rollnick’s motivational interviewing**, **J. L. Austin’s account of speech acts and promises**, and Lacanian uses of the *cut*. MCIP is not presented by any of those authors, and its four steps should not be treated as an authorized restatement of their methods.

1. **Mirror:** Recognize the person’s felt reality, value, fear, concern, or legitimate grievance without automatically affirming the associated factual claim.
2. **Cut:** Introduce one precise discrepancy, contradiction, failed prediction, hidden assumption, or concrete reality check. Cut the protected connection, not the person’s dignity.
3. **Invite:** Ask the person to perform the next epistemic operation: formulate the claim, identify a counterexample, make a prediction, compare sources, calculate, or state what could change their confidence.
4. **Promise:** Anchor the opening in a small verification step, shared commitment, practical support, or relationship that makes continued inquiry possible.

The sequence is:

```
Mirror lowers identity threat
↓
Cut interrupts the protected narrative or automatic S1 → S2 sequence
↓
Invite returns authorship and leaves the uncertainty gap open
↓
Promise turns reflection into action and makes independence survivable
```

At large scale, MCIP would need to be a **fractal social practice**, not one broadcast designed to convert a population. Many relationships, communities, media encounters, and institutions would have to create protected doubts, precise reality contacts, opportunities for personal verification, and credible alternatives to abandonment.

Its population-level function would be controlled **de-synchronization**:

- Mirror separates members’ dignity and legitimate experience from the authority’s interpretation.
- Cut interrupts the institution’s monopoly on meaning with a concrete failure or discrepancy.
- Invite creates protected spaces for uncertainty, investigation, dissent, and plural expertise.
- Promise supplies the relationships and material conditions required to question without losing one’s whole world.

The danger is that large-scale “liberation” becomes **closed or uncorrectable successor culture mechanics**. Replacement culture mechanics is unavoidable under single-slot exclusivity; pathological closure is not. Mirror can become calculated identification, Cut can become destabilization, Invite can become guided discovery toward a fixed doctrine, and Promise can become initiation into a new mechanically solidary group. MCIP is agency-supporting only when its Cut is reality-answerable, its Invite is genuinely open, and the persuader’s own model remains corrigible.

23. Safeguards for persons, institutions, and cultures

No safeguard abolishes dependence or error. The objective is to preserve multiple routes of correction.

Personal safeguards

- **Cheap-check rule:** When a decisive source, count, observation, or elementary calculation is readily available, perform it before delegating the question.

- **Authorization–evidence distinction:** Ask whether confidence comes from the evidence, the institutional signature, or both.
- **Prediction record:** State what the model expects before the outcome is known.
- **Defeater question:** Ask what observation would reduce confidence or change the conclusion.
- **Source-chain audit:** Determine whether apparently independent authorities ultimately rely on one source.
- **Domain check:** Ask whether the trusted person's competence actually covers the present claim.
- **Symmetry check:** Consider whether identical evidence would be judged differently under rival branding.
- **Gap tolerance:** Practice leaving uncertainty unresolved rather than filling it immediately with an authorized S1.

Institutional safeguards These bounded jurisdictions are constituted by universally binding lifted rules; their plurality does not localize the meta-order that makes their limits, interaction, appeal, and correction authoritative.

- explicit jurisdiction and domain limits;
- transparent evidence, methods, uncertainty, and conflicts of interest;
- traceable provenance from spokesperson to underlying source;
- visible correction and retraction procedures;
- institutional separation and genuinely independent review;
- protection for internal dissent and whistleblowing;
- access to data and methods where safety and privacy permit;
- public records of predictions, failures, and learning;
- distinction between coordinating action and certifying factual truth.

Cultural safeguards

- dignity of persons independent of their current correctness;
- public honour for correction and principled dissent;
- moral permission to ask elementary questions;
- plural external affiliations and practical rights of exit that make inspection, defence, repair, or reality-responsive reconstruction of the one installed weave survivable;
- resistance to a single institution becoming the exclusive voice of the distributed bigOther;
- refusal to mistake a counterfield or rival institution for a second local bigOther: it can support or contest the installed lens, not co-occupy its PCI slot;
- shared commitment to justice, tolerance, human rights, jurisdiction, and correction as a universally binding open meta-program rather than an excuse to terminate inquiry;
- piety toward the real as the final norm of model correction.

An agency-supporting culture does not teach people to trust nobody. It teaches them **how to trust without surrendering the possibility of correction.**

24. Diagnostic questions

The following questions help identify the configuration without assuming in advance that dependence is pathological:

1. Who or what is recognized as entitled to certify reality in this domain?
2. Is that authority personal, role-based, institutional, professional, distributed, or symbolic?
3. What originally established the authority's trust, and does its current record sustain it?
4. Does the authority expose evidence and method, or primarily display authorization?
5. What would count as a defeater, and who is permitted to present one?
6. Are apparently plural sources genuinely independent?
7. Is authority limited to its proper domain, or has it spilled into coordination, morality, identity, and total interpretation?
8. Would the same evidence receive the same weight under different institutional branding?
9. Are inexpensive direct checks welcomed, ignored, or socially punished?
10. Does disagreement produce curiosity, or shame, fear, exclusion, and accusations of disloyalty?
11. Can the institution acknowledge error without losing its identity and legitimacy?
12. Can the person doubt or exit without losing every source of belonging and support?
13. Does a master signifier organize a concrete inquiry or terminate it?
14. Which causal story assigns blame, victimhood, responsibility, and remedy, and what alternatives has it hidden?
15. Does the resulting model make risky predictions that reality can prove wrong?

16. Which signals are local outputs, which belong to the shared symbolic protocol, and which patterns exist only at field level?
17. Is the audience arranged in a privileged authority-addressed topology, and would the same message have the same effect through a peer channel?
18. Do participants merely hear the same message, or do they know that others hear it and observe one another's response?
19. Does a putative multi-mind-self preserve memory, judgment, intention, and care through turnover, or does apparent unity disappear with one leader?
20. Is "shared ownership" only legal title or incentive alignment, or does one continuing collective perspective organize perception and action?
21. Does shared binding force reside in concrete rules and answers or in the rules that generate, select, apply, and revise them, and does that first-order or lifted weave fully occupy the single slot?
22. Does a universal lifted rule allocate and limit the authority at issue, or has a person, office, profession, institution, or community exceeded that allocated jurisdiction?
23. Can the meta-order and its authorized interpreters be corrected and succeeded, or do they claim that their certification determines what reality may be?

No single answer is decisive. The pattern matters.

25. Examples, cases, and boundary tests

This section is the example home for the first-order/lifted distinction across the theory family. The cases do not prove the framework. They make its classifications risky enough to criticize and test.

The diagnostic in concrete terms The two architectures can govern exactly the same subject:

FIRST-ORDER

the community shares R1, R2, R3 ... as the proper concrete answers

LIFTED

the community shares M as the proper way to produce an answer

$M + \text{current } K_t + \text{situation } C \rightarrow \text{binding } R_t(C)$

The first question is therefore not "How abstract does the vocabulary sound?" or "How many rules are written down?" It is: **What must members share in order to recognize one another as properly formed—the concrete answer, or the generator that can produce and revise answers?**

Rule density nevertheless matters as evidence. Especially vivid first-order signatures include:

- detailed rules governing which foods may be eaten, by whom, when, and after which preparation;
- fixed rules for sex, menstruation, childbirth, corpses, bodily fluids, washing, and restoration after contact;
- prescribed clothing, hairstyles, greetings, seating orders, and forms of address for each status;
- fixed calendars of fasting, feasting, rest, mourning, and ritual observance;
- hereditary rules determining occupation, marriage eligibility, residence, and family duties; and
- craft rules prescribing the proper material, tool, gesture, and sequence rather than a result to be demonstrated.

Religions and cultures organized around many such rules are often first-order, especially when a *beseelte* person follows them without external enforcement because they feel intrinsically clean, decent, honourable, or human. That proposed association is a falsifiable hypothesis; it is not a measured correlation coefficient. Conversely, a legal or scientific corpus can be enormous while solidarity remains lifted if the common binding rule is the rule that generates and corrects its current contents.

Central case: bodily regulation and scientific hygiene Calling one side "purity" and the other "hygiene" would miss the mechanism. Both are rulesets governing bodies, substances, contact, and cleaning. They differ in where the fixed binding rule resides.

Several religious orders make the concrete answer itself morally binding. The [Qur'an's ablution instruction](#), for example, specifies washing the face and forearms, wiping the head, washing the feet, and a clean-earth alternative under stated conditions. [Mishnah Shabbat 7:2](#) enumerates thirty-nine primary categories of prohibited Sabbath labour, while an [Orthodox Union explanation](#) shows how concrete derivative rules are applied; the same organization's account of [niddah](#) describes menstrual separation, examination, clean days, and immersion. These are not merely private hygiene preferences. They classify proper conduct and membership through concrete answers.

The anthropological case is equally direct. [Richard Shweder, Manamohan Mahapatra, and Joan Miller’s cross-cultural study of moral development in orthodox Hindu Bhubaneswar](#) examined Brahman and so-called “Untouchable” children and adults alongside a Hyde Park comparison group. [Jonathan Haidt’s 1992 dissertation](#) summarizes how food, sex-role, and clothing violations in the Bhubaneswar material were treated as universal moral obligations rather than mere conventions. The present theory classifies that studied Brahmanical milieu as predominantly first-order mechanical solidarity: numerous concrete rules and answers carried the shared moral force.

Scientific hygiene uses the same subject matter with a different architecture. Its fixed rule is roughly: identify a causal hazard using the best available evidence, test which intervention changes transmission or harm, apply the result to the present situation, and revise it when the evidence changes. The output is not fixed in advance. Current [WHO hand-hygiene guidance](#) recommends cleaning both hands with plain soap and water at specified moments and permits sufficiently concentrated alcohol rub under particular conditions. WHO treats [menstruation as a natural bodily process requiring health, water, sanitation, and freedom from stigma](#), and explains that [dead bodies after natural disasters generally do not cause epidemics](#), while identifying specific infectious-disease, water-contamination, and handler risks. The concrete precautions differ because the same evidence-generating rule is being applied to different causal conditions.

The contrast can therefore be stated without changing labels:

First-order bodily regulation shares the concrete answer: this contact, hand, substance, interval, or washing sequence is proper. Lifted scientific hygiene shares the generator: determine the actual hazard and let current evidence select the precaution.

Whole traditions as testable classifications The framework need not retreat from classifying an entire religion or communal tradition. It must, however, specify the historical and institutional object and say what would falsify the classification.

Scoped project hypothesis	Observable reason for the classification	What would weaken or reverse it
Orthodox Judaism is predominantly first-order mechanical solidarity.	Everyday religious formation shares a large corpus of concrete answers about Sabbath conduct, food, bodily states, time, and communal practice.	Evidence that ordinary solidarity primarily binds adherents to an answer-generating procedure whose concrete outputs are expected to change with new inputs.
Classical, fiqh-centred Islam is predominantly first-order mechanical solidarity.	Revealed and juristic prescriptions govern concrete acts such as ablution , fasting , food , and inheritance as religiously proper answers.	Evidence that the tradition’s ordinary shared binding force lies principally in a revisable generator rather than in those substantive answers.
The Brahmanical Hindu milieu studied in Bhubaneswar was predominantly first-order.	Food, bodily, clothing, sex-role, and status rules were treated as objective moral obligations.	Reanalysis showing that participants shared a rule-generating method while accepting materially different outputs as equally proper.
Old Order Amish Christianity is predominantly first-order.	The Young Center’s account of the <i>Ordnung</i> describes district-specific, often unwritten rules governing dress, technology, education, leisure, transport, and discipline, embodied through baptismal commitment and everyday practice.	Evidence that communal recognition normally attaches to a common generator rather than conformity to the district’s current concrete <i>Ordnung</i> .
Pauline Christianity contains a decisive lifted transition.	Romans 14 permits different answers about food and days while making faithfulness, conscience, peace, and the effect on the neighbour governing considerations; 1 Corinthians 8 similarly subjects liberty about food to its effect on another.	Evidence that the apparently generative considerations merely conceal one fixed set of concrete answers, or cannot authorize divergent outputs in practice.

Scoped project hypothesis	Observable reason for the classification	What would weaken or reverse it
Quaker Christianity is predominantly lifted in its collective decision architecture.	Quaker Faith & Practice makes disciplined discernment and the revisable “sense of the meeting,” recorded by the clerk amid differing convictions, the binding procedure rather than voting on a predetermined answer.	Evidence that the procedure cannot generate genuinely different answers or that conformity to a fixed substantive catalogue supplies the real communal bond.

These are classifications proposed by culture mechanics, not conclusions asserted by the cited traditions or already established by one observation. “Predominantly” allows mixed subsystems without making the hypothesis immune to failure. The Amish case is a useful hard test: an *Ordnung* can be updated as technologies and local issues arise without thereby becoming lifted. The decisive question is whether members are bound together chiefly by the updating generator or by the concrete *Ordnung* it currently produces.

Rabbinic Judaism supplies the inverse hard case. A religion classified as predominantly first-order can contain a lifted subsystem. The “oven of Akhnai” discussion in [Bava Metzia 59b](#) locates a legal decision in an authorized human process of textual argument and majority decision rather than in a heavenly intervention. That decision procedure can generate a concrete ruling not fixed by the immediate facts alone. Its presence does not automatically determine where the wider religion’s ordinary mechanical solidarity resides.

Further concrete lifted generators Lifted rules are not vague lists of admirable nouns. They are procedures that can be followed and can return a result:

Domain	Fixed generator	Changing first-order output
Political succession	The Catholic Church’s conclave constitution , as amended in 2013 , fixes electors, scrutiny, required majority, secrecy, and acceptance rules.	Which eligible person becomes pope cannot be listed in advance; the procedure generates the officeholder. Its procedural detail shows why “many rules” is evidence, not a definition, of first-order solidarity.
Contracts	German Civil Code §535 supplies the legal form of a tenancy and makes the parties’ agreement legally productive.	The premises, rent, duration, and resulting duties differ with the contract’s inputs while being recognized through the same legal generator.
Markets	The EUPHEMIA day-ahead market-coupling algorithm applies common optimization and constraint rules to submitted orders.	Market-clearing prices and allocations are generated anew for each bidding zone and delivery period.
Technical safety	NIST’s performance-based structural-fire work develops validated models, experiments, and performance criteria rather than prescribing one material and construction sequence for every building.	Different structures, materials, and protective designs can qualify when current evidence shows that they meet the shared performance requirement.

Domain	Fixed generator	Changing first-order output
Scientific knowledge	Inquiry binds participants to observation, reproducibility, causal comparison, criticism, and revision rather than to a protected conclusion.	Barry Marshall and Robin Warren's evidence for <i>Helicobacter pylori</i> changed the accepted account and treatment of gastritis and peptic ulcer, as summarized by the 2005 Nobel Prize press release . The changed answer is evidence that the corrective generator outranked the old answer.
Religious adjudication	Rabbinic textual argument and majority decision can operate as an authorized decision generator.	The ruling in a new dispute is an output of that procedure even within a wider religious order that may remain predominantly first-order.

Markets and contracts make the logic especially visible. The shared rule is not a single price or promise. It is the rule by which present bids generate a price or present consent generates an obligation. A first-order craft order, by contrast, can prescribe the proper material, tool, gesture, and sequence because fidelity to that concrete answer is itself the mark of good workmanship. A lifted performance order fixes how safety or quality must be demonstrated and permits the qualifying technology to change.

Boundary rules and falsifiers

1. **Detail is a strong indicator, not the essence.** Thirty-nine named categories, a district *Ordnung*, or an elaborate washing sequence strongly suggests first-order solidarity when the answers are followed as self-compulsorily proper. An elaborate election or market algorithm shows that a generator can also be detailed.
2. **Fewness is not the essence of lifting.** Generative compression is common because one rule can yield many outputs, but a short sacred command can remain first-order and a lifted constitution can fill volumes.
3. **Revision is not sufficient.** First-order rules can be extended, interpreted, or periodically updated. Ask whether the community treats the procedure or the resulting concrete rule as the primary shared obligation.
4. **Pluralism is not sufficient.** A lifted generator can produce plural outputs, but it can also generate one uniform answer. First-order plurality across subcultures does not itself create lifted solidarity.
5. **Corrigibility is independent.** A first-order order can respond to reality, and a lifted generator can be closed: “whatever the authorized body declares” is a second-order rule even when no evidence may correct it.
6. **The single slot remains single.** Meta-rules, current knowledge, and generated answers are layers of one weave. Lifting does not install a second evaluator above a first bigOther.

Teacher and classroom A teacher legitimately possesses coordination authority, normative authority over classroom procedure, and domain-specific epistemic authority. Agency is supported when the teacher shows methods, welcomes checks, admits mistakes, and trains pupils to reproduce the reasoning. Authority-gating occurs when “the teacher says so” replaces an available calculation and questioning is treated as misconduct.

Unknown institutional spokesperson Millions of citizens may trust a spokesperson whom none knows personally because the office, credential, channel, and institution authenticate the speech. This can be rational delegated knowledge. It becomes institution-gated when the same evidence is rejected without the institutional signature, when the institution’s claim cannot be independently defeated in principle, or when the spokesperson’s authority extends beyond the institution’s actual jurisdiction.

Political causal story A public condition is narrated as the product of a chosen culprit, a defined victim, and a remedy administered by the institution already seeking greater authority. The story may be correct, partly correct, or strategically distorted. Epistemic agency requires comparison with alternative causal models, omitted variables, base rates, predicted consequences, and the institution’s incentives—not automatic rejection merely because the story is political.

Counter-institutional capture A person recognizes genuine institutional failures and begins questioning official sources. They then adopt a counter-community whose master signifier—*Awakening* or *Hidden Truth*—classifies every institutional statement as deception and every counter-source as courageous. This is not yet cognitive liberty. The gate has changed direction, but source authorization still preempts symmetrical evaluation.

The failure is not that the source or community is rival. Rival institutions can provide necessary correction. The failure is that the successor gatekeepers become preemptive, classify their own authorization as sufficient, and disable symmetric evaluation and correction.

Repeater and crowd One prestigious speaker reaches a large audience because office, channel, and reputation amplify the signal. A crowd of individually weak transmitters can nevertheless produce equal or greater gain by repeating the phrase, displaying the same emotion, and making unanimity visible. The example distinguishes unequal node gain from aggregate field amplification.

Cultural domain boundary Crossing from one region into another may reveal a sharp change in house forms, flower decoration, street care, or customs such as *Kehrwoche*. The magnetization analogy treats the boundary as a possible cultural domain wall maintained by dense local reinforcement. The visible contrast is an observation to be explained, not proof that all residents are synchronized or that geography caused the pattern.

Broadcast authority topology The *Volksempfänger* placed a distant authorized voice into many homes while listeners could understand themselves as members of one simultaneous audience. The culture-mechanical point is the replicated teacher-before-class geometry: common attention, common reception, authority, and narrative could converge. The historical example does not imply that the message succeeded uniformly.

Collective ownership Two assigned collaborators may coordinate without ever experiencing the task as *ours*. By contrast, a *Bahner* who protects the railway beyond the measured private task, a resident who treats common space as belonging to the civic *we*, or a Subak participant who maintains a continuing irrigation-ritual order illustrates the stronger unitary-owner hypothesis. Each remains a candidate explanation requiring comparison with incentives, habit, surveillance, and personal virtue.

26. Cross-references and branching concepts

Related term	Short semantic definition	Relation to epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity
Culture mechanics	Proposed framework beginning with homo duplex, the local bigOther, its mythological lens, and its coupling interface.	Supplies the individual source architecture from which the field account begins.
Lacan’s big Other / shared symbolic protocol	The locus of language, law, and symbolic authority; functionally translated here as the on-the-wire protocol among local bigOthers.	Makes local classifications publicly intelligible without perfectly copying private states.
Epistemic dependence	Necessary reliance on other knowers and institutions.	The unavoidable starting condition, not itself a defect.
Personal epistemic authority	A trusted person’s considered judgment functioning as evidence.	Healthy when competence is domain-limited and trust remains defeasible; preemptive when the person becomes a permissioning layer.
Epistemic vigilance	Monitoring communicated information for competence, honesty, coherence, and evidence.	Helps calibrate dependence without collapsing into gullibility or indiscriminate distrust.
Epistemic credulity	Insufficiently discriminating acceptance of communicated claims.	One possible disposition or failure mode; ordinary authority-gating is often selective rather than generalized.

Related term	Short semantic definition	Relation to epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity
Epistemic trust anchor	A person or institution whose authorization gives claims presumptive credibility.	Can provide rational delegation or become a preemptive reality-validation node.
Epistemic gatekeeper	A node that filters what a person admits as knowledge.	Names the personal, institutional, distributed, or symbolic routing structure.
Preemptive gatekeeper deference	Treating the gatekeeper's judgment as replacing rather than supplementing accessible evidence.	Marks the pathological transition from reliance to preemption.
Authority-gated belief updating	Updating primarily according to recognized authorization.	The central failure mechanism.
Asymmetric epistemic permeability	Unequal openness to evidence depending on its authorized route.	Explains how easy persuasion and difficult correction can coexist.
Role-conferred epistemic authority spillover	Transfer of authority from coordination, morality, care, or one knowledge domain into another.	Explains how formal offices acquire epistemic force they have not independently earned.
Pastoral epistemic authority	Epistemic trust grounded in guidance, care, protection, or personal interpretation.	Can support judgment or make surrender feel like safety.
Socialization into institutional trust	Learning which offices, credentials, institutions, and channels may certify reliable knowledge.	Installs the background trust architecture through which later claims are evaluated.
Lifted mechanical solidarity	Shared binding rules generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers.	Explains how one full capture can produce changing outputs and can, as one application, constitute differentiated citizens, institutions, and jurisdictions.
Organic solidarity	Cohesion through specialization and interdependence.	Produces differentiated professions and institutions whose legitimacy may be supplied by lifted mechanical solidarity.
bigOther	Culture-mechanical sentiment classifier linking symbolic order to felt legitimacy, shame, loyalty, and belonging.	Supplies the local source and receiver through which field authority becomes affectively operative.
Mechanical-solidarity field	Emergent coherence among compatible local bigOthers that acts back through expectations, sanctions, institutions, and apparent consensus.	Names the group effect within which epistemic agency is exercised.
Distributed bigOther	Dynamically maintained symbolic-affective network state reproduced by local bigOthers, institutions, roles, practices, and artifacts.	Turns individual signals and enforcement into a self-reinforcing social field with memory.
bigOther-presence / bigOther-as-Thou	Project-developed terms for the field or symbolic authority locally encountered as an objectively present Other.	Names one phenomenological form of field back-action without identifying the experience with its whole mechanism.
Multi-mind-self	Distributed bigOther integrated enough to perceive, remember, judge, intend, own, and act with collective continuity.	Names a possible collective agent, not every crowd or mechanically solidary field.

Related term	Short semantic definition	Relation to epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity
Unitary ownership by the multi-mind-self	One collective agent owns and cares through many <i>beseelte</i> persons.	Reinterprets successful “shared ownership” as collective-person ownership rather than fractional private psychology.
Privileged authority-addressed programming topology	A differentiated authority position addresses a comparatively uniform audience under common attention.	Proposed recurrent geometry that can heighten reception and synchronization without defining mechanical solidarity.
Repeater	A local bigOther with greater gain, reach, credibility, frequency, connectivity, or institutional amplification.	Explains unequal influence while preserving the claim that every local bigOther transmits.
Master signifier / S1	Privileged signifier organizing identities and bodies of knowledge; translated here as a compressed protocol token.	Can select and activate the common interpretive mode; becomes pathological when it terminates inquiry.
Laser synchronization	Metaphor for dynamic alignment of attention, affect, interpretation, and action.	Describes how many local classifiers enter a coherent common mode.
Ideological power	Michael Mann’s category, adapted by Rainer Mausfeld for power over sense-making categories, interpretive contexts, and framing narratives.	Names a possible macro-level means of programming the interpretive and trust environment; this entry focuses more broadly on the subject-side mechanisms and their corrigibility.
Causal story	Narrative assigning cause, responsibility, victim, fixer, and remedy.	Political-scale mechanism for organizing the distributed bigOther and forming agendas.
Persuasion	Process of changing belief, evaluation, identity, or action.	Can restore or suppress agency depending on epistemic direction, reciprocity, and correction.
Socratic manipulation	Questions that simulate open inquiry while steering toward a preselected conclusion.	Shows why an autonomy-flavoured method is not automatically truth-directed.
Contaminated mindware	Learned rules or beliefs that impair rationality and may disable their own evaluation.	Supplies content and anti-correction rules that authority and identity can protect.
Motivated reasoning	Directional use of reasoning toward a preferred conclusion.	Often occurs downstream of identity, sentiment, or authority-gated classification.
Bonhoefferian Dummheit	Socially induced loss of inner independence despite intact intelligence.	Describes the person-level result of power-saturated, slogan-mediated capture of judgment.
Normopathic adaptation	Adaptation to a pathological social normality until it no longer appears pathological.	Describes the population-side reproduction of a captured epistemic order.
Need for closure	Preference for definite resolution and aversion to ambiguity.	Can accelerate attachment to an S1 or authority that fills uncertainty.
Epistemic adulthood	Capacity to inspect and revise inherited standards and trust architecture within a fully installed lifted program.	Names the developmental achievement; it is reflective agency within full capture, not escape from programming.
Cognitive liberty	Reflective distance from socialization combined with continued capacity for trust and participation.	Names positive freedom under a universal, corrigible meta-order with bounded subordinate authorities.

Related term	Short semantic definition	Relation to epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity
Epistemic emancipation	Lifting from full capture by shared concrete answers to full capture by a reality-answerable generator of answers.	Names the practical unbraid/rebraid problem through which inherited answers lose finality without necessarily disappearing.
MCIP	Mirror, Cut, Invite, Promise.	Proposed micro-method for restoring agency while keeping the successor weave and its interpreters corrigible.
Piety toward the real	Humble willingness to let complex reality correct concepts, stories, institutions, and conviction.	Supplies the normative standard and final right of refusal.
Holistic structural realism	Model-centered epistemology in which concepts and operations are tested through prediction, surprise, and revision.	Supplies the positive reality-correction loop used by this entry.
Moral individualism	Shared commitment to the equal dignity and rights of persons.	Prevents factual correction and respect for social reality from becoming contempt for persons or worship of institutions.
Nächstenliebe	Love of neighbour directed toward the concrete person's reality-based good.	Requires concern and sometimes intervention while forbidding instrumental dehumanization.

27. Scope and terminological cautions

Epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity is a proposed synthetic term, not the established name of a single scientific theory or diagnostic category. It connects questions from social epistemology, Durkheimian sociology, Lacanian psychoanalysis, developmental theory, political psychology, narrative theory, persuasion research, and the proposed framework of culture mechanics.

Several boundaries are essential:

1. **It is not an anti-institutional doctrine.** Institutions are indispensable instruments of distributed knowledge. The problem is opacity, monopoly, domain spillover, preemption, and resistance to correction—not institutional form itself.
2. **It does not idealize personal verification.** Direct checking is decisive only where it is competent and proportionate. Elementary arithmetic cannot replace specialized medicine, engineering, history, or science; it can sometimes expose a particular claim within them.
3. **It does not equate disagreement with independence.** Automatic contrarianism and submission to an uncorrectable or preemptive gatekeeper are not cognitive liberty; the mere fact that a source rivals an incumbent does not decide the question.
4. **It is not a theory of intelligence.** High intelligence can coexist with authority-gated updating; modest intelligence can coexist with strong epistemic integrity.
5. **It is not a clinical diagnosis.** Credulity, Dummheit, normopathic adaptation, and capture are used as conceptual cross-references, not licenses to pathologize political or religious opponents.
6. **Mechanical solidarity is not necessarily hierarchical or unhealthy.** The large-group/small-elevated-group pattern is one important architecture, not the essence of the Durkheimian concept.
7. **A master signifier is not identical with mechanical solidarity.** It is one symbolic operator that may help organize solidarity.
8. **A causal story is not necessarily a lie.** Narrative selection is unavoidable; the test is comparative explanatory and predictive adequacy, openness about uncertainty, and responsiveness to consequences.
9. **Persuasion method does not determine truth.** Gentle inquiry can mislead, and forceful intervention can sometimes protect life. Epistemic direction, love of neighbour, proportionality, consequences, and corrigibility must be considered together.
10. **Piety toward the real is not submission to whoever speaks for “reality.”** It requires the opposite: no authority's certification can remove the possibility of external correction.
11. **Cognitive liberty is not epistemic autarky.** Its mature form is conscious interdependence, not isolation.

12. **"Freeing" is not self-authenticating.** A liberation campaign can install closed or uncorrectable successor culture mechanics. The liberator must expose their own model to the same tests demanded of the other person; replacement or rivalry alone is not the failure criterion.
13. **The field is neither isolated individual psychology nor a new physical force.** Culture mechanics treats relational organization as causally real and irreducible to independently formed individuals, while locating its implementation in persons, communication, institutions, practices, and artifacts. Field physics remains an analogy.
14. **The privileged programming topology is not universal or inherently manipulative.** Horizontal and leaderless synchronization also occur. A teacher can use the topology for truthful education, and an audience can resist it.
15. **A distributed bigOther is not automatically a multi-mind-self.** The latter requires sufficient continuity, memory, judgment, intention, and coordinated action; a momentary crowd may remain below that threshold.
16. **Unitary collective ownership is not legal title.** It is a proposed psychological-social relation and must be compared with incentives, habit, surveillance, personal virtue, and ordinary organizational coordination.
17. **Collective agency does not erase personal responsibility.** *Beseelte* persons remain biological, moral, and legal actors even when they enact a continuing collective perspective.
18. **bigOther-presence does not settle metaphysics.** The theory proposes one functional route by which an authority becomes present and conduct-directing; it neither proves nor disproves additional religious or metaphysical claims.
19. **Plural authorities are not parallel local bigOthers.** The main processor may compare alternatives and external counterfields may support reflection, but one local bigOther executes one operative lens. Compatible packages can be integrated; incompatible capture requires unbraiding and rebraiding rather than runtime ranking.
20. **Full, lifted, universal, and corrigible are different properties.** Full describes complete slot occupancy; lifted means that shared binding force lies in rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers; universal describes how far those rules govern; and corrigible describes openness to inspection, succession, and reality's right of refusal. Particular authorities can be plural and domain-limited beneath a universal lifted order.

The framework is descriptive before it is accusatory. Shared trust, narratives, symbols, and institutions can coordinate real knowledge and protect human dignity. The normative threshold is crossed when the system disables the very procedures by which its claims, classifications, and authorities could be corrected.

Semantic summary

- **Broader class:** social and developmental theory of situated epistemic agency.
- **Central object:** the person's relation to a socially installed architecture of epistemic trust.
- **Individual source and receiver:** the local bigOther within homo duplex.
- **Shared communication interface:** Lacan's big Other, functionally translated as the on-the-wire symbolic protocol.
- **Starting condition:** unavoidable epistemic dependence.
- **Social environment:** a mechanical-solidarity field, often combined with organic differentiation.
- **Order-level distinction:** first-order solidarity shares concrete rules and answers; lifted solidarity shares the rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers.
- **Generative compression:** fixed installed meta-rules can combine with changing knowledge and situations to produce many changing concrete outputs; neither fewness nor detail alone defines the order level.
- **Modern structural possibility:** lifted mechanical solidarity can span an organically differentiated and plural society, but plurality and division of labour are consequences or applications rather than the definition of lifting.
- **Complete slot occupancy / full capture:** first-order and lifted programs can each fully occupy the one local bigOther; fullness is not itself pathology.
- **Lifted jurisdiction:** an answer-generating meta-order may govern universally while allocating and limiting plural first-order outputs, authorities, and jurisdictions.
- **Corrigibility axis:** first-order and lifted full captures can each remain open or become closed; rivalry and replacement alone do not decide which.
- **Transmission process:** socialization into institutional trust.
- **Authority nodes:** persons, roles, institutions, professions, identities, channels, and apparent consensus.
- **Unequal-gain node:** repeater.
- **Privileged but non-universal geometry:** differentiated authority addressing a comparatively uniform audience.
- **Proposed receptive condition:** the authority-addressed programming state.
- **Symbolic operator:** master signifier or S1 as compressed protocol token.

- **Narrative mechanism:** mythology or causal story.
- **Single-slot capture constraint:** compatible material may reinforce or extend the installed weave; incompatible governing capture requires incumbent unbraiding and successor rebraiding.
- **Dynamic process:** synchronization and field back-action among local bigOthers.
- **Emergent network state:** the distributed bigOther.
- **Possible collective agent:** the multi-mind-self.
- **Collective-property hypothesis:** unitary ownership by the multi-mind-self through many *beseelte* persons.
- **Central pathological mechanism:** authority-gated belief updating.
- **Characteristic observable pattern:** asymmetric epistemic permeability.
- **Pastoral subtype:** care-grounded surrender of epistemic judgment.
- **Individual susceptibility factors:** identity dependence, need for closure, authoritarian submission, low vigilance, and fear of exclusion.
- **Population-level outcomes:** distributed enforcement, Dummheit, and normopathic adaptation.
- **Healthy configuration:** a universal corrigible meta-order with calibrated, plural, domain-limited dependence upon particular authorities.
- **Developmental achievement:** epistemic adulthood.
- **Normative freedom:** cognitive liberty.
- **Normative orientation:** piety toward the real.
- **Moral orientation:** truth joined with Nächstenliebe and epistemic humility.
- **Liberation process:** epistemic emancipation.
- **Proposed conversational intervention:** MCIP—Mirror, Cut, Invite, Promise.
- **Central normative question:** Does authority provide a corrigible route to reality, or does its certification replace reality-testing?

Example of use

From the perspective of **epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity**, the citizens' reliance on the institution was not irrational merely because it was socially learned. The decisive problem was that institutional authorization had become preemptive: identical evidence was rejected outside the approved channel, elementary checks were treated as disloyal, and the institution claimed authority to define its own failures. Restoring agency therefore required more than transmitting contrary facts. It required making the inherited trust architecture visible, preserving social permission to doubt, and reopening a route through which reality could correct both citizen and institution.

Compact formulas

Healthy form:

socialization → institutional trust → delegated expertise → exposed evidence and method → prediction and correction → calibrated reliance

Field form:

local bigOthers → shared symbolic protocol → reciprocal classification and response → mechanical-solidarity coherence → distributed bigOther → field back-action upon local judgment

Programming-topology form:

differentiated authority + comparatively uniform audience + common attention and reception → heightened receptivity → activation, reinforcement, or reprogramming → stronger field coherence

Incompatible-capture form:

incompatible governing offer → incumbent bindings loosened and unbraided → liminal instability or dependency → retained and new strands rebraided → one successor lens installed → field reinforcement and defensive reasoning

Order-level and lifted-jurisdiction form:

fixed M + current K_t + situation C → binding R_t(C); a universally governing M may constitute, allocate, limit, coordinate, succeed, and correct plural first-order outputs and jurisdictions

Collective-owner form:

distributed bigOther + continuity + group judgment and intention → multi-mind-self → one collective owner acting through many *beseelte* persons

Pathological form:

socialization → master signifier and trust anchor → field-amplified authorization → authority-gated updating → asymmetric permeability → defensive rationalization and collective enforcement

Developmental form:

socially authored trust → reflective distance → self-authored trust → self-transforming trust → cognitive liberty

Normative form:

Respect persons unconditionally; evaluate propositions conditionally by evidence; regulate action through justice; preserve reality's right to correct every model and authority.

Liberation form:

full capture by shared concrete answers → unbraid their claim to finality → rebraid a shared reality-answerable generator → full lifted capture; Mirror the person → Cut the protected false connection → Invite independent judgment → Promise support for living with the result

Terminological provenance and primary sources

The vocabulary above does not come from one theory. The following map distinguishes established concepts from adaptations and new syntheses. Links point to the relevant publications rather than to conversations about them.

Established terms used substantially in their source sense

- **Mechanical and organic solidarity** — Émile Durkheim. *De la division du travail social* (1893) is the defining source. Durkheim's concepts are retained; *lifted mechanical solidarity* is the extension made by this entry.
- **Epistemic dependence** — John Hardwig. "Epistemic Dependence," *The Journal of Philosophy* 82(7), 1985, pp. 335–349 (DOI) is the direct source for unavoidable rational dependence on other knowers.
- **Cognitive authority** — Patrick Wilson. *Second-Hand Knowledge: An Inquiry into Cognitive Authority* (1983) analyzes why people recognize some others as proper influences on what they think.
- **Epistemic authority and preemption** — Linda Trinkaus Zagzebski. *Epistemic Authority: A Theory of Trust, Authority, and Autonomy in Belief* (2012) is the principal source. Christoph Jäger's 2016 critique is especially relevant to the danger that authority displace understanding.
- **Choosing among experts** — Alvin I. Goldman. "Experts: Which Ones Should You Trust?" (2001) (DOI) grounds several audit criteria used here: arguments, agreement among experts, interests and biases, and track records.
- **Epistemic vigilance** — Dan Sperber, Fabrice Clément, Christophe Heintz, Olivier Mascaro, Hugo Mercier, Gloria Origg, and Deirdre Wilson. "Epistemic Vigilance" (2010) is the defining paper for vigilance toward communicated information.
- **Epistemic trust, mistrust, and credulity** — Chloe Campbell, Michal Tanzer, Rob Saunders, Thomas Booker, Elizabeth Allison, Elizabeth Li, Claire O'Dowda, Patrick Luyten, and Peter Fonagy. "Development and Validation of a Self-Report Measure of Epistemic Trust" (2021) defines and operationalizes this three-part construct. Its *credulity* scale is narrower than the broad nonclinical usage in this entry.
- **Pastoral power** — Michel Foucault. "The Subject and Power" (1982) is a concise primary source for the individualized, totalizing form of guidance from which *pastoral epistemic authority* is adapted.
- **Master signifier, S1/S2, and the master's discourse** — Jacques Lacan. *Le Séminaire, Livre XVII: L'envers de la psychanalyse* (1969–1970) is the central source for the four discourses. *Seminar XX: Encore* contains Lacan's characterization of the signifier as "stupid."
- **Causal stories** — Deborah A. Stone. "Causal Stories and the Formation of Policy Agendas," *Political Science Quarterly* 104(2), 1989, pp. 281–300 (DOI) is the defining paper.
- **Motivated reasoning** — Ziva Kunda. "The Case for Motivated Reasoning" (1990) is the canonical review.
- **Need for cognitive closure** — Donna M. Webster and Arie W. Kruglanski. "Individual Differences in Need for Cognitive Closure" (1994) defines and measures the construct.
- **Dysrationalia and contaminated mindware** — Keith E. Stanovich. "Dysrationalia: A New Specific Learning Disability" (1993) introduces *dysrationalia*; "Contaminated Mindware" (2009) develops the latter concept.

Borrowed concepts whose meaning is deliberately extended here

Term in this entry	Source and responsible thinker	Difference in the present usage
Lifted mechanical solidarity	Durkheim's mechanical solidarity	A project-developed order-level distinction: common binding force is moved from concrete rules and answers to rules that generate, select, apply, and revise them. Modern plural integration is one important consequence, not the definition. <i>Lifted</i> is not Durkheim's term.
Socialization into institutional trust	Wilson on cognitive authority; Niklas Luhmann on trust ; Anthony Giddens on expert and abstract systems	Synthesizes these antecedents with Durkheimian solidarity into a specific many-to-few socialization mechanism; none of the three authors uses the complete model stated here.
Preemptive gatekeeper deference	Zagzebski's Preemption Thesis	Restricts and radicalizes preemption into a pathological permissioning relation in which contrary evidence cannot be admitted without authorization.
Pastoral epistemic authority	Foucault's pastoral power	Isolates the epistemic effect of care-grounded guidance; it is narrower than Foucault's historical account of pastoral power.
Lacan's big Other as shared symbolic protocol	Lacan's locus of language, law, and symbolic authority	"On-the-wire protocol" is a culture-mechanical functional translation of one aspect, not Lacan's definition or a complete exegesis.
bigOther, local bigOther, distributed bigOther	Lacan's big Other	Recasts symbolic authority as a local affective classifier and an emergent network state. These are culture-mechanical adaptations, not Lacan's definitions.
bigOther-presence and bigOther-as-Thou	William James on felt objective presence ; Martin Buber's <i>I and Thou</i>	Borrows phenomenological and relational cues for how field authority may be locally encountered. Neither author proposed the local processor or distributed-field mechanism.
Mechanical-solidarity field	Durkheim's mechanical solidarity and collective consciousness	Treats solidarity as emergent symbolic-affective coherence with back-action upon local judgment. The field ontology and physical analogies are proposed here.
Laser synchronization	Analogy with physical lasers	A heuristic metaphor for social coupling and coherent collective output, not a claim that Durkheim or Lacan proposed a laser model or that social alignment obeys laser physics.

Term in this entry	Source and responsible thinker	Difference in the present usage
Magnetization, domains, domain walls, charged particles, photons, and repeaters	Analogies with physics and network engineering	Project-developed models for alignment, boundaries, source/back-action, relative carrier-independence, and unequal gain. They do not assert physical identity.
Multi-mind-self and unitary collective ownership	Otto von Guericke on the real unity of associations ; F. W. Maitland on moral and legal personality ; Christian List and Philip Pettit on group agency	Extends group-person and group-agency neighbors with local bigOthers, mechanical-solidarity field formation, <i>Beseelung</i> , and the claim that one collective self owns through many persons. None of the cited authors proposed that synthesis.
Privileged authority-addressed programming topology and programming state	Freud on group psychology; Green and Brock on transportation; Horton and Wohl on parasocial interaction; Chwe on common knowledge; Bourdieu on authorized speech; Collins on interaction rituals	Synthesizes several mechanisms into a new, testable geometry. No source establishes the complete compound state.
Bonhoefferian Dummheit	Dietrich Bonhoeffer, “Von der Dummheit” (1943; PDF of the complete section) (HTML transcription)	Names a family resemblance between socially induced loss of independence and the present capture model. It is not an IQ measure, diagnosis, or complete restatement of Bonhoeffer.
Normopathic adaptation	Erich Wulff, <i>Psychiatrie und Klassengesellschaft</i> (1972) ; Joyce McDougall’s psychoanalytic normopathy; Hans-Joachim Maaz, <i>Das falsche Leben</i> (2017)	Uses the family of terms descriptively for adaptation to a pathological social normality without adopting any one author’s clinical or political theory. The term has more than one intellectual genealogy, so a single uncontested origin should not be asserted.
Piety toward the real	Robert N. Bellah’s introduction to Émile Durkheim on Morality and Society (1973)	Bellah’s phrase characterizes Durkheim; this entry turns it into an explicit norm of epistemic model correction. It is not Durkheim’s own technical term.
Moral individualism	Durkheim, “L’individualisme et les intellectuels” (1898)	Durkheim’s moral defense of the sacred individual is retained, then joined here to the distinction between unconditional respect for persons and conditional evaluation of propositions.
Cognitive liberty	Richard Glen Boire, “On Cognitive Liberty” ; Jan Christoph Bubnitz, “My Mind Is Mine!?” (2013)	Extends freedom from mental interference into a positive developmental capacity to inspect and revise one’s socialized trust architecture. That extension is not standard in the legal literature.
Epistemic adulthood	Robert Kegan’s constructive-developmental theory	Applies Kegan’s subject-object and self-authorship pattern specifically to epistemic trust. The term and trust stages are new here.

Term in this entry	Source and responsible thinker	Difference in the present usage
Nächstenliebe / love of neighbour	Jewish and Christian ethical tradition, classically Leviticus 19:18	Applied here to truth-directed care and intervention. The reality-corrigibility rule paired with it is this entry's ethical synthesis, not a definition contained in the scriptural phrase alone.

Newly proposed terms in this synthesis

The following expressions should not be attributed to Hardwig, Durkheim, Lacan, Foucault, Bellah, Kegan, McRaney, Stone, or any other cited author unless a later source establishes otherwise:

- **epistemic agency under mechanical solidarity;**
- **authority-gated belief updating** and **institution-gated belief updating;**
- **asymmetric epistemic permeability;**
- **epistemic trust anchor, institutional epistemic proxy, and reality-validation node;**
- **role-conferred epistemic authority spillover;**
- **culture mechanics** in the specific sense used here;
- **lifted mechanical solidarity;**
- **first-order full capture, lifted full capture,** the distinction between shared answers and a shared answer generator, and **universal jurisdiction over the allocation and limitation of first-order outputs and jurisdictions;**
- **mechanical-solidarity field** and **field back-action** in the specific sense used here;
- **on-the-wire symbolic protocol** as the culture-mechanical translation of Lacan's big Other;
- **bigOther-presence** and **bigOther-as-Thou;**
- **repeater** as an unequal-gain local bigOther;
- **privileged authority-addressed programming topology** and the proposed **programming state;**
- **multi-mind-self, unitary ownership by the multi-mind-self, and Beseelung / beseelt** in their present technical senses;
- **epistemic adulthood, epistemic emancipation,** and the three trust-development stages;
- **state transmission, operation transmission, and Socratic manipulation** as defined here;
- **MCIP—Mirror, Cut, Invite, Promise.**

Field, programming-topology, and collective-agent source lineage

- **Émile Durkheim** supplies mechanical solidarity, collective consciousness, and the non-individualist starting point. [The Division of Labour in Society](#) does not contain the field-physics or local-processor analogies.
- **Robert N. Bellah's** introduction to [Émile Durkheim on Morality and Society](#) supports reading Durkheim as a theorist of collective psychology and supplies *piety toward the real*. Bellah does not propose the multi-mind implementation.
- **William James** and **Martin Buber** supply partial phenomenological neighbors for felt presence and second-person encounter. The project-developed terms and causal synthesis remain separate from their accounts.
- **Otto von Guericke, F. W. Maitland, Christian List, and Philip Pettit** supply increasingly explicit accounts of real group personality, moral/legal personality, and organizational group agency. Their work helps specify the threshold question while leaving the culture-mechanical implementation new.
- **Sigmund Freud, Melanie Green and Timothy Brock, Donald Horton and R. Richard Wohl, Michael Suk-Young Chwe, Pierre Bourdieu, and Randall Collins** each establish or theorize one component adjacent to the proposed programming state. Their works are linked in Section 12; none should be cited as establishing the whole authority-addressed topology.
- The **Volksempfänger** example is documented by the [Science Museum Group's collection record](#). Its use as a technological replication of the classroom geometry is the present framework's interpretation.

Persuasion and MCIP: sources and method lineage

- **David McRaney, [How Minds Change \(2022\)](#),** is a journalistic synthesis of research and practice concerning belief change. It motivates parts of the persuasion discussion, but *state transmission, operation transmission,* and MCIP are not McRaney's terminology.

- **Joshua Kalla and David Broockman**, “[Reducing Exclusionary Attitudes through Interpersonal Conversation: Evidence from Three Field Experiments](#)” (2020), provide empirical evidence concerning deep canvassing and non-judgmental narrative exchange. Their intervention is not MCIP and does not show that a conversational method guarantees truth.
- **Carl R. Rogers and Richard E. Farson**, “[Active Listening](#)” (1957), are an antecedent for *Mirror*.
- **William R. Miller and Stephen Rollnick**, [Motivational Interviewing: Helping People Change](#) (third-edition chapter, 2013), are antecedents for reflective listening, eliciting the person’s own reasons, and preserving authorship.
- **J. L. Austin**, [How to Do Things with Words](#) (1962), supplies the speech-act background for treating a promise as an act that creates a practical and relational commitment.
- **Jacques Lacan’s** use of the *cut* supplies a loose psychoanalytic analogy for interrupting an established sequence. MCIP’s *Cut* is operationally defined by this entry and should not be presented as Lacanian technique without further argument.

Independent reality-orientation source

- [Holistic Epistemology and Metaphysics: Structural Realism](#) supplies the model-centered loop of concepts, operations, prediction, surprise, and revision used in the positive account of reality correction.